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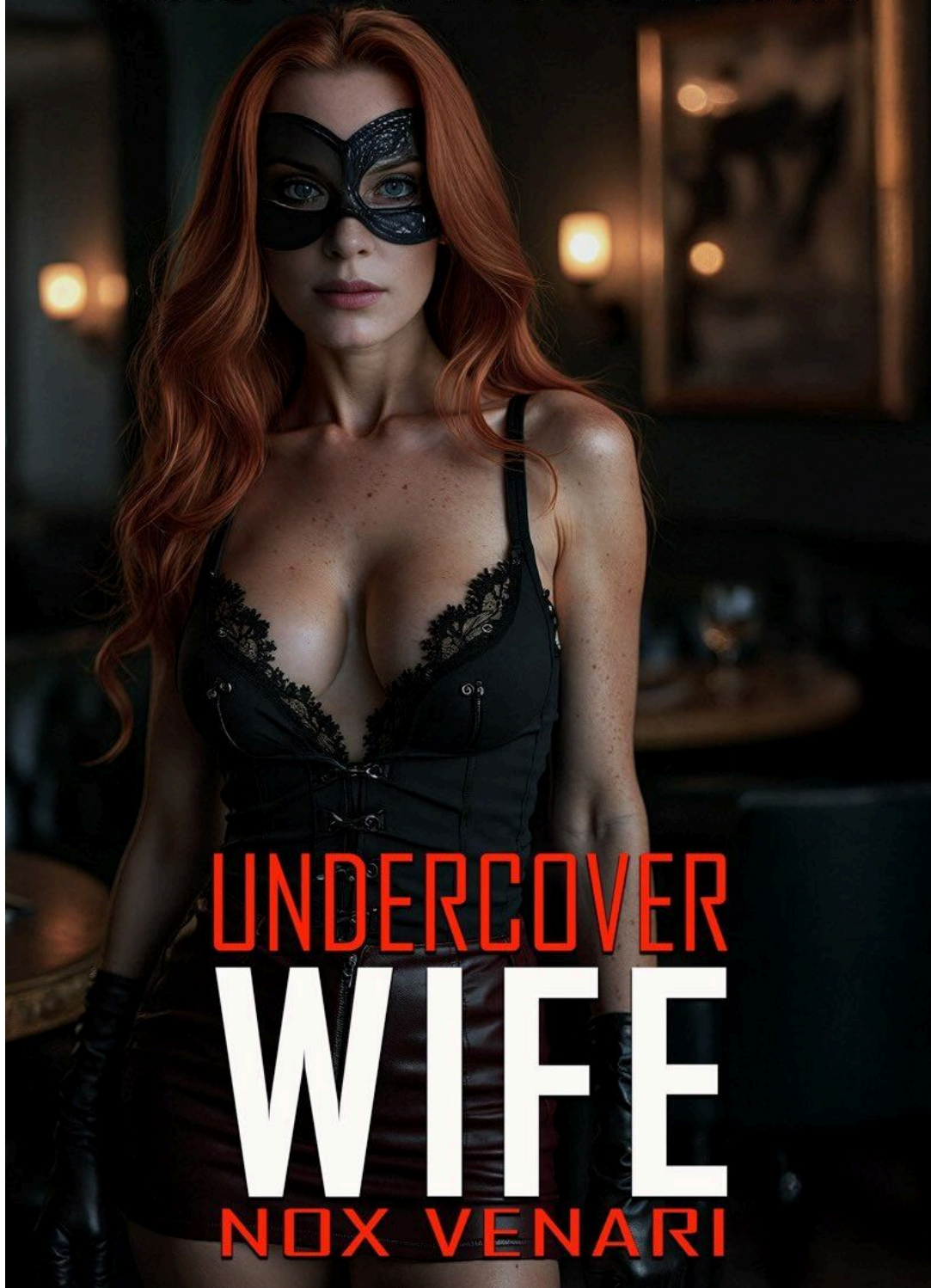
BESTSELLING AUTHOR  
**KIRSTEN MCCURRAN**



**UNDERCOVER**  
**WIFE**  
**NOX VENARI**

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undercover wife: nox venari

kirsten mccurran



## **UNDERCOVER WIFE: NOX VENARI**

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## previously

Former CIA field officer Madison Sinclair has been working a desk in Langley for the past sixteen years. She left the danger and excitement of covert missions behind when she met the love of her life, Charles Sinclair, and chose starting a family over the thrill of using her mind and body in the field. Madison has settled into a comfortable suburban life in McLean, VA—two kids, soccer games and school plays, a nice house, and membership in the local clubs. Madison doesn't miss the old life because she chooses not to think about it.

All of that changes when Madison is called to Deputy Director Jennifer Bristow's office. A dangerous new cyberthreat to the United States, Null:Echo, has arisen, and her nation needs Madison's help to stop it.

The quantum cipher key can hack any system in seconds, completely undetected. And the Russian hacker group that built it, Glacier Flame, is about to sell Null:Echo to the highest bidder, which will undoubtedly be the Middle Eastern nation of Kharabat, a major state sponsor of terror groups around the world.

The CIA needs someone to get close to Prince Zaydan bin Zaman Al-Kharabati and stop the deal. Madison is uniquely qualified. The young prince has particular tastes in women—older, married women who are ripe for seduction, and Madison fits the bill. After sixteen years on a desk at Langley, she knows she's unprepared for such a dangerous and unpredictable mission, but Bristow makes it clear there is no other choice.

Madison meets the team for what has been dubbed Operation Scarlet Phantom: Cassandra Gale, the ambitious young officer acting as handler for the mission, Tayshawn "Tay" Dentinger, a brutal and resourceful field officer with an axe to grind against Madison, Manny Sanz, one of the



Wizards from the CIA's technical division, and the man who will be acting as Madison's husband while undercover, Damien Kane.

Madison hasn't seen Kane in sixteen years, not since their last mission together, which left them both shot and clinging to life. But Madison and Kane were more than partners, and when she chose Charles, it meant not choosing Kane. As if their steamer trunk full of baggage wasn't an issue that could derail the mission, Madison needs to walk the line between building believable chemistry with Kane and doing something that will betray her marriage.

Kane and Madison become David and Michelle Richardson and gain membership to Nox Venari, the exclusive, international sex club for the world's famous and elite, which is also the scheduled location for the Null:Echo deal. Madison needs to unearth the seductive vixen that she buried beneath the suburban mom so she can wrap Prince Zaydan around her finger and obtain Null:Echo for the good guys.

**[These events all take place in Undercover Wife: Null:Echo, now available in ebook and paperback wherever books are sold.](#)**

# one

**2009**

**London**

Kane stood on the balcony of the CIA safe house, looking out on a busy London morning. He held onto the railing to steady himself, but told himself he didn't really need it. The noise of the hustle and bustle drifted up to him: men and women rushing to work, those red, double-decker buses passing by. He wasn't in a hurry to get anywhere, but then, he'd only been on his feet for about forty-eight hours.

The recovery from Russia had been one of the rougher ones. By the time Madison finally out of the country and access to medical attention, he'd lost a dangerous amount of blood. She wasn't much better off, but she somehow soldiered through. She always did. Her gunshot wound had been patched up, and she'd been right back on her feet, handling all of the mission debriefs while Kane lay in the medical suite recovering from being stitched back together—again. If he had any sense of self-preservation, he knew he needed to find another line of work, but the Agency was his life. The Agency and Madison.

The mission had been a success. The Turks didn't get the Russian targeting system, and they'd taken out Anatoly Reznikov, a genuinely bad guy. The world wouldn't miss him. Ordinarily, killing a high-ranking FSB officer on Russian soil would be a huge problem, but Reznikov was so dirty, the Russians couldn't make too much noise. But the desk jockeys in Langley were not happy that Madison had killed General Kemal Arslan. That had not been part of the plan.

All of that was above Kane's pay grade, but he knew they were raking Madison over the coals. The Turks were very upset, raising formal protests over the death of one of their most decorated generals. The Russians had told them that the CIA killed Arslan in his hotel suite in Moscow.

As the CIA was denying any involvement, they could hardly point out that Arslan was killed in the study of an FSB official's dacha. In the meantime, they made Madison go over it again and again, trying to find a hole in her story, a reason why there was no other option than to kill the Turkish general. Kane hadn't been there, but he knew that Madison had a good reason for taking the Turk out. She handled it better than he would have. He'd have told them all to fuck off.

Kane heard the door and winced when he turned to go back inside. He hoped he hid the wince, but knew Madison would see through it. She carried a tray with two cups and a bag of pastries. She'd gone out to fetch the only coffee he found drinkable in London. He cursed the limeys and their obsession with tea.

"We got lucky. These are the last of the cranberry scones they had," she called out, leaving everything on the dining room table with her purse and keys. She hurried across the room to help Kane back inside.

"I'm good," he said, trying to wave off her assistance.

"What are you doing up like this? Are you determined to reopen your wounds?" She took his weight and helped him onto the couch.

The CIA safe house was large for a London flat in that fashionable part of town, but the furniture was functional at best. He groaned as he settled on the unyielding couch. Kane's eyes said thank you even if the rest of him resented that he needed her help. She'd dragged his bleeding ass halfway across Europe. She'd done enough.

"I can't lie around forever. I've got to get moving. Even Doc Zimmerman says so."

“With help. You know your balance is shit. Are you still seeing double?”  
Madison bought him the coffee and scones.

“The concussion is fine. It’s gone. I’ll be back out there in no time.”

Her skeptical look said it all. Annoyed, Kane snatched her wrist and twisted. She yelped and tried to pull away, but she’d been caught off balance. The bullet wound in his thigh screamed when she dropped into his lap, but he gritted his teeth and took it. Madison tried to struggle away, but he locked his arms around her.

“What the hell are you doing?” she scolded. Slowly, she stopped struggling.

“Proving that I can still take you down.”

“You think so? I didn’t want to hurt you. I’m in enough trouble over Arslan. I don’t want to explain you bleeding out on the Agency’s cheap couch on my watch.”

“We both know I can take you down any time I want, Maddy.”

She turned, grabbed both his wrists, and slowly pinned them to the back of the couch. He didn’t fight her hard. Madison twisted as she did it and ended up straddling him. His cock stirred, despite the pain. She pretended she didn’t feel it.

“Force me off you,” she said, eyes intense, but a smile on her lips.

“Now that’s a Catch-22, Maddy, because I could, and I want to prove you wrong, but I also don’t want you off of me.”

Madison squeezed her thighs, forcing him to wince against a new spike of pain in his leg. His cock still throbbed against her. “You’re barely stitched back together, and you still only have one thing on your mind.” She shook her head, kept him pinned.

“I have quite a few things on my mind, but they all involve you staying on top of me.” He smirked.

“You’re definitely not healthy enough for that. Besides...”

Kane twisted his wrists so quickly that they were out of her grasp before she could react. His coffee tumbled to the floor behind the couch. He grabbed Madison’s head with both hands and pulled her into a kiss. She stiffened for a moment, like she knew she should fight it, but then the heat between them won out. It always did. Even before there was love between them, there’d always been that. A pull neither of them could deny.

Their tongue fought an angry, desperate duel before Madison bit his lip and pulled back, breathless. His hands still cupped her face, and she put hers over his. “Damien, I can’t.”

“Why not?” Kane didn’t believe her. Madison’s cheeks were flushed, and her breathing was fluttery. “I feel that you want to, Maddy.”

“You know why...”

She paused, didn’t say his name. Kane knew she didn’t want to rub in the fact that her resistance was about someone else. She didn’t need to. But he knew she wanted it; the desire was coming off her in waves. Maybe it made him a bastard, but he wasn’t going to let her off easy. He couldn’t. He wasn’t that noble.

“He’s not here. We are. I am. Don’t tell me you don’t care. You dragged me out of that dacha and past all of those dangers for a reason.”

“You’re my partner, Damien.”

“Bullshit. It wasn’t a duty or obligation, Maddy.”

“Damien, please...” She closed her eyes. The struggle washed across her face. It made her even more beautiful. “When I saw Reznikov point that gun at you. When I saw you on the floor...all that blood... I couldn’t lose you. Not like that.”

“You didn’t. You don’t have to. I’m right here.” He bumped her nose with his, making Madison open her eyes and look at him. He was lost in those

sapphire depths.

“But that’s why this can’t be anything more, Damien. I need more, and I need it with someone who’s not going to bleed out in some Moscow basement. I’m sorry if you can’t see that. He makes me feel safe.”

“And I don’t?”

“Not like that. You can’t, and you know it, Damien.”

Kane stared, face hardening. He would not show her his heart breaking in real time. “I’m not giving you up without a fight, Maddy.”

He kissed her again, fierce and combative. She fought harder that time, but her tongue still sought his. Her thighs relaxed so she could grind against him. She clearly felt how hard he was for her then. Still, her body was tense, like she was ready to tear away at any moment. He shoved her jacket off, then pulled her tight black tank top over her head. Madison tried to stop him. Kane pulled her fiery locks, and she whimpered into his mouth. He tossed the tank top aside.

“Goddam you.”

“Probably,” he agreed.

This time, she kissed him. He turned them, putting Madison on her back on the couch. The move felt like he tore open his barely healed bullet wound. His hand found the bandage covering the wound on her side and lightly caressed it. She tore at his ancient, worn Elvis Costello t-shirt. My Aim is True. It was, but Kane knew that wouldn’t matter in the long run. What they were doing in that CIA safe house wasn’t about the long run.

Madison raked her fingers through his hair, chasing his kisses like they were her oxygen. Her eyes were so vulnerable. He’d never seen that side of her. She whispered, “Not out here. In the bedroom. Please, Damien.”

Kane eased off her, breath catching with the pain. When she helped him into the bedroom, they were leaning on each other.

Madison knew it was wrong. Charles popped into her head when Kane pulled her into another hungry kiss beside the bed, but she couldn't help herself. Everything she'd been through with Kane, the passionate moments and the danger, had formed a bond she couldn't deny. She hadn't chosen Charles because she didn't want her partner. She'd made her choice because Charles could give her the life that Kane never could, a life she'd never dreamed of growing up with an unstable mother on the south side of Boston.

The life she had with Kane just wasn't sustainable. Madison couldn't keep doing it, knowing that one or both of them could wind up dead. Moscow had only confirmed that fear. As she gently peeled away Kane's t-shirt and felt his chest hair tickle her nose while she kissed his firm, defined pecks, she justified it as a goodbye to him.

Kane gasped when she nipped at his stubbled chin and enticed his tongue out with her own. Drawing on her exceptional multitasking skills, she devoured his kiss while unbuckling his belt and pushing a hand into his jeans. He was thick and ready for her. The pain of broken ribs and a gunshot wound could not dampen his enthusiasm for her. Madison smiled into their kiss as she pumped his cock, relishing his groans.

"You still fucking want it, Maddy..."

Madison bit his lip. "Shut up before you ruin this, Damien."

Slipping to her knees, she dragged his jeans and boxers down with her. He must have been wearing the underwear because Agency nurses were coming in to check on him. He usually went commando. She paused to kiss the jagged line of a nasty old scar he picked up in Kabul when he stepped in the way and took a choora that was meant for her.

His cock was hot and heavy in her hand. Rather than pull it right into her mouth, she lifted it, stroking the underside of the head with her thumb while tracing the large vein up the underside with the tip of her tongue. She took her time kissing and sucking the underside of his cock before tilting it down while licking the sides. The head brushed her cheek and left a sticky smear of his excitement. Her hot breath on his balls made him tremble. She stared



up at him while rubbing his head across her lips. He looked dizzy with need for her. Kane knew all of her tricks, but she was glad he was still helpless in the face of them.

Taking hold of her loose ponytail of flaming hair, Kane guided Madison's mouth onto his cock. She wasn't a woman who needed direction, but she didn't fight taking it. He loved watching her lips stretch around his girth and the way her nostrils flared when she adjusted her breathing—the grudging surrender in her eyes. Their relationship—whatever it was—had always been something of a power play, a struggle for control, and neither of them ever stayed on top for long.

Once she found a rhythm, Madison brushed off his hand and chose her own pace. That was even hotter than Kane setting it, and he moaned deeply. She flattened her hands on his thighs and took him deep, sucking hard, all hungry mouth, tight wet lips, and eager tongue. She purred around his meat like she loved it in her mouth. Kane had enjoyed a lot of blowjobs, but he'd never known a cocksucker as enthusiastic as Madison Byrne.

“Goddam it, Maddy... Fuck... Yesss, baby...”

Her steady pace was relentless, like her mouth was made to get him off. She took him so deep that her nose pressed against his body. She didn't seem to have a gag reflex. There was a reason she always had her targets eating out of the palm of her hand. Madison didn't always need to go there—or get sexual at all—but when she did, the men, and sometimes the women, were helpless to resist. Kane had always thought that she was so good because deep down, it wasn't just a job. She loved it.

Madison pulled off his shaft, breathless. Her tongue caught the trail of saliva that stretched back to her wet lips before she licked them. She looked a little dizzy herself, like she'd been totally caught up in the moment. Kane had worried she'd remember her fiancé and stop it, but her cheeks were flushed with heat. She wasn't stopping anything.

He pulled her into another fierce kiss when she stood and guided her onto the bed. They both winced when they moved. Madison wasn't as bad off as Kane, but they were both only a few weeks out from being beaten and shot

in Russia. The bruises on her face had faded to a faint discoloration, but her reset broken nose still stung when she touched it. Overcoming the pain was proof of their searing desire for each other.

He nearly stumbled when he tried to step out of his own jeans. “Careful,” she warned. The stab of pain from the bullet wound in his leg made his vision swim. Every movement brought its own fresh wave of hurt.

She kicked off her boots, and Kane worked the tight jeans down her hips, then slid them off her legs. The twisting motion made the wound in Madison’s side scream, but it wasn’t spotted with blood like the bandage on his leg. He’d pulled it open again. Pushing through pain had become second nature for him, and she wasn’t going to question his judgment. Kane was a big boy. He could make his own decisions.

“Fuck...” The painful groan was drawn out when he crawled onto the bed between her thighs.

“Damien, please...”

He ignored her and flicked open the front clasp on her plain, soft black bra. Her tits spilled out, and he gathered them, falling on them. His rough mouth took her thick, pale tips from stiff to throbbing. The next time his name escaped her lips, it was an urgent moan of pleasure, not a warning. Her nails raked through his thick, dark hair. His stubble brushed her nipples as he moved between them, making her burn for his touch.

“Oh god...yeah...Damien...that’s...ohhh...”

Madison was trembling when she pulled him by the hair and forced him to look up. Kane smiled. He loved seeing her like that, so needy, so ready. When her engine got going, she was like a freight train. He flashed his cocky grin and began kissing his way down her toned, flat belly, only briefly pausing to softly kiss the bandage over her wound. It was his silent acknowledgment of what she’d done for him in that Moscow basement. He got down to her bikini line before she stopped him with another tug of his hair.

“No... Stop teasing me... I... Just do it... please...”

His tongue traced a figure eight just below her cute belly button. “Tell me, Maddy.”

“You’re such a dick...” she panted, smiling. “Fuck me, Damien! Is that what you need? Fuck me now... Please...”

“Since you asked so nice... Shit!”

Madison’s voice went softer, but still thick with need. “Damien, if you’re not up to it...”

Kane smiled through the pain as he not-so-gracefully slid on top of her. “I’m always up for this, Maddy. I just twisted wrong. You know that better than anyone. Remember Belarus?”

“I’m pretty sure I handled most of the work that time. If that would make it easier... Oh god...Damien...babe...god yes...like that...”

Her recollection of the time they had sex in the back of a caravan surrounded by goats while she kept pressure on a gunshot wound in his shoulder was cut short when Kane stabbed his thick cock deep inside her. Madison rolled her hips up at him while her sheath tightened around his shaft to keep it right where she needed it.

Kane gritted his teeth against the pain, but refused to relent, working his cock into her with deep, powerful strokes. The way her mouth fell open with each breathy moan and that almost surprised look in her eyes with each thrust made the pain worth it. The agonizing throbbing in his leg would help him hold out anyway. Being inside her was so amazing, it could make any man finish much too quickly.

The pain etched in his face was difficult to bear, but his dedication to having her made Madison desperate for him. Not many men would fuck through those injuries. She knew she should stop him, but instead she locked her legs around his waist and pulled him deeper inside her.

“Ohhh god...yeah...Damien...ohhh god yesss...don’t stop...please...I’m... I’m...”

“Fuck...Maddy...can’t stop...so beautiful...I fucking need you...”

“Damien...don’t...ohmygod...yeah...ohmygod...”

Madison wanted to warn him, to tell him not to need her. She wasn’t his and never could be, but she came first. As the wave of pleasure crashed through her, she knew—deep down—that she needed him too, and that was why she had to get away. Needing a man like Damien Kane was dangerous. She cried out his name and surrendered to the ecstasy he pushed through her.

“Baby...stop...just stop for a minute...” she panted, wiping at the sweat on his forehead.

“Fuck, Maddy... I can’t... I need you...” He slowed, but kept his hips churning, thrusting deep.

The cock filling her made Madison’s head fuzzy, but she persisted. “I know, baby... Let’s just switch, okay? Ohhh god... Damien...”

Kane gasped when she helped him ease off of her. She kissed him deeply when she rolled him onto his back. He was soaked with sweat, but he’d never admit to Madison that fucking her was too taxing. He pulled her flaming locks out of her ponytail and laced his fingers through her thick mane while they kissed.

She kissed his chest again, licking at the salty slickness. He hissed when her tongue flicked over his nipple. Even though she was desperate to have him inside her again, Madison gingerly moved on top of Kane and settled onto his cock. He pulsed inside her, his need a palpable thing. God, I’ll miss this, she thought, and immediately felt guilty for it. Sex with Charles was also great. Reliably good. Every time. But it never made her feel this enflamed.

Madison sat up straight and rolled her hips, smiling down at him while she worked his cock. Bracing her hands on his chest for balance to ride him hard was out of the question, given his broken ribs. She couldn’t lean back

and brace her hands on his thighs because of his gunshot wound. Instead, she worked her core, gyrating her hips, making him stare up at her with unabashed awe. The motion made her own gunshot wound scream with pain, but she could bear it. Part of her even liked it. The pain made her burn brighter and felt like the punishment she deserved.

“Maddy...fuck...fuck yesss...fuck me, babe...” He held her waist, pulling her harder onto him.

“Damien...ohhh god...god yesss...”

Kane fixated on the wild look in her icy blue eyes, but her big, swaying breasts were hard to ignore. Her body was insanely perfect. Sometimes he thought she'd been built for her work, and then felt guilty because that was too close to saying she was built to be a whore. He didn't see her that way. Her tits felt even more perfect in his hands. Kane sculpted them and rolled the tips just hard enough to make her gasp. He was proud that he knew exactly what she liked.

“Ohmygod...Damien...yesss...oh god...yeah...” she cried.

Madison pulled his hands from her chest and clasped them in hers. Leaning hard, she used his resistance for leverage and rode him hard. The CIA safe house filled with the sounds of the bed's creaking protests beneath them and their growing moans. Hers rose an octave, and she howled, coming apart as Kane's thick, hot cock pushed her over the edge once again. The orgasm overwhelmed her, and Madison arched her back to jam her pussy onto him.

“Fuuuck...Maddy...” Kane growled.

Holding out a second time was impossible. He flooded her with his release, pumping a thick deposit deep inside Madison. She cried out and tightened around him when she felt the flood of his cum. Her cries pitched up once again, and her sheath milked the very last drop out of him.

Trembling, she slid off him and lay beside Kane on the bed. They were both gasping, trying to catch their breath. She quickly turned and kissed him before falling back again with a sigh.

“So, was it worth the pain?” she panted.

“Fuck, Maddy, you could have stabbed me right in the middle of it, and I wouldn’t have stopped. You know the answer.” He gave a rumbling sigh.

“Are you okay?”

Madison was glowing. The answer was obvious. She smiled. “I don’t care if that did internal damage. It was worth it.”

She cuddled tight against his side, knowing it would be the last time. She loved Charles, but it still broke her heart. She hoped Kane understood it wasn’t an easy decision. His hand caressed the small of her back, and she was glad he didn’t try to say anything else.

## two

### Present Day

### McLean, Virginia

Madison stood just outside the family room and spied on Charles, who was sitting on the couch with their kids. Was it spying? This was her family. She wondered how he coaxed the two teenagers to sit together long enough to watch a movie. In her mind, they were united against her. Charles was still peeved when she left, and Chazz put on a brave face, but he was hurt that she'd missed his show Saturday night after promising she wouldn't. Penny refused to give her anything, as usual.

The calm, domestic tableaux already felt strange to her after just one weekend away working on Operation Scarlet Phantom—after spending the weekend playing house with Kane while Cassandra directed their social media photos and encouraged them to act more like a couple.

Their handler stopped short of telling them to fuck each other—barely. Madison was tempted to tell Cassandra that she should show her how it's done and fuck Kane herself if she didn't like what she saw. It would have been worth it for the look on the young Asian woman's face. Cassandra didn't like Kane very much. Madison sensed their handler thought they were both past it and that her operation should have fresher talent, but Prince Zaydan bin Zalman Al-Kharabati had very specific tastes, and Madison fit the bill.

“Hey, guys. Miss me?” she announced, plastering on a smile and walking into the family room.

Charles jumped at her voice, spilling the popcorn bowl in his lap. His glasses almost fell off when he leaned forward to gather the wayward kernels. Madison knelt in front of the couch and helped pick up the popcorn. Her heart swelled at the sight of her straight-laced, sometimes goofy, normal husband.

“Hey, Maddy. I didn’t even hear you come in,” he replied, tense, but happy to see her regardless. “How was your work trip? I hope they didn’t wear you out.”

“It was a lot, but I’m just happy to be home with you guys.” She dropped popcorn back into the bowl and reached over the squeeze Chazz’s leg. “How did the show go, buddy? Dad sent me videos. You were great.”

“It was fine,” the fourteen-year-old replied. “Everything went fine. Grandmom was there.” Grandmom would be Charles’s mother. The kids rarely saw Madison’s.

“I’m glad she came out. I’m so sorry I couldn’t be there. There was just no way to get out of this work thing.”

Chazz shrugged. “Whatever. It’s just one show.”

Madison knew he didn’t mean that, and it broke her heart. It was just one show out of many he’d perform before he left for college—maybe he’d pursue theater there, too—but he didn’t see it that way in the moment, and she didn’t blame him. She was much too aware of how it felt to have parents who didn’t show up. Her father was rarely around after the divorce, and her mother was often distracted by her latest friend.

“I’m really sorry. I promise I won’t miss the next one.”

Chazz worked hard to appear indifferent. She turned to Penny.

“Glad you won all your games this weekend. You guys are a lock for the playoffs now.”



“I knew we would be. We’re better than all of those teams,” the sixteen-year-old answered.

“Stay humble, Pen,” Charles warned. “Win graciously.”

“Dad, we blew out that last team. It’s hard to be humble about that.” Penny laughed. “It feels good to dominate.”

“Penny, listen to your father. Always be kind first. We taught you better than that,” Madison scolded.

“Please, Mom. You don’t take shit from anyone. You’re not humble.”

“Penny! Language!”

The girl laughed. “Okay. I’m going upstairs. This movie sucks anyway.”

Madison watched her daughter go, thinking, That could have gone better.

“I’m going up, too,” Chazz said.

“But the movie is almost over, champ,” Charles said.

“Yeah, you two finish watching your movie. I just got home, and I need to unpack and shower anyway. Enjoy your guy time.” Madison left her boys to it, shouldering her bag and feeling like an even worse parent than before. She tossed the bag on the bed and stripped, leaving her clothes in a pile on the floor. Obsessively organized, Madison never did that. But she was tired. Guilty. She just needed to shut off for a while. With a last look, she left them to it.

The steaming needles of water sliced into her back, cutting into her fatigue. She held onto the wall and hung her head. They had the master bath redone a few years ago, and it was her sanctuary. The giant, walk-in shower felt like her own personal spa. She only loved the massive jetted tub more. Steam swirled around her, and she tried to let it carry her guilt away.

Under any other circumstances, it would have been a lovely, romantic weekend. She would have forged cherished memories if she’d been in New

York with Charles all weekend. Instead, she was building fraught memories with her fake husband, Damien Kane.

She remembered lying on a blanket in Central Park, limbs intertwined as she held up Melissa Richardson's phone to take a selfie. Melissa kissed David for the camera, and Madison tried not to feel anything on the inside while radiating the love shared by a longtime couple on the outside. She tried not to think about the way Kane's kisses used to make her feel, while insisting to herself that she'd never feel those things for him again. I love my husband. I love Charles.

The Richardsons had shared a romantic dinner at one of New York's most exclusive restaurants. Madison had worn a pretty, subtly sexy dress and smiled like she was trying to entice Kane when he snapped her picture from across the table. They had held hands and talked about the Richardsons' lives and worked on faking that chemistry that had been dangerously real sixteen years ago.

For once, Madison had been glad Cassandra had walked her and Kane back to the hotel. Having their handler right there, all the time, criticizing their chemistry, was the reality check she needed. The Asian woman kept telling Madison that she needed to warm up to Kane, and she snuggled closer against his side, but that was all. She could hardly tell Cassandra that she was intentionally keeping her former partner and lover at arm's length. Madison was not going to admit that playing house with Kane could be a problem—even to herself. She was a professional, and she would handle it.

Back at the hotel, she'd been half-scared that Cassandra would tell them to go into the bedroom and sleep together. She would have drawn the line there. If they had to do things at Nox Venari to sell their cover, she would. But she would not practice-fuck Kane.

In the house she shared with Charles, Madison slipped into the comfy tank top and sleep shorts she usually wore to bed. She was starting to feel normal again. She looked around their bedroom and decided she would not lose everything she had to this operation. She wouldn't allow it.

Downstairs, Charles was sitting on their back patio staring up at the moon as the clouds floated past, shrouding its reflected light before letting it shine once more. She stepped through the sliding glass door with a beer and pulled it closed behind her. The late June D.C. humidity enveloped her in a wet blanket, barely alleviated by the slight breeze stirring the trees.

“I guess the movie’s over?” she asked, slipping into the deep Adirondack chair beside his.

“It is. I don’t know why they keep making John Wick movies. They’re ridiculous at this point.”

“Isn’t that the point? And why were you watching a John Wick movie with our fourteen-year-old?”

Madison refrained from telling him all the reasons the movie truly was ridiculous, beginning with all of the “gun fu” nonsense. You’d never fire a gun like that in close quarters.

“Come on, Maddy. The violence is completely cartoonish. And it was the new one without Keanu, I think it was called Ballerina or something? That’s why I thought Penny might be interested.”

She laughed. “Because girls like ballerinas? Oh, honey, you are not a modern man.”

“Sure, I am,” he argued, taking a long pull off his vape. The sweet smell of cannabis filled the air.

“Charles! Do you have to do that?”

“I need some way to unwind. It was a long weekend.”

“What would the partners at your firm say?”

“Who do you think gave it to me? You’re probably the only one in this neighborhood who isn’t getting high.”

They both laughed.

“Except for all of the other people with sensitive government jobs. I’m not the only one. I’m sorry again for not being around this weekend, hon.”

He answered with a resigned sigh. “I know you would have been if you could have been. You wanted to be at Chazz’s show.”

“I wish he were as understanding.”

“He will be. Give him time. Teenage boys are big balls of uncontrollable emotions. They just don’t let it all out like girls do. And those emotions are especially complicated when it comes to their moms.”

“You’re not implying some Oedipal thing, are you? Ew...”

“Is that your third beer?” He gave her a look. “No, of course not. I’m just saying, he’s moving into figuring out his identity without his mommy always there to make everything better. He’s pulling away, but he doesn’t want you to.”

“I’m not. That’s not what happened, Charles.”

“I know. And he will, too.” He took another pull on his vape. “So, how did it go? Was this foreign bigwig properly pampered?”

“I think he was happy,” she replied, thinking about how smug Kane was when she had to play his loving wife. He saw the resistance behind her eyes and seemed to love it. He’d always been the kind of prick who liked to torture people, but she thought it was more than that.

“Did they keep you hopping all weekend?”

“More or less. We were on call 24/7, and there was always something.”

Charles watched her and marveled at how smoothly she lied. It was a white lie, something her work required, but she still did it flawlessly, like she believed every word. A lesser man would have been concerned that his wife could lie like she breathed, but he loved her and trusted that she’d never lie about anything important. Madison gave him that smile, and he couldn’t help but love her.

Not knowing how much of what she told him was untrue was both a blessing and a curse. If he knew she was lying about something serious—something meaningful—it would tear him apart. And Madison probably had to carry secrets no one should have to deal with. He wanted to lift her burden, but he didn't want to know those things. The only thing he was sure of was that she did not have some anodyne job at the State Department. He had enough experience in and around government to know a cover story when he heard one.

Charles wondered if everyone with a spouse with a vague State Department job worried that they were a spook. How many embassy aides really worked for the Agency? Living in and around D.C. and working in certain parts of government meant accepting a lot of things most normal people would never consider. Working as a lobbyist meant Charles often had to look the other way when he didn't want to. He'd never had to fully compromise his ethics, and never would, but he knew that CIA officers didn't have that luxury.

He didn't know that Madison worked for the Agency. Part of the deal was that one never asked. Some people probably did, but Charles was not that weak. He respected her too much. If she could live with whatever burden it put on her, then he could carry the not knowing. But she was not processing passports at the State Department. He was sure of that. He was also sure—mostly sure—that she wasn't a field officer because her work rarely required travel. He thanked God for that. He didn't know if he could live with fearing she wouldn't come back every time she left the house.

"I'm just glad to be home with you and the kids." Madison tilted her head, giving him a quizzical look. "Are you there, honey?"

"Yeah, sorry, maybe the vaping is kicking in quick tonight." Charles grinned. "Just got into my head for a moment. I'm glad you're here, too. I hope you had some fun this weekend. Hope it wasn't all work."

Madison thought about lying in the park with Kane and walking through the Met hand-in-hand. It felt nice when she shut her brain off—and that was the problem. And then there was Casius and his toy. She worked hard to deny

that she enjoyed any of it. It's a job, she told herself. You're not supposed to have fun. You can't enjoy any of it.

"I just wanted it to be over so I could get home."

She took a long pull on her beer bottle and moved to settle in his lap, her arms around him. He squeezed her back, and his familiar warmth instantly made her feel better. She rested her head on his shoulder. He kissed it.

"You're here now, and that's all that matters, Maddy. I hated being in bed without you."

"Then you should drag me up there and give me a reason to stay home."

"Give me a minute to enjoy you right here, then maybe, babe."

"I like it right here, too," she sighed, but when she felt his growing excitement under her rear, she wiggled it. She was rewarded with a twitch and a whimper.

"Don't start that now," he warned, lighthearted.

Madison laughed and began kissing his neck. "I didn't start anything. You're the one getting hard."

"A monk would get hard with this ass in his lap." He stroked her hair and moaned at her lips on his neck.

"Maybe I should test that. Did you set up dinner at the congressman's house yet?"

Charles laughed and felt for the edge of her soft tank top. "Jesus, Maddy. You'd kill that poor man. They'd need to find a new Archbishop."

"I don't think he needs any encouragement, not how he was looking at me, but it is nice to know I can tempt a man of God to sin." She ground her ass down harder on him and nipped at his neck.

"Maddy...babe... you are sin. That body...it's the ultimate temptation."

“Still think so? Even after all these years?”

Charles pulled her lips to his. The desperate heat of his kiss was the only answer she needed. It was slow and deep, but she attacked his tongue. She needed him. “I’ve never loved you more, Maddy. I’ve never wanted you more.” His hand slid under her tank top, warm and grasping. His palm skimmed over her nipple, and she whimpered. Her core tightened in anticipation of what was to come.

“If I’m sin and here to tempt you, then I should offer you a bite of the forbidden apple.”

Madison tossed off her tank top and pulled his mouth to her chest. He didn’t fight her like he did on the couch the other day, but his glazed eyes and goofy grin meant that he was already stoned from the vape. Charles pulled off his glasses and eagerly, softly suckled her. She moaned and rubbed his smoothly shaved head. She ached for him. After a weekend with Kane, she needed her husband to make love to her.

“Yeah...honey...so good...you know what I need...”

“Goddam, you’re on fire, Maddy...”

He hardly had the words out before she stuffed her breast back into his mouth. Madison needed his mouth busy on her supple, freckled flesh. The words didn’t matter, although she meant hers. Being lovers for so long meant that Charles knew exactly what she liked. That could be a problem for some couples, but not for them. Damien doesn’t know me anymore, she thought.

Charles circled and flicked her pulsing bud with his tongue before lightly nipping with his teeth, sending pleasure sizzling through her. He could be a little rougher, but she valued his tenderness. She didn’t need someone to manhandle her. She hardly even remembered what that felt like.

“Honey...please...I need you...now...” she softly moaned, sliding away from him.

“We shouldn’t, Maddy. We’re outside. The kids... The neighbors...”

“We didn’t get caught the other night,” she replied with a wink, voice husky with need.

“That was luck.” His protest was weak. He didn’t prevent her from wrestling his jogging shorts down his legs. He even helped by pulling one leg free. His eyes widened when her tits bounced while she wiggled out of her sleep shorts.

Charles stared at his sexy wife in awe. Even after sixteen years of marriage, he couldn’t quite believe she was his. The curve of her hips may have been fuller than that night they met, but he found her softer curves even sexier than that toned, hard body she had back then. She felt right in his arms. But she seemed to have that old fire back. Something in her eyes was different, like something she hadn’t felt in ages had been switched on.

Madison climbed astride him on the Adirondack chair and sank onto him with a satisfied moan. They’d barely fooled around, but she was already slick and ready. He appreciated that she was so hot for him, but he did question why. As she rolled her hips, Charles wondered if this was that sexual peak that women were supposed to get later, and immediately felt silly for considering it. He had to stop overthinking it and appreciate how lucky he was.

“God...honey...I missed you this weekend...missed this...” She held his shoulders for balance and aggressively worked her hips to massage his cock inside her.

He gripped her hips and pumped up at her the best he could in his awkward position in the sloped-back patio chair. It was up to Madison to do all the work, and he wasn’t complaining. Watching her move on his cock was almost as good as feeling it.

“Can’t...ohhh...believe we’re doing this...” he moaned.

“We can...ahhh...still be exciting...ohhh yesss... spontaneous...yeah, honey...”



Charles glanced nervously around, still not fully in the moment, even as he throbbed inside her churning pussy. Neither of the neighbors could realistically see them in that spot, but they could certainly hear them. However, the kids could come downstairs, and if they looked outside, they'd need years of therapy.

“Maddy...shhh...ohhh dammit...you're...”

Madison leaned in and kissed him, stifling her moans for a moment, but then she threw her head back and cried out even louder, thrusting her breasts forward. Charles buried his face in them, nipping at her swollen, pale tips as they swayed with her motion. It was difficult to remember to be careful when his hot wife was fucking him so hard.

“Honey...Charles...ohmygod...yeah...yeah...oh god...ohhh god yesss...”

He clapped his hand over her mouth when she shrieked into the humid night. Madison stiffened and jammed down onto his cock so hard that it almost hurt. Her pussy felt like it was melting down around him, and Charles released with a grunt, jetting it up inside her. She trembled and tried to pull his hand away, but she was still shouting into it, and he wouldn't let go. It was only when she was turning red that he realized she might not be able to breathe, and he let go. She collapsed on top of him, chest heaving. Their thighs stuck together in the humid night.

“Oh god...ohhh fuck...” she gasped, still shaking while she clung to him. She laughed. “That was sooo good...”

“It was, but Jesus, Maddy...” he groaned, his heart hammering while he held her tightly.

“I know... I know...” she sighed, pulling back enough to kiss him. They were lost in the jungle of her wild, tangled hair. “But a little bit of risk every once in a while makes it hotter, doesn't it?”

His thumb brushed her cheek, and he kissed her. “I don't need anything to make it hotter when I have you. Is this your way of telling me you've been bored?”

“No. Never. Not bored, but we need to mix it up some to make sure we don’t get there.”

Charles knew there was more going on, but he didn’t press her. He chose to appreciate what he had and trust Madison to work it out for herself. He could never even guess at all the things he didn’t know, the trouble that lay ahead. Charles valued a simple, ordered life because he understood how chaotic the world out there could be. Madison had that chaos in her, but she’d always controlled it. The limits of her control were about to be tested.

## three

The conversation where Madison told Charles that she'd be traveling to New York a lot over the next several months had not gone well. Her cover was that she'd been reassigned to the US Mission to the United Nations to fill in for someone on maternity leave. The charged undercurrent of their conversation was new. Charles wasn't saying anything about it, but he clearly knew she wasn't being entirely truthful, and she didn't know how to handle that.

They'd always lived with the understanding that her work involved things she couldn't share with him. He was an adult, and Madison appreciated that he respected her enough to let it lie. Whether it was a question of State Department secrets that she couldn't share or something deeper, he'd always accepted the reality she presented. But that was when it didn't intrude on their lives. Sometimes work took her away at odd hours or she had to run in on short notice, just as his work required dinner meetings and golf weekends, but she'd never gone out of town for days at a time and left Charles to white knuckle the parenting on his own.

This time, Madison would only be gone overnight, but he was chilly when she left that Friday morning with a bag slung over her arm. She packed business casual to maintain the ruse that she would be working at the UN, but her Melissa Richardson identity awaited her in Philadelphia.

The Acela took her from Washington to Philadelphia. Dentiger picked her up from 30th Street Station and drove her to the Richardsons' home, a condo on Rittenhouse Square that the Agency had rented. Tayshawn Dentiger barely said two words to her on the drive into Center City, but he glanced into the rearview mirror to watch her in the backseat. He might still have been salty about their encounter on the training course at The Farm, but that didn't mean he couldn't appreciate a beautiful woman. Even a black pantsuit and a white shell couldn't hide Madison's charms. The large

Black man couldn't decide whether he wanted to put the MILF in her place by fucking her or taking another shot at her on that course.

Kane waited at the condo. He'd gone up to Philadelphia days earlier since he had nothing holding him back in Washington. When Madison arrived, he'd made himself at home in the Richardsons' upscale condo. The kitchen was a mess, and three jackets were tossed haphazardly onto one of the living room chairs. Manny Sanz, the tech wiz from DS&T, sat on the couch with his feet up, working on his laptop. A large, hard plastic cargo case sat on the expensive coffee table. Madison tried not to think about the scratches it would leave.

"Your little lady is delivered," Dentiger announced, walking in ahead of Madison.

"Really?" Madison frowned.

"Did you have a nice trip, honey?" Kane asked.

"Fantastic. I guess it's the maid's day off?" she asked, staring at the sink full of coffee cups. "You weren't saving that for the little lady, were you?"

Kane followed her gaze. "I'll get to it."

Madison huffed and dropped her bag. She hip-checked him out of the way. "The dishwasher is literally right here," she said, lowering the door. It was not her job to clean up after the men on her team, but her mom instincts just kicked in. "You're as bad as my teenagers."

"Sorry, Mom," he replied, flashing that cocky grin that she at once hated and loved once upon a time.

"Yeah, sorry, Mom," Dentiger added, without Kane's charm.

"I clean up after myself," Manny chimed in from the living room. The first floor of the condo was an open floor plan, with a wall of floor-to-ceiling balcony doors overlooking trees and brick-paved paths of Rittenhouse Square.

“I don’t know how much we’re all going to co-occupy this space, but while we are, we need to show some common courtesy,” she said.

“Fine, let me clean it up,” Kane replied, trying to nudge her away from the sink.

Madison stood her ground, bracing herself against his pressure. She almost retreated from the feeling of his body against hers, but winning was more important. They pushed hard against each other.

“Stop it! I’ve got this,” she protested.

“You want me to clean up after myself, let me do it,” Kane argued.

“Bickering already?” Cassandra asked, coming down the stairs. “Now you two sound like a real married couple. It’s about time.” She saw them struggling in the kitchen and stopped with her hands on her hips. “What are you two doing?”

“She started it,” Kane complained.

“I did not. I was just telling these pigs that they need to pick up after themselves.”

“Just stop it. Save the passion for when you have an audience,” Cassandra scolded. “I can’t believe you two are old enough to be my parents and you’re behaving like this.”

The CIA officers stopped to stare at their handler. The Asian woman was younger than they were, but not that much younger.

“How old do you think we are?” Kane asked, voice rising.

“I am not old enough to be your mother!” Madison protested, offended.

“Close enough,” Cassandra replied.

Madison didn’t know exactly how old Cassandra Gale was, but she would have guessed early to mid-thirties. She would have had to have been

pregnant as a high school freshman to be the girl's mother.

"How old are your parents?" Kane asked.

"Somewhere around your age. That's not the point. Can we all just behave like the professionals we're supposed to be?"

Madison used the distraction to push Kane out of the kitchen. He grumbled, but he went.

"Are you two ready for tonight? I mean, like, mentally prepared?" Cassandra continued.

Kane grinned and dropped onto the couch opposite Manny. "I was born to play this role. I'm ready. Do you have your part down, Maddy?"

"I'll hold up my end. You don't need to worry about that," she replied, hoping she sounded more confident than she felt. Madison wished she knew which bothered her more, going into a sex club like Nox Venari, or pretending to be Damien Kane's wife while she did it.

"I feel like you two were warming up nicely by the end of last weekend, but we can't have any slip-ups like we had during our run-throughs at Langley this week. You two need to be David and Melissa Richardson. The stakes are too high for us to be undone by a simple mistake," Cassandra said.

"I can feed you guys information through the earpieces, but whatever comes out of your mouths has to sound natural," Dentiger said.

"We'll be fine. You don't need to worry about us," Madison replied, annoyed by how defensive she sounded.

"No offense, but you ain't been in the field in like twenty years. Covert ops have changed a lot since the last time you were out there."

"It has not been twenty years! Fuck! How old do you people think we are?" Madison complained.

“I was out there doing it when you were trying to figure out how to feel up your first girl. Madison has forgotten more about being in the field than you’ll ever know,” Kane said.

“That’s what I’m afraid of. I’ve seen your file, man. Impressive stuff, but how can you still even move? The Agency didn’t even have proper physical therapy back then, man. And Mama Bear over here...”

Kane started to rise from his chair. Madison came out of the kitchen to stop him. She did not need him to fight her battles.

“Enough!” Cassandra called out. “I know everyone is tense because of the stakes here. But we will all do our jobs, we will do whatever the mission requires, and we will stop Al-Kharabati from getting Null:Echo. Minds on the mission, people. Let’s all sit down and go over this one more time. And then the two of you need to start getting ready. We should leave here by seven at the latest.”

“Shit,” Dentiger laughed. “I can’t believe you’re making the Black guy on the team play chauffeur.

“Enough,” Cassandra reiterated. “Manny will be doing tech checks in the back of the van while we follow you. We don’t want them with just any Uber Black driver. Now, everyone, take a seat.”

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Madison smacked her lips, leaned into the mirror for a closer look, and applied a bit more of the True Red lipstick. It was a darker shade, closer to a blood red than the brighter, vivid shade that most people would associate with a vampy red lipstick, but she didn’t like those shades with her hair color. It was a lipstick she usually reserved for dressy, special occasions, like Charles’s client dinners. She chose it to keep a part of herself while she was acting as Melissa Richardson.

The lipstick was part of her attempt to control what she could in Operation Scarlet Phantom. She'd also gone shopping in Washington earlier in the week to choose Melissa Richardson's clothes, particularly her outfits for Nox Venari. She didn't quite trust Cassandra's judgment in that regard. The woman didn't seem to understand seduction in the way Madison did. But Cassandra—and Deputy Director Bristow through her—were trying to control every aspect of the mission.

Madison couldn't do her job if the Agency didn't trust her judgment. She kept her questions about that topic to herself. Madison didn't know how she would respond to the pressure of being undercover after so many years away from it. She forced her hand steady as she applied her makeup. Their arrival at Nox Venari loomed, but she still couldn't quite believe this was happening.

After one last check in the mirror, she decided her hair and makeup were ready. She'd done her eyes with dramatic shadow and tight mascara to make her blue eyes pop, but it felt unnecessary when she would be wearing a mask all night. Nox Venari required the mask in all public areas, and she didn't anticipate going anywhere private on their first visit, even if Prince Zaydan was there. She was supposed to be playing hard to get. Melissa Richardson was not the sort of woman who'd fall all over him.

The dress waited for her on the bed. She walked into the bedroom in the lacy black lingerie she'd chosen for the night and stared at it. Madison thought it was sexy, but classy. She knew she could pull it off. She'd chosen the little black cocktail dress after a lot of consideration about how Melissa Richardson would dress for a night like this. She was a well-off suburban mom from the Main Line outside of Philadelphia. Her world had been volunteering and carpools.

Madison knew dozens of women like her. She lived in that world, even though she wasn't like that—not really. But unlike her friends back in McLean, an empty nest had pushed Melissa—with the urging of her husband, David—to decide it was time to explore her darker passions.

The last touch before slipping into the LBD was pulling on sheer tights. She had one foot up on the bed and was tugging the tights up her leg when she



heard Kane behind her.

“Not thigh highs? That’s not like you.”

“What the hell, Damien? You can’t just walk in here while I’m getting ready,” she angrily replied, awkwardly turning on him with one leg in the tights.

“We’re supposed to be married, right? We should be comfortable with each other.” He didn’t hide the way he drank in her body.

Madison fought the urge to cover herself. She would not give him the satisfaction. The woman he’d known, thirty-two-year-old Madison Byrne, proudly displayed her body. She’d even liked it when Kane looked at her like that. Forty-eight-year-old Madison Sinclair wasn’t a prude. She usually changed without Charles in the room, but she didn’t hide her nudity from her husband. However, she did not parade around in her lingerie in front of other men. Still, she stood there and let him look.

“Cut the crap, Damien. We’re not Melissa and David right now. I’ll switch it on when I need to, but there’s no reason for you to be here right now. What are you doing in here?”

“I want to be sure we’re on the same page tonight. Convincing Cora Ludolf and her flunky that we’re some normal couple looking for adventure was one thing. Selling it to Al-Kharabati is going to be another. We need to be rock solid.”

“Do you think I don’t know that?”

“I get the feeling that you’re letting our...baggage...get in the way. I’ve put the past behind me, so I think our familiarity is an asset.”

Madison wanted to punch him. His arrogance was as infuriating as ever. Part of her found it sexy when they were younger, but now his questioning of her ability to do the job felt condescending. But that wasn’t the only thing she felt.

As ridiculous as it was to be having this discussion while she was standing there in a lacy black bra and panties, her tights only half on, she felt her body responding to Kane's attention. It shouldn't matter, but her unspoken fear that he'd look at her after two kids and sixteen years and be turned off was laid bare. Laid bare and put to rest. He could hardly make eye contact. His eyes were all over her. Madison willed herself not to stare at the front of his tuxedo pants, but she knew he liked what he saw. She hated that it mattered to her.

She finished pulling her tights on and stepped right up to him, ignoring her own nakedness and how good he still looked in a tuxedo, and poked a finger into his chest. Why does he have to look good? she thought. Somehow, his generally rumpled composure looked even better in black tie.

"I will be fine, Damien. The past isn't a problem for me. It's the distant past, isn't it? I feel like I've lived a whole lifetime since then. Haven't you? I've had two kids. They're teenagers. I've built a life with someone. I hope you have, too. Our past isn't a problem for me unless it's a problem for you."

Madison tensed. Kane looked like he was going to try to smack her or kiss her. She didn't know which would have been a bigger problem. She braced herself for either one.

"I guess we're both clear then," he replied, grinding his jaw.

"I'm glad we are. Now, can I finish getting dressed?"

"Sure. I'll see you downstairs, Maddy."

The tension drained, and he turned away. She exhaled as she watched him go, relieved that she was convincing. The last thing either of them needed was for him to know about the maelstrom of emotions she experienced every time she was near him.

Kane pulled the door closed and stopped in the hallway. His temper burned almost as hot as his lust. Seeing Madison in that black underwear was the last thing he needed. He was already struggling to rein it in. Fuck, her tits

look amazing, he thought. He wanted to burst back through that door and throw her onto the bed.

*Maddy's selling herself as this proper suburban mom type, but I know my Maddy is still in there. I felt it when we kissed. Kane would never force her, but he knew he wouldn't have to. Just as he knew he'd have her soon enough.*

Madison could insist that she could get the mission done without crossing any of her new moral lines, but they both knew that was bullshit. You didn't go into a place like Nox Venari and keep your panties on. No one would believe they were a couple looking to explore if they just held hands and kissed each other on the cheek. He was certain that Madison would cross those lines with him, and he was just as certain that she'd love every second of doing it.

*At least I convinced her that this is just another mission to me, he thought as he walked toward the stairs. She couldn't know that their last time together in London still felt like yesterday for him. He buried it because he'd had to, but the moment he walked into the briefing at Langley, it all came rushing back like a tidal wave, and it bowled him over.*

*I need a fucking drink, Kane thought.*

## four

“Comms check. 1...2...3. Can you hear me, Madison?” Manny asked. He was a tinny voice in her ear.

“I hear you, Manny.”

“Comms check. 1...2...3. Kane, do you hear me?”

“Yeah, I hear you.” He was annoyed they were doing it again.

“Now, both of you. Can you hear me?”

“We hear you. It’s all working,” Kane sniped.

Madison shot him a look. Softly, she replied, “We hear you, Manny. It’s all working. Do you have eyes?”

“Check...and check. We’re good to go.”

They sat in the back of the SUV, a block away from Nox Venari. Dentiger was in the front seat. Cassandra and Manny were in the black Sprinter van parked up the street from the club. They’d both inserted the tiny, invisible earwigs back in Philadelphia to make sure they were working. As they prepared to enter the club, they’d slipped them in again. The comms were hugely important to the success of any mission.

The spies also carried tiny, concealed video transmitters, which had come a long way since Madison was last in the field. In 2009, she’d made recordings with small cameras, but the development of something so small that it could transmit clear video over such a distance was new to her. Her transmitter was concealed in a golden locket Melissa Richardson wore around her neck, while Kane’s was hidden in one of the black studs closing

his tuxedo shirt. The backing was thicker than an ordinary stud, and he'd have to pocket it if his shirt came off, which Madison still hoped would not happen.

"Does that mean we're ready to go?" Dentiger asked.

"We're ready, if you guys are. Peacock is still in the nest, but he prefers to be fashionably late," Cassandra said over comms. Peacock was the code name they'd assigned to the young prince.

"If he shows at all," Kane replied. The closer they'd gotten to Nox Venari, the tenser he'd become, but he'd always been wired on missions. Age hadn't mellowed that.

"The team on him will alert us the moment he moves," Cassandra answered.

"And if he decided he wants a cozy night in?" Madison asked.

"We can call it an early night, but tonight will still be useful in establishing the Richardsons at Nox Venari," Cassandra replied.

"Then let's get moving," Dentiger said, shifting the SUV into gear.

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Arriving at Nox Venari late on a Friday night for one of their parties was a very different experience from arriving on a weekday morning. A black velvet curtain blocked the hallway ahead of the front staircase. They were greeted by Syma once again; she was standing beside a small table just inside the doors. A black leather mask covered the upper half of her face, but she was still recognizable. Kane would have known those tits anywhere.

The hostess wore a black and red lace bustier and black leather hotpants, matched with laced-up, knee-high shiny leather boots. The silver fox head

symbol of Nox Venari was nestled in her deep valley of cleavage. The massive man beside her looked like a pro wrestler. He was dressed in all black, and there was an earpiece with a wire curling away from his ear instead of a mask.

“If you don’t mind, sir,” the guard said, stepping forward.

“Sure. I have nothing to hide,” Kane replied, with David Richardson’s amiable smile. He held his arms straight out from his shoulders. He knew how to take a pat-down.

The guard firmly patted him down and extracted his phone. It was a prop for Kane’s cover, just like the hotel keycard, ID, and credit cards tucked into David Richardson’s money clip. The phone went into a locking, signal-blocking pouch.

“Ma’am?” the guard asked Madison.

“I can search you if you’d prefer, Mrs. Richardson,” Syma suggested.

Madison didn’t have to perform looking nervous. Standing on the threshold of Nox Venari had her heart hammering. Would Melissa be more uncomfortable having a man pat her down or making a fuss to have Syma do it? she wondered.

“That’s okay. We’ve been to events that required security. Just don’t be too rough, sir,” she answered with a shy smile.

She held her arms out at her sides like a lady, not like she was being frisked by the cops the way Kane had. The guard’s hands were smooth but firm over her body, even though it would have been impossible to hide anything under that dress. The subtly sequined black material clung to her figure, and the middle panel was sheer lace. But the guard felt her up anyway. Madison chose not to enjoy the frisking. She even squirmed and snickered the way she imagined Melissa would.

The guard also inspected her purse and took her phone as well. She made a face and said, “Is that really necessary? We have kids...”

Kane laughed and said, “They’re adults now, honey. If they’re calling their mommy late on a Friday night, it’s not going to be the kind of trouble you can get them out of. They’ll probably need a lawyer. And I made sure they all know how to reach Frank.” He placed a reassuring hand on the small of her back.

Madison smiled, snapping the small clutch she carried closed. The only things left in it were some cash, lipstick, a pack of tissues, and Melissa Richardson’s ID and credit cards. “I guess I just refuse to think of them that way. They’ll always be kids to me.”

“And that’s exactly why we’re here, Mel. It’s time for us to start living as adults again,” Kane said, sliding his arm around Madison and kissing her cheek.

Syma sealed their phones in the bag and handed Madison a small black chip with the number 48 embossed in gold. “If you feel the need to come and check your phones, you can come back up here at any time, and I’ll get them out for you, but you cannot take them any deeper into the club. I’m sure you understand and appreciate how seriously we take our members’ privacy.”

“Yes, I get it. Mel is just nervous. We both are. You know, this is our first time,” Kane said, playing the concerned husband.

“You’ll find there is no reason to be nervous. Our members are all very respectful. Nothing is going to happen that you don’t want to.” Syma smiled.

Madison returned the smile with a worried tinge. “Maybe that’s what I’m afraid of.”

Syma tapped the iPad she held. Turning to the table, she lifted two silver fox head pins. She briefly held them to the tablet before passing them to Kane and Madison.

“These are your emblems of membership. Please wear them somewhere on your person while in the club. Simply present them each time you arrive. I

recognized you, of course, but it may not always be me at the door. These are your keys to the club. If you lose them, we will need to verify your identities and membership another way.”

Kane turned the card over in his hand before pinning it to his jacket. Madison stared at the fox head with its tiny red eyes in her palm. It was the perfect symbol for the night hunt. She pinned it to her dress.

“I appreciate what a tight ship you run. I don’t think a place like Nox Venari can operate without such measures. I know that I wouldn’t want our membership to be exposed, Kane said.

He smiled at being a successful interloper, despite all of the club’s security measures, but then, they were CIA, not just journalists or local police trying to penetrate Nox Venari.

“Now, if you’ve not brought your own masks, you may select from ours. Please respect that your mask must be worn at all times in the public areas,” Syma said.

“Even in the pool?” Madison asked.

“Yes, even in the pool, although no one will be a stickler if you slip it off to dunk under the water.”

The spies had not brought their own masks. It had been a discussion, and Cassandra believed it was the sort of detail the Richardsons would miss. Manny was also working with the Wizards back at DS&T in Langley to conceal an undetectable camera in a masquerade mask.

Kane selected a black leather Harlequin mask with an elastic band and slipped it over his head. A small silver fox head was riveted between the brows. Madison lifted a soft, lace mask from the table.

“Sweetheart, would you?” she asked. She held her hair up while he positioned the mask across her eyes and knotted it at the back of her head. She dropped her hair and teased it with her fingers to conceal the knot. The mask made her pulse jump. It was suddenly much more real.



Syma swept the black curtain aside with a flourish, and in her crisp British accent, she intoned, “Welcome to Nox Venari. I hope you find everything you’re looking for.”

*So do I, Madison thought, focusing on Null:Echo.*

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“Comms check. Do you hear me?” Madison mumbled. She’d long ago mastered the art of speaking just loud enough for comms with minimal lip movement. She sat on a red, crushed velvet couch in the reception lounge.

Kane was refreshing their drinks at the bar—Johnnie Walker King George V for himself and a Negroni for her. He was excited to drink the high-end blended whiskey on someone else’s dime.

“We hear you, so far, so good,” Cassandra replied in her ear.

“The video is coming through, too. Looks like a nice place,” Manny added from the van.

“No movement from Al-Kharabati yet. I’ll keep you posted. Just mingle and make friends,” Cassandra said.

Madison smiled and mumbled, “Sure, just like I’m on a playdate for one of the kids.”

Rumors were that Nox Venari used signal jammers in case anyone managed to slip a mobile phone or other device into the club. Manny had been confident that even if the club did deploy such illegal technology, it would be no match for the Agency’s gear. She was pleased he was right, but they hadn’t ventured very far into the club yet.

The lounge was sparsely occupied. She assumed other parts of the club were more crowded. The doors opened at nine that Friday night, and they’d

arrived close to eleven. No one wants to be the first arrival at a sex club.

But even among the dozen or so people in the lounge, Madison recognized a meteorologist from one of the national morning shows standing with a man she assumed was the woman's husband. Her stylized white rabbit mask didn't disguise her identity, especially when Madison heard the woman's voice as she passed. The slender, strawberry blonde weathergirl wore a black silk kimono over an emerald bra and panty set, with a matching garter belt and stockings. The bra worked hard to push up the woman's small breasts.

The dress code for men at Nox Venari was simple—black tie. And Kane had cleaned up well. But women had options, with the only requirement being to dress to impress. Female members were encouraged to wear either sexy evening wear or lingerie. Madison was not surprised that the real world's double standards extended into the club. For all the talk of how the Lifestyle was female-led, it was still a man's world.

*It looks like our perky weathergirl might be making a connection, she thought. The woman and her husband chatted with another couple. The meteorologist's husband was slight and nerdy-looking, even with his black mask and tux. Uncharitably, Madison thought the weathergirl was looking to trade up. The man from the other couple, wearing a stylized stag mask, was tall and filled out his tuxedo nicely. So much for that squeaky clean image, she thought.*

"I don't think I've seen you here before, although I suppose it's hard to tell with the masks. But I think I'd remember you, with that beautiful hair. I'm Paul."

The voice came from a man who'd come up on her blind side. Madison was annoyed that she'd been too distracted to catch his approach. Have to sharpen up, she told herself. He was tall, with a ring of tightly shaved gray hair, and a belly that strained the button of his tuxedo jacket. The black harlequin mask looked tiny on his jowly face.

"I'm Melissa," she said, forcing a smile. She wanted to tell the man to fuck off, but Melissa Richardson would be polite. Melissa would also be

guileless and use her real name. Pseudonyms were always an option at Nox Venari for those who truly wanted to conceal their identity. “This is my... our...first time.” She looked around. “Is your wife here with you?”

Paul chuckled. He stared into the cleavage that her black dress offered up while he spoke. “Oh, she’s in the next room watching the show. I won’t be surprised if she’s found a new playmate before I return. I like to think of us as the unofficial welcoming committee.”

“That’s awfully nice of you. We actually had a tour, with Cora and someone else...” she replied, pretending to stumble for Casius’s name.

“Yes, all new members get the tour, but you need to spend time with longtime members to get the lowdown on how the club actually works. We’ve been members forever. We’ve got this place wired. I could show you around. Maybe we can even catch up with Doris in the next room.”

Even with the mask, Madison knew that look. The last thing she wanted was to be alone with Paul in the club, and that was surely the plan. Melissa might have fallen for this act, but Madison would not. Her alter ego, however, wouldn’t want Paul touching her either.

Madison looked through the wide doorway and across the hallway to the performance room. She heard soft music and the occasional gasp but couldn’t tell what the club members were watching. Still, she did not want to go off with Paul, and doubted Melissa would either.

“We should wait for Dave. That’s my husband. He’s just over at the bar getting drinks.”

They looked over to where Kane leaned one elbow on the bar while a lean, dark-skinned bartender in a black leather vest prepared their drinks. Kane gave a jaunty little wave.

“He’ll be right back,” she added.

Kane watched them from the bar. David Richardson would have rushed over to rescue his wife. He was a standup guy like that, and he cherished his

wife, even if he had a weird kink where he wanted to see someone else fuck her. But Kane was enjoying watching Madison squirm, so he hung back and told the bartender to take his time.

If he were a betting man, and he was, Kane would have put the over/under on someone hitting on Madison when he left her unattended at under five minutes, but no one ran over when he stepped away. The chubby guy chatting her up had taken his sweet time. He probably thought she was out of his league by Kane's reckoning.

He was surprised that no one had approached them in the almost hour they'd been at Nox Venari. The years had done nothing to diminish Madison's beauty. She was even more stunning, if anything. His balls had been aching since he'd walked in on her in the bedroom earlier. Seeing her in that black lace had been too much.

She was still incredibly fit, but she had a layer of softness she probably wouldn't have acquired if she'd stayed in the field like him. With him. He knew he was a little rough with wear from the field, but he didn't think he was so bad either. People should be climbing over each other to fuck us, he thought with a chuckle.

Before Kane could effect Madison's rescue, she rose and walked out of the room with Paul. He was sure she'd blow him off, which made it an interesting turn of events. The jealousy he felt as she left with another man was surprising. She wasn't in any danger—Madison was on comms, and the young prince wasn't even in the club, but Kane thought he should still follow and keep an eye on her. Strictly for professional reasons, he told himself.

The S&M bartender set down their drinks, and Kane was about to go after Madison and Paul when a man stepped in his path. "You're Dave Richardson, if I'm not mistaken. Yes?"

The ornate silver fox mask and the draping black robe meant that it took a minute for the man's identity to register. The fox mask was similar to the Nox Venari symbol, and the name clicked in Kane's mind.

“Anthony Ludolf, right?” Kane replied.

Ludolf smiled. “The masks don’t quite hide our identities as well as some members wish they would. One may opt for a fuller mask, I suppose, but those are cumbersome after too long. Don’t worry, your identity isn’t exposed. I just know when Syma swipes someone into the club.”

“Balaclavas aren’t allowed, I suppose. Or maybe an old school Tricky Dick mask?” Kane replied. He was itching to follow Madison, but he couldn’t afford to blow off the club owner.

Ludolf gestured to the bartender, who poured out a double Jamison neat. “We prefer something with an air of class, though if the Nixon mask was worn for some kind of roleplay, I guess it would work. I’m pleased to see you here so soon. Cora told me about your interview. I assume Melissa is somewhere around?”

Kane wondered how much the icy blonde shared, but didn’t take the bait. The Ludolfs had some form of open marriage, but did Cora have that kind of freedom? The club owner enjoyed watching him work it out and didn’t elaborate.

“She is. Actually, I was just about to join her in the next room. I’m not sure how I feel about her going off on her own just yet,” Kane replied.

“Please, have a drink with me first,” Ludolf said, taking his glass from the bar. “I’d like to celebrate the two of you making such a bold move. I know many would like to explore a place like Nox Venari, but they don’t have the stomach for it. Not surprising that a man in your line of work does.”

“I wouldn’t have gotten very far if I shrank from challenges,” Kane replied, raising his glass. “Or if I didn’t go after the things I want.”

“And what exactly do you want? I know what you told Cora, and I’ve read your application, but neither gets to the core of why you and Melissa are here. People tend to view a place like Nox Venari in many different ways, and often that view is shaped by their own desires. No one is wrong, by the way. Nox Venari can be almost anything you want it to be.”

Kane appeared to seriously consider the question the way a man like David Richardson would. His alter ego was a much more conventional man and wouldn't be apt to spill his secrets to a virtual stranger. Kane kept his thoughts close as well, but for very different reasons. He lived a life of secrets.

Similar in their boldness, Kane and Richardson were nevertheless very different men, and their expectations of a sex club would be just as different. Kane felt deeply, but sex had become almost a sport to him. Fucking and loving were easily split from each other. A place like Nox Venari was like a playground to Kane. David Richardson loved and cherished his wife. He may have had dark fantasies about his wife, but that didn't mean unclenching to indulge them would come easily.

"I just want us to be open to all possibilities," Kane tried.

Ludolf shook his head and grinned. "That's the vague answer from your application. If I may, reading between the lines, I believe there's a specific possibility you want to explore, and it primarily involves Melissa."

David Richardson would not like being called out, but neither would he squirm under Anthony Ludolf's directness. The men locked eyes behind their masks. "I feel like you're implying my wife is a possession, like she doesn't have a say in what we do here. This is not just about me, Anthony. I may have some...interests...I'd like to indulge, but so does Melissa. I didn't drag her here."

"I'm sorry if I insulted you, my friend. I'm sure that your lovely wife has her reasons for being here. I'm only trying to signal that no one will shame you for your kinks here. Many of us crave the excitement of watching our partners enjoy themselves."

"You and Cora?"

"We're not strictly a hotwife couple. Are you familiar with the term? I seek my own pleasures with other women, but I do find great excitement in watching Cora enjoy herself."

Kane made a face. “I don’t like labels. I find them limiting, but yes, I do look forward to watching Melissa indulge herself.”

He knew what a hotwife was and was sure that Richardson would, too. He may have been a conservative, middle-aged man, but David Richardson was a man who did his homework.

“Well, no one will label you here either. I agree they can be limiting. Am I restricted from enjoying chocolate ice cream because I love strawberry? Of course not. However you and Melissa choose to enjoy yourselves, I wish you well. Perhaps I may even help your sweet wife on her journey at some point.”

Kane almost laughed out loud. He thought he must be slipping because he didn’t see it coming. Maybe he was the dinosaur Dentiger thought he was. This asshole wants to fuck Madison, he thought. Does he go through every new application looking for women he wants to screw? It’s probably the whole reason the Ludolfs started this thing. They just got bored with fucking each other. Kane knew that if things had gone differently, he’d never have gotten bored with making love to Madison. Nor would he have needed to bring more people into their bedroom. Watching her do her special kind of work had always been thrilling, but he didn’t need it.

“Thanks, man. I appreciate that. But I think I’d better go and find Mel. She may be feeling vulnerable on her own. And if she’s not, I don’t want to miss a second of it.”

## five

The raven-haired beauty whimpered and panted, pleading for mercy, but it was like a mockingbird's false signal. Her labored moans were thick with pleasure. Perhaps she begged for mercy, but it certainly didn't sound like she wanted to stop. The last thing she wanted was to dismount the massive black cock she was riding; there was no way she could escape the powerful fucking she was receiving. The Black man underneath her was in complete control. Her wrists were bound behind her back, and his large hands guided her hips in time with the rhythm of the sensual music pumping into the room from invisible speakers. They were on display on a bed that rotated slowly on a dais at the center of the Nox Venari showroom, and the room was full of sensual red light.

"Oh god! Please don't..." the woman begged, staring down helplessly at her tormentor before tossing her head back to cry out to the ceiling. The thick waves of raven hair cascaded down to her waist, swaying with the motion of their bodies.

"Don't what?" growled the man beneath her. He reached up to maul one of her swaying, pendulous breasts that were left exposed by the rose-red leather underbust corset. Her breasts were impossibly large for such a slender woman. "Don't stop?"

"I...I...can't take it...please...killing me..."

"Can take it...will take it...desperate slut..."

"No! Nononono...OH FUCK! YES! YES! FUCK ME! USE ME! PLEASE!"

The man's hands were so large that he could hold her hips and still stretch his thumb out to rub her clit. Her shrieks were ear-splitting when she came.



The line between reality and performance was blurred.

“Jesus...” Madison breathed, barely audible over the woman’s moans and the background music. She stood toward the back of the small group with Paul, who crowded close to her. She had seen a lot of things in her spy career, but she’d never seen anything quite like that.

“Valeria is so impressive, isn’t she?” Paul whispered in her ear. “She is a club member, not a hired performer.” His arm settled across the small of her back, and his hand landed on her hip.

“I can’t even imagine. I could never...”

“Not everyone is an exhibitionist like Valeria, but there is an excitement to playing where others can see you. Don’t tell me you’ve never fooled around with the risk of getting caught, Melissa.”

Paul’s touch made her squirm when he caressed her through the sheer portion of her dress, but she didn’t stop him. She wasn’t particularly ticklish. It gave her the good kind of tingles.

“I’ve... Nothing more than necking in the backseat of a car or in the park. Nothing like...this.” She wasn’t so distracted that she forgot to answer as Melissa Richardson.

Madison’s answer would have been very different, but she’d never have gotten on a stage to fuck for strangers. She was skeptical that Valeria was just another Nox Venari member—she knew the club brought in beautiful professionals for their events—but perhaps the club was as libertine as they claimed.

The man beneath Valeria was a perfect specimen, but he may not have been a ringer. Madison thought he was awfully familiar. Is that Casius? The possibility made her gasp. She was glad she didn’t know he was hung like that when they were so close.

The Black man stilled Valeria, but her hips kept churning, confirming the lie that she didn’t want it. Her hips rolled, and she arched her back to jam her

hips onto him. His resonant laugh filled the room. “You want this, don’t you, my eager slut?”

“No...I don’t...can’t...oh god...take it...”

He lifted the bound, masked woman like she was a doll, rolling out from under her like it was choreographed. She wasn’t tossed about, but he wasn’t gentle. Her ass ended up in the air, and her forehead pressed to the mattress. He pulled her into position by her bound wrists. Up on his knees, the enormity of his cock was obvious.

“How long do these things last?” Madison asked, eyes locked on the thick slab of meat pulsing in front of the male performer.

Between Valerie’s excitement coating his shaft and the mood lighting, the dark condom on him was barely visible. Madison had been with big men—both undercover and in her personal life—but the Black man was truly impressive.

“Who is he?” she asked.

“Who can say? A lot of men like him come through here. They’re popular with the women. Is that what you’re looking for, Melissa? I could help smooth your way,” Paul said.

He moved behind her, keeping his hands on her hips. Madison knew she should slip away when he nuzzled through her fiery hair, but the sex show had her so horny that she chose to enjoy the touch. Paul was a man she could handle. She’d apply the brakes when it was time.

“Paul, my husband is around.” The warning was weak. Melissa wouldn’t want to move so quickly, but she would be affected by the sex show just as Madison really was.

On the dais, the man teased Valeria with his thick tool, and she pushed back at it with needy mewling noises. “You need it, don’t you?” His tone was teasing.

“No...I don’t...” the woman cried out. The man slipped the head of his cock into her, but a strong hand on her back kept Valeria from impaling herself. “God...”

“Tell me, and you can have it. Tell me what a needy slut you are. Or should I punish you?”

His big palm landed on her narrow, upturned rear with the crack of a rifle shot. Madison jumped. He was painfully hard, desperate to sink into Valeria, but he maintained such control, a quality that had always impressed Madison. She’d always been too wild for weaker men—until she met Charles. He made her want to tame herself.

“I’m a needy slut...a needy...married...slut... Please...fuck me now... You own my pussy...” Valeria begged.

The man powered his cock into her, and she wailed. Madison gasped. Watching him break Valeria made her core tighten. Paul slid a hand higher to cup the underswell of her breast. She let it stay too long, captivated by the way Valeria was possessed by the massive black cock. The woman shuddered every time he slammed it home. Her tits hung and swayed beneath her. The crowd around them gasped with the sudden violence of their coupling.

Out of the corner of her eye, Madison saw a woman on her knees, serving two men at once. The man on her left was content to receive his blowjob, but the one on her right held the back of her head and forced it deep into her throat. She struggled, but didn’t shove him away. Another woman exposed herself and pulled her companion in to consume her breasts. The crowd around Madison was charged by the sex show and began to give in to their carnal desires. Swept up, Paul more aggressively groped her.

“Paul, you should stop. I don’t want Dave to catch me like this,” she warned, placing her hand over his. She throbbed with desire, but neither Madison nor Melissa wanted him.

“What are you here for, Melissa? I see you watching them. Do you need a man to make you do it, too?”

Kane materialized at their side like she'd summoned him. He noted Paul's hands all over her with a raised eyebrow and a setting of his jaw. Madison did not like the judgment she sensed there. Kane felt many things, but judgment wasn't one of them.

"Honey..." he said, sitting closer.

Madison dug her nails deep into Paul's hand. She kept them embedded when he flinched and loosened his grip. She waited until he hissed with the sting before letting him pull his hand away.

"Dave, sweetheart. Where were you?" she asked, trying to seem flustered as Melissa would be.

"Getting drinks took longer than expected, honey," he replied, handing Madison her cocktail. "Who's your friend?"

"This is, uh, Paul. He's showing me around the club."

"He's showing you something," Kane replied, looking down on the pudgy man. No acting was required. Neither Kane nor Richardson liked that another man presumed to lay hands on what was his.

"Melissa told me you guys were new." Paul's words rushed out. He cradled his sore hand before hiding it at his side.

"We are. That was very friendly of you, Paul. But Mel and I would rather stick together tonight. Isn't that right, honey?"

Madison hated his possessive tone, but still slid into his arm. She downed half of her Negroni. She needed it. "I knew you'd find me," she replied.

"I always do."

"Speaking of finding," Paul said, I'd better go track down my wife. She's in here somewhere. Have a good night, you two." He hurried off.

Valeria shrieked on the dais again, and Kane paused to watch before turning Madison and steering her away. The body language was all the

Richardsons, but the tension between them was all theirs.

“I don’t mind you having your fun, Maddy. Go for it. But I don’t think Melissa would let a man grope her five minutes after arriving at the club,” he hissed.

They reached a corner of the room. Madison ignored the couple slowly, sensually fucking against the wall beside them when she yanked away from Kane.

“How dare you?” she spat back, cheeks as flushed with anger as arousal. “I’m doing my job. I’m not here to get my kicks.”

“Just try to remember your character.”

The spies faced off, the couple beside them oblivious to their conflict. Kane was smug. Madison clenched a fist, debating whether she should throw a punch or just her drink in his face. The sensual, rhythmic music and moans drifting through the room made an odd counterpoint to their disagreement.

“Get yourselves under control, children,” Cassandra warned through their comms. “The Richardsons are a loving couple. Work out your shit on your own time.”

Madison’s nostrils flared, and she fought to control her inner rage. The most infuriating part was that Kane had not changed at all in sixteen years. He was enjoying pissing her off, which only made her want to hit him more. Instead, she downed the rest of her Negroni.

“I need another drink.”

She turned on her heel and walked away from Kane.

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Madison was not a lightweight, but she began to feel the liquor when she was halfway through her third Negroni. The leather-vested bartender poured with a heavy hand to loosen the members' inhibitions. She'd taken a moment to cool down and was back in character, playing the loving wife to Kane's David Richardson. She decided that the easiest way to get through the night was to fully throw herself into playing her role.

They saw shadowy figures of couples in the smaller private lounge when they moved down the first-floor hallway. The room was smaller than the forward lounge that held the bar, and the walls were lined with couches. Beaded curtains partially obscured the couches, but the couples on them weren't hidden. Soft, ambient music floated from the room, nearly cloaking the moans escaping the room.

Kane paused in the doorway, watching the shadows move with interest. In another time, another place, he would have pulled Madison into the lounge and joined the other couples writhing in the dark. Having her while surrounded by other couples would have made the blood sizzle in his veins.

He'd always had a voyeuristic streak, which was why he loved watching Madison work—even when they were sleeping together. He also wanted the others to hear the way he made her moan.

"Do you want to go in, sweetheart?" she asked, holding his hand and pressing the one that held her drink to his shoulder.

"I don't know. Are you ready for that?" he replied, losing himself in the moment and feeling that she was really his—whichever name she was going by.

"To watch, maybe. We couldn't... Not with people around, Dave."

Kane knew she could. She had. He'd seen it. They'd done it. But Melissa hadn't and probably wouldn't. Not yet. "I know, honey. I meant to watch, not to...y'know...do anything."

"We can if you want to..."

“No, let’s keep exploring.” He wasn’t sure he’d be able to behave himself if they went into the shadowy room. If she guessed why he’d decided to keep going, she didn’t say anything.

Hand-in-hand, they ascended to the second floor. Kane looked toward the bedroom where Cora went to her knees, while Madison looked toward the toy room and squeezed his hand tighter to keep it from trembling when she thought about what Casius made her feel in there. The deep-seated need he stirred was even stronger when she thought that he might have been the hung masked man who was making Valeria beg downstairs.

“Anything you want to check out up here?” Kane asked.

Madison smiled. “You could show me where Cora sucked your cock.”

“You’d love that, wouldn’t you?” he chuckled. “I don’t mind showing you the scene of the crime, but that bedroom door is closed.” Most of the doors on the second floor were. The toy room remained open, but it was a public room. And the orgy room was open, of course.

“Oh fuck! Ohhh fuck yes!” The deep, throaty cry came from the toy room.

Madison tugged him toward the noise. The toy room intrigued her the most, and she needed to know what brought that sound out of some anonymous woman. On the way, Cassandra crackled through their comms.

“Peacock has flown the nest. I’ll let you know if he’s headed your way as soon as I know.”

“Roger,” Kane replied.

The news checked Madison’s stride, but she still pulled Kane into the toy room. The room wasn’t crowded, but the handful of people inside were gathered in one corner. The deep rumble of a machine was nearly as loud as the woman they’d heard from the hallway. A woman and three men stood around the Sybian, where an older woman rode the device. Her long, gray hair was swept back, and a colorful bird mask hid her identity. Her cocktail dress was pulled down to her waist, exposing her shaking, low-hanging tits.

“What the fuck?” Manny marveled over comms. “She’s like a GILF or something... Riding a fuck machine... Goddam!”

“Keep the comms clear,” Cassandra scolded.

It wasn’t the Wizard’s first inappropriate utterance over comms. He’d been stunned by the sex show when Madison had walked into the room downstairs.

“I’m starting to think you don’t watch enough porn, which is weird to say,” Dentiger laughed.

“I said, keep the comms clear, dammit,” Cassandra stressed.

The Sybian controller, a bulky box tethered to the machine by a thick cable, was held by a man who watched with glee as he adjusted the dials. Another, younger man stood by the gray-haired woman’s side, and she jerked him off aggressively, even though her focus seemed to be on the Sybian controlling her body.

A third man, older than the others, watched, leaning against the wall with his cock out. His age meant he was most likely to be her husband. His eyes never left the woman riding the Sybian. A thick, Black young woman in pink lingerie leaned against him and played with his shaft while whispering in his ear. He nodded and licked his lips. His small, satin harlequin mask didn’t hide his leer.

“Jesus. What the fuck is that?” Kane marveled. He kept a tight hold of Madison’s hand. He’d seen a lot of things, but nothing like that.

“Some crazy sex machine. How can she even handle that?” she replied, unaware of how the breathy whisper made her sound.

“I bet you could take it. Should I put a quarter in it so you get a turn?”

Madison laughed. “It’s not a Pac-Man machine.”

“But you didn’t answer me.”



“Sweetheart, stop it. Not in front of all of these people...”

She slipped her hand out of Kane’s to get a closer look. Watching a woman like that surrender herself to the machine was fascinating. She remained behind the group gathered around the Sybian, sipping her Negroni as she watched the older woman lose her mind on the machine. The man in control dialed it down to a low rumble, letting the woman pant and catch her breath. She leaned forward, hands on her thighs, rolling her hips against the machine, making her heavy tits hang down. After a beat, the Sybian was turned up again, and she tensed, closing her eyes tight to focus.

Madison would have been truly stunned if she’d known the woman was Jacqueline van Houtton, the headmistress of a prestigious Connecticut private school. The mother of five—and grandmother of two—was a pillar of her community, a former Girl Scout leader and women’s choir member. And, apparently, a filthy-mouthed nymphomaniac.

“Fuck yes! More! Turn it up! Fuuuck... Ruin me, you bastard!” Jacqueline shouted.

The spectacle touched something deep inside Madison. She didn’t know the woman by name, but she understood who Jacqueline van Houtton was—a powerful woman. And Madison understood that the woman had turned herself over to the Sybian and given control of it to someone else. Deep down, she understood the craving to let someone else just take control. Part of her wanted to see what the Sybian could do to her, but she was afraid of how much control she might give up if she truly let go. That had always been her greatest fear.

“I’d kill to see you on that,” Kane breathed in her ear. It was the side without the comms earwig, and he whispered low enough that it wouldn’t be heard under the roar of the Sybian.

“Stop it. I’d never subject myself to that. That’s...insane. Look at her,” Madison responded, shifting in her heels and squeezing her thighs together without even realizing it.

“But you want to. It’s written all over you.” He ran his hand down her side. She trembled and bit her bottom lip. Kane still knew how to touch her, even after so many years apart.

“It might be interesting... Wild... But no... That would be insane. Look at her.”

“Yeah, look at her. That thing is scrambling her goddam brain. Tell me you don’t want to come like that, honey.”

“Fuck! Fuck! Too much! It’s too much... Oh fuck! Please! Don’t stop! Breaking me...”

Jacqueline screeched and lurched on the Sybian, another orgasm scrambling her brain. The man being jerked off by the Black woman—her husband, attorney William van Houtton—growled, “Take it, darling! Show them who you really are!”

“I’m... I’m a... Oh fuck, I’m a helpless harlot... Need it... Oh, fuck, I need it... Break me! Fuck!”

Madison gasped and leaned back into Kane. She told herself they were playing the Richardsons, and it was appropriate, but it felt like they were Madison and Kane. He caressed her through that sheer lace panel in her dress, and his touch ignited sparks she couldn’t deny.

“Baby...” she whimpered. Madison used to call him baby. That wasn’t Melissa. She corrected, “Sweetheart... it might be fun... what if I can’t handle it...”

“But you want to,” he whispered, his stubble brushing her cheek. She leaned into it. It was so easy to get lost with him. Dangerously lost.

*I’m playing Melissa, she insisted to herself. “Maybe... If I were alone...”*

“No, honey. You want someone to control it. You need someone to control it. I’d love to...”

Kane began inching her dress up her thighs. She weakly pushed it down.

“Honey...Dave...we shouldn’t...not in front of these people...mmm...”

“Tell me, honey...Mel...you want someone else to control it...you...don’t you?”

Madison bit her lip and nodded. Kane was whispering in her free ear, but she’d suddenly remembered that the team could hear her end on comms. The dress slid high on her thighs. She’d let him touch her. Her thighs relaxed. His hand was hot on her tummy. It moved lower. He felt her heat. His fingertips curled under the hem of her dress to pull it just a little higher. They grazed the black lace of her panties. Madison swooned, told herself it was Melissa.

“Peacock is on his way to you. Confirm. Peacock is on his way. I can’t hear anything over that damn sex machine,” Cassandra said in their ears.

“Roger. ETA?” Kane asked, raising his voice to be heard on comms. He sounded cool as ever, but he never stopped touching Madison. She stiffened when he added pressure to her mound.

“Less than ten,” Cassandra answered.

“Got it. We’re ready,” Madison said, clearing her throat to force a normal tone into her voice. Her hips shifted, pushing her pussy back at his hand. She thanked god for the barrier of her panties. She wanted Kane to rip them away.

“Make sure you’re in his path when he arrives,” Cassandra ordered.

“We know what we’re doing,” Madison snapped. She had no idea what she was doing, letting Kane touch her like that. She’d been resolved to behave at Nox Venari unless circumstances demanded otherwise.

“Sorry to tear you away from the senior sex show,” Dentiger chuckled in their ears.

“Fuck off,” Kane growled, well-aware that Jacqueline was probably less than ten years his senior. She was a sexy, mature woman. He wouldn’t have

minded a tumble, unless the machine really ruined her.

Madison abruptly turned in his arms and thrust her tongue into his mouth. Kane stiffened, so stunned he nearly toppled backwards. She grabbed him through his tuxedo pants, making him grunt into their kiss. She channeled all of her hunger into the kiss, giving him a moment to kiss back before she ended it. Panting, she nibbled on his ear, the one without the earwig, and whispered to him.

“That was Melissa kissing Dave. Don’t think it’s anything else, and don’t get used to it.” She pulled back and kissed him again, more of a loving wife’s kiss than an I need you to fuck me right now kiss. Madison knew that their cameras couldn’t capture a thing when their bodies were pressed so close together. “Dave, sweetheart, I need another drink.”

Kane kissed her back, slow, sensual, drawn out. Madison hated the need that welled up inside her. “Sure, honey. You do look thirsty.”

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Parking themselves near the bar in the lounge, they were perfectly positioned to intercept Zaydan when he arrived at Nox Venari. Madison sipped her fourth Negroni. She was already tipsy; she blamed that on the effect that being was having on her and decided she had to slow down. Switching to water would have made more sense, but a nervous Melissa would probably keep drinking.

Kane stayed at her side, a possessive arm around his wife. Madison may have become a respectable soccer mom in the intervening years, but he could still read her. She’d always been drawn to the darker, edgier side of her sexuality, and being in Nox Venari was pulling that out of her. Kane thought he could have her if he pushed it. Madison’s panties were soaked when he touched them. He badly wanted her, but he didn’t want to take her.

He told himself he was trying to respect her marriage. When he fucked Madison, it would be because she came to him.

“Peacock is landing. He’s right outside,” Cassandra informed them.

“Got it,” Madison replied.

“Do peacocks even fly?” Kane mused.

“Does it matter?” Madison replied, giving him an annoyed look.

“Just wondering.”

“Yes, they can fly short distances, but they don’t migrate or anything,” Manny chimed in over comms.

“Focus, people,” Cassandra snapped. “He’s walking up the front steps now. Rami is with him.” Rami was Zaydan’s ever-present bodyguard.

“I was hoping he’d leave the goon in the car,” Madison muttered.

“I’m surprised they let him in here. Nox Venari has its own security,” Kane added.

“The rules are always bent for the privileged, aren’t they?” Madison said.

Madison moved toward the hallway. They couldn’t assume that Zaydan would come into the lounge, and she wanted to arrange a meet-cute to get on the board with him. Kane hung back. It wouldn’t do to have Melissa’s husband lingering.

She tried to prepare herself for the possibility that the prince would be so taken with her—a silly notion—that he would try to sweep her right into one of the bedrooms and fuck her. Melissa would never move so fast, but Madison was so horny that it would be a struggle to behave. She locked in on Charles. He was her North Star. She might have to sleep with Zaydan at some point, but she didn’t have to give in tonight.

The curtain was swept aside, and Zaydan strode into the hallway. Even with the black leather Harlequin mask—which seemed custom-molded to his features—the prince was strikingly handsome. Madison knew he was an attractive man, but she wasn't quite prepared for his presence. His rich brown skin was flawless, his thick black hair swept straight into a pompadour that hung past his collar, and his beard was full but impeccably trimmed.

The black tuxedo jacket had a subtle, intricate violet pattern that only showed when the light caught it just right. His black silk shirt was open at the collar, allowing dark hair to peek out. Zaydan looked like he was born to wear the custom-tailored tuxedo. He even smelled good when Madison got close enough to catch his sandalwood scent.

Zaydan turned toward the steps, and Madison tripped forward into his path. Her Negroni splashed his jacket—a test to see what sort of man he was. Rami swiftly moved around the prince—impressive for a man built like a living tank—and snagged her by the arm. The grip made her wince. He roughly yanked her away from his charge. Kane set his drink down and began to move out of the lounge.

“Ow!” Madison exclaimed, no acting required. She tried to pull her arm away, but it was locked in Rami's grip.

“Rami, please,” Zaydan said, putting a hand on his bodyguard's chest. His rich voice carried an English prep school accent.

“Boss, she came out of nowhere,” Rami complained, releasing her arm.

Madison stepped back, tossing her flaming locks. She felt a charge down to her core when she locked eyes with the prince.

“Does this look like an assassin to you, Rami?” Zaydan said, offering the most radiant, cocksure grin she'd ever seen.

“That hurt,” Madison said, offended, rubbing her arm.

“I apologize for Rami. He can be overzealous. Are you injured?”

Zaydan held Madison with one hand on her hip, while the other caressed where she throbbed from the bodyguard's steel grip. His soft, tender touch stirred a throbbing deeper inside her. She didn't have to fake her reactions to the prince.

Madison glared at Rami. Melissa Richardson would be outraged at being manhandled. "Teach your gorilla some manners," she griped, keeping contact with Zaydan's impossibly deep, dark eyes. The anger was already melting away.

"This was an outrage, of course. I do not like to see any woman roughly handled against her will." Zaydan was just as captivated by Madison's clear blue eyes. He only briefly glanced away to take in her curves, and he liked those even more. "Rami," he snapped.

The bodyguard's jaw set, but he bowed his head. "Ma'am, my humblest apologies. I should not have laid hands on you."

"I am expected upstairs, but I hope you will allow me to make this right. If you are still around and available when I come down, may I buy you a drink?"

Madison managed a flirty smile. "Aren't the drinks free? It's an open bar."

"Point taken. Will you share a drink with me anyway..." He paused, fishing for her name.

"Melissa."

"Melissa. Such a lovely name. Will you share a drink with me later?" He kept his hands on her. She didn't try to remove them. He also didn't offer his own name.

"Maybe I'm insulted that I can't hold your interest right now. I can only imagine what you need to rush off to in a place like this."

Zaydan stepped closer and dropped his voice to a whisper. "Trust me, Melissa. I know our meeting will be the highlight of my evening, even

under such tumultuous circumstances. I hope another suitor hasn't swept you up before I return."

His beard was downy soft when he kissed her cheek. His full lips were even softer. Melissa swooned. Madison told herself it was all Melissa.

"Come find me...if I'm available," she teased.

Kane and the security guard arrived at the same moment. The guard spoke first. "Is there a problem here, sir?"

"Just a misunderstanding. Nothing to be concerned about, but thank you. You may return to your post," Zaydan said. Rami glared at the guard over his shoulder, offended that anyone would think his charge needed any help other than him.

"Mel, honey, are you alright? Did something happen?" Kane said, holding Madison's other side.

Madison felt supercharged and awkward between them. Kane was trying to play the concerned husband, but she felt the energy between the men. It was rams facing off, not two polite, professional men concerned over her.

"I'm fine, sweetheart. It's fine. I just stumbled, and..." She paused to allow Zaydan to offer his name. He didn't. "And this lovely man came to my assistance. Everything is okay. Isn't it?" She looked to the prince.

He held her gaze. "Exactly right. Just a minor incident. I'm glad I was here to assist your lovely wife, sir." He didn't ask Kane's name. It was irrelevant.

"Your jacket," she fussed, brushing at the brocade.

Zaydan placed his hand over hers. "Please, Melissa, don't give it a thought. No damage has been done. But now, I really must be going." He gave a cursory look at Kane, squeezed Madison's hand, and added, "I truly do hope to see you again tonight. But now I really must be away."

With another kiss on her cheek, he was gone, disappearing up the stairs with Rami close behind. Kane glared at his back. A genuine smile lingered on



Madison's lips.

"Mission accomplished," Kane muttered.

"It's a start," she replied, not entirely hating the buzz Zaydan instilled in her. She felt like a schoolgirl meeting her crush for the first time. This one could be trouble, she thought, wondering if it would truly be a betrayal of Charles if she enjoyed her work just a little bit.

## six

Back at the condo in Philadelphia, Madison exchanged Melissa Richardson's wedding ring for her own and powered on her phone to check messages. Charles had called twice and texted several times. Madison wanted more than anything to call him back, but it was nearly three in the morning. He would not be awake. She'd have to find a way to make it up to him. All she wanted to do was peel off her dress, take a shower, and slip into bed. She would catch the Acela back to D.C. sometime the next day.

When Prince Zaydan came down the steps, he went right out of the club without looking for Madison. Cassandra said not to worry because they'd made first contact, and that was progress, but Madison couldn't help but feel offended that he didn't seek her out. She felt silly, but she wanted the handsome young prince to want her.

A long, hot shower turned out to be just the thing she needed. After peeling off her Nox Venari costume, she stood under the shower in the expensive condo and let the steaming water melt the night away. It wasn't planned, but part of letting it all go and becoming herself again meant releasing all the sexual tension Nox Venari stirred in her. Madison took the shower massage wand from its mount and moved it between her legs.

The three pulsing jets pounded right above her mound, and the initial spike of pleasure was so powerful that she swayed on her feet and leaned against the cool tile wall. She gasped and pulled the massager back while she caught her breath. Madison hadn't been so desperately horny in such a long time. Those recent episodes when she attacked Charles, or when she rushed to get off after her first visit to Nox Venari with Kane, didn't compare.

Madison maneuvered the shower wand back down, but used her hand as a barrier this time. The water jets vibrated her fingers when she touched her clit. She whimpered and bit her bottom lip. Closing her eyes, she thought of

that dark-haired woman, Valeria, riding the masked man who Madison was convinced was Casius. His cock was enormous, and Valeria obviously loved every thick inch of it. Making love to her husband was wonderful, but no man had made Madison come like that in years.

And then there was the kiss she shared with Kane. When Melissa kissed Dave in her mind. The flood of arousal that the kiss brought happened to Madison, not Melissa. She could rationalize it all she wanted, but the chemistry with Kane was still there, even after sixteen years.

She withdrew her hand, losing the barrier between the shower wand's punishing jets and her pussy. The hot water beat directly onto her hooded clit. Biting back a sharp cry, she came in a rush so sudden it took her breath away. She saw colors behind her closed eyes as her body tensed like she'd been electrocuted.

The intense force of the jets kept the orgasm searing through her, and Madison rode it until the sensations were just too strong. She dropped the wand, letting it swing on the hose, the jets beating against the glass door of the walk-in shower with a threatening rhythm.

Madison slid down the wall to sit on the rough shale tile floor. The thick steam made it difficult to breathe, and she liked it. She felt like she should be punished for the thoughts that made her come. They were not thoughts of Charles.

Afterward, she strolled into the bedroom with a fluffy towel wrapped around her body and another wrapped around her hair. She was setting an alarm on her phone when she heard a light rap of knuckles on the door.

"Yes?" she said softly, leaning against it from the other side.

"Can we talk?" It was Kane.

"Is this something that can't wait?" She was aware that Manny was downstairs in the living room and didn't want him to know she was letting Kane into her room in the middle of the night. Cassandra and Dentiger had left for their hotel rooms.

“Maddy... Just... Can we talk for a minute?”

Madison sighed and opened the door.

Kane was surprised by the sight of his former lover wrapped in a towel. He'd seen her that way so many times, but never thought he'd see it again. He'd thought he'd never see Madison again.

*Did she open the door because she's getting comfortable with me? He knew it was more likely because the Madison he knew wasn't fussy or modest like that. She hadn't covered up when he walked in on her in her underwear at the beginning of the night. That image was still locked into his head.*

“What do you want, Damien?” she asked as he passed by her. She closed the door behind him.

“Maddy...”

He paused because seeing all of that pale flesh on display was quite the distraction. The towel around her body barely came to mid-thigh and had slipped low on her breasts. Her décolletage was more freckled than he remembered, as were her cheeks and nose now that she was scrubbed clean of makeup. Strands of flame hair escaped the towel turban, darkened by their dampness. Looking at her fresh-faced like that, Kane felt like no time had passed at all since Madison walked out on him in London.

“Tonight got weird, right?” he finally said with a chuckle.

She smiled. “Well, you know, I don't get to nearly as many sex shows as I used to, so that thing on the dais was interesting.” She tucked an errant strand of hair back into the towel, and Kane noted she was wearing her own diamond-crusted wedding ring again.

“No? The kids' soccer club hasn't staged a sex show as a fundraiser? No sex clubs there in the D.C. suburbs?”

“I'm sure there must be at least one swingers' club in the District. I wouldn't know. Probably some house parties in McLean. Again, I'd have no

idea. I doubt any of the people we socialize with are into that.”

“Hey, you never know. I bet a lot of people would say that about the couples we saw at Nox Venari tonight.”

Madison laughed. “Probably, but trust me, the people we know are not like that. I couldn’t even imagine it. God, I wouldn’t want to.”

“I’m sure no one thinks the Richardsons would go to a place like Nox Venari.”

“You mean if they were real? I’m sure you’re right. I mean, there’s less than zero chance Charles and I would ever go to a place like that.”

“Of course,” he agreed, cooling at the mention of her husband.

She walked to the windows overlooking Rittenhouse Square and peeked between the drawn curtains. Kane admired the way the towel barely covered her ass. She didn’t realize he could see the curves of her cheeks, or she never would have turned her back on him. Or invited him into the bedroom.

“Tonight couldn’t have been so shocking for you. The Agency must send you to all kinds of seedy places.”

“Yeah, seedy places, but not sex clubs for the rich and powerful. Crazy shit went down at Nox Venari, but it’s hardly seedy. If you want seedy, I’ve got some dives I could take you to. I even know a couple right here in Philly.”

“I’m sure you do. I think you know every dive bar in the world.”

Kane winced at her dismissive tone. “You’re not so removed from dives yourself, Maddy. I knew you when you were still fresh out of Southie, before you were the Queen of McLean. I know just how much you love to get down and dirty.”

She turned on him. “Is that why you knocked on my door? To remind me that I came from white trash?” Her eyes narrowed.

“No. I didn’t come here to fight.” He held up his hands.

“Then why are you here, Damien? The sun will be up in a couple of hours. This isn’t the time for a walk down memory lane.”

“I just wanted to make sure you’re good with everything. Not the Nox Venari stuff. I know you can handle yourself in a place like that. You couldn’t have changed that much.”

“Thanks, I think.”

“I mean, I’m not playing the white in shining armor. But the other stuff. Playing the Richardsons. I wanted to make sure you were okay with that. Do you want to talk about what happened at Nox Venari?”

“I’m not sure what you mean, Damien.” She stiffened. “This isn’t the first time I’ve pretended to be in love with someone. In a couple. I’m a bit rusty, but it really wasn’t that hard. I have actual experience being a wife now... being in a normal, functional couple. You don’t need to worry that playing house is going to scramble my head.”

Kane was hurt by how matter-of-fact she was. “Maddy, we’re not just two officers they threw together. When you kissed me...”

“I was playing a role, Damien.”

“And when I touched you? Don’t give me the playing a role bullshit. You reacted to my touch the way you always did. That wasn’t you just pretending to be Melissa.”

“It was a physiological response in a sexually heightened atmosphere. It wasn’t about you or our history.”

Kane stepped closer to her, infuriated by her refusal to admit what he knew he’d felt. What he knew was true. Madison could pretend that the years had erased whatever they’d had, but it was a lie, and he wouldn’t go along with it. He didn’t grab her arm like he did the last time they had this argument, but they were inches apart.

She shrank back from him for a moment, then mustered herself and defiantly got in his face. "I'm not going to tell you what you want to hear just because your ego needs it, Damien. We're both supposed to be professionals. It wasn't about you. It was the job."

"I felt how wet you were, Maddy. Was that professional?"

"You didn't even touch me there." She stiffened.

"I didn't need to. The heat was fucking radiating from your pussy, just like it always did. You're a sexual woman. It's not a complaint."

"Don't... Don't talk to me like that. You don't get to do that. Besides, I'm not the girl you knew. I don't even recognize her anymore."

Heat came off Madison in waves, and it prickled Kane's skin like he was standing in front of a bonfire. Her towel hung even lower, and she was flushed crimson from her cheeks to the slopes of her breasts. She shifted from foot to foot, and the knot loosened with every motion. He marshalled every shred of willpower to keep from reaching for her.

"I know who's standing in front of me, and goddam it, Maddy, you're more beautiful than ever. It's like not a day has passed." The words slipped out.

"Damien..."

As if it were nudged by the hand of God, the knot on her towel gave way at that exact moment, and the fluffy white fabric dropped to puddle at her feet. They were both so startled by Madison's sudden nudity that they just stood there motionless. Kane stared at all of her glorious, naked flesh, and she stared at him staring. His cock had been rising since he walked into the room and saw her in the towel, but it surged into steely hardness in a second.

Madison began to bend down and grab the towel, but all it took was a gentle touch on her shoulder to stop her. She looked up at Kane, and he saw the fear and raw desire in her eyes. Her tits hung heavier than he

remembered, but all of her curves were rounder now, sexier. He nudged her shoulder, and she straightened, those tits brushing his chest.

“Damien...” It was low and breathy that time, more of a plea than a warning.

“Maddy...”

Kane hauled her closer, and she gasped when he hungrily kissed her. Madison didn’t hesitate like she had when he first kissed her, not a week ago. She stood on tiptoes and leaned into him, hands coming up to hold his face while she pressed her tongue into his mouth. He would have enjoyed being right if he hadn’t been so distracted by having her lush, naked body pressed against him.

Her doubts and anger were all forgotten when Kane kissed her. The anger wasn’t quite forgotten, but it fed her passion. Madison just reacted, as she had when he touched her in Nox Venari. She came hard in the shower, but it wasn’t enough. She needed to be touched. And as much as she wanted to deny it, Kane still triggered the same chemical reaction in her that he always had.

His calloused hands were rough and warm on the soft skin of her back, then her firm, round ass. They were not the hands of a lawyer—the hands of her husband. The print on his old Black Flag t-shirt was scratchy on her nipples. Warning bells went off in the back of her mind, but feeling Kane’s hands on her, his tongue slipping into her mouth, robbed her of common sense. Her hands slipped from his face to grip his t-shirt and pull him tightly against her. She nipped at his lower lip, and he attacked with his tongue.

Madison pulled at his t-shirt, but it was a struggle because his hands were all over her bare breasts. She paused, moaning deeply, when his rough fingers rolled her tips, thickening them with desire. He massaged her breasts, and she pushed into his hands. Damn her, she wanted it. She needed it.

Kane reluctantly took his hands from her body long enough to tear his t-shirt over his head and fling it away. When he grabbed her again, he steered



Madison toward the bed with his hands on her hips while they furiously kissed. Her long, red nails raked through his graying chest hair. Her tits gave an alluring bounce when she sat on the edge of the bed, and he couldn't resist them. The rougher he kneaded them, the more she wanted it. Her hands covered his, but not to pull them away.

"Oh god, Damien..." She moaned when he knelt in front of her and buried his face in her chest.

The pleasure that radiated from his hungry mouth on her supple, heavy breasts stole Madison's ability to reason. Holding Kane to her chest, pushing her tits into his mouth, was so wrong, but she couldn't care. When he sucked and drew her swollen, dark pink tip out, ecstasy shot through her, making her core tighten in anticipation of being filled. He went from one breast to the other—over and over—his teasing mouth making her want to scream for more. Madison barely held back from crying, God, Damien, fuck me!

Kane kissed his way down her tummy, and Madison was all too aware of the pooch that wasn't there the last time he saw her naked. It didn't matter how hard she worked out—after two kids, it was never going away. He didn't seem to notice, like she was still perfect to him.

Palms flat on her thighs, he pushed them apart.

"Damien...wait...we shouldn't..." The words came out between halting gasps. And then he brushed his lips down her landing strip, and the caution died.

Kane spread her open with his thumbs, and his tongue darted in for a taste. Madison stiffened and immediately melted. The burst of her tangy arousal reminded him of why he'd been addicted to going down on her all those years ago.

"Ahhh...Dam...yesss..."

Madison raked her nails through his hair, so much grayer than the last time he was down there. His curious tongue pressed deep, exploring every

intimate part of her. It electrified her pussy everywhere it touched. She felt so exposed to him, but then he lifted one of her legs over his shoulder, opening her even wider. She cried out and bowed her back, trying to find a way to lift her pussy to his hungry mouth.

It was right at that moment that her wedding band caught the light from the bedside lamp and glinted—a beacon to her adultery. Madison couldn't tell herself she was playing Melissa Richardson as Kane went down on her in that bedroom. They weren't performing for anyone but each other. She began a moaned warning, trying to tell him they had to stop, but he pushed on her stomach and she just lay back on the bed, allowing him to lift her other leg over his shoulder, too. She was fully open to him, and he feasted.

The towel came loose from her head as she tossed it back and forth on the mattress. The spill of fiery hair against the white towel was striking. Madison hooked her legs on his shoulders for leverage to grind her pelvis back at Kane. His tongue worked deep while his lips were always kissing, sucking. The technique was sloppy, undisciplined, but it drove her wild.

“Yesss...oh god...Damien...don't...don't stop...ahhh god...”

Kane had no intention of stopping. He was a man with a mission. She was losing it, and he was proud to be the author of her undoing. He was determined to prove he could make her come as hard as he ever had—harder than her husband, a man he'd never met. He shifted his focus to her clit, tongue dancing across it while he intensely sucked. She was sopping and pulled his fingers right into her. He drove those fingers hard, fucking her hard enough to fill the bedroom with wet noises. Kane stared up from between her legs, between her breasts, but she wouldn't meet his eyes. It was a reminder that she belonged to someone else.

“Ohhh fuck...yesss...yesss...YES!”

Madison kicked her heels into his back when she came, twisting on the bed while locking her thighs tightly around Kane's head. He couldn't breathe, but he never stopped licking her pussy. The intensity of her orgasm made his balls ache. Her arousal had always been his perfect aphrodisiac.

Even when he'd listened to her—or even better, watched her—with other men during their missions, he'd been filled with a potent lust for her that he couldn't control. Their first time together had been after he'd watched her seduce a Belgian arms dealer in Helsinki. Kane had wanted her so badly that he couldn't keep his hands off her. Their attraction had been growing for a while, and that had been the spark it needed to explode. The Frenchman had been a poor lover, leaving Madison with a deep need for a real fucking.

“Damien...Dame...please...stop...too much...it's...too much...”

Kane couldn't stop. He had to have her. She finally pulled one of her legs back, locked her heel on his shoulder, and shoved him back with such force that he nearly fell on his ass. He leaned back and smiled at what a panting mess he'd turned her into.

“Can't breathe...damn it...Damien...”

“Worth it,” he replied, wiping his damp mouth on the back of his hand.

“Cocky bastard...”

Madison lay on her back, legs dangling over the side of the bed, still open. He stared at her glistening sex and couldn't hold back. Kane stood and pushed his sweatpants down. Her eyes widened at the thick cock that bobbed in front of him.

“Damien...wait...” she implored, catching her breath. She held out a hand.  
“Don't...”

“Don't what? Are you still pretending you don't want to fuck me, Maddy?”  
He stepped closer.

“It's not about want.”

She sat up on the bed, feeling too vulnerable, sitting there naked in front of him. The way Kane looked at her made her want to give in to him again.

The only reason she didn't cover herself was that she refused to give him the satisfaction.

"So, you remember your scruples after I make you come? That's convenient."

"I didn't invite you in here. And I didn't ask you to go down on me."

"Sorry I made you come so hard. I'm a real asshole."

Madison stared at his cock. She couldn't not. It was there, right in front of her, as thick as she remembered. She tried not to remember—remember the way it used to fill her, the way it could make her come over and over again. Back then, Kane could fuck for hours. She missed being fucked for hours.

Madison still twitched with aftershocks of the orgasm he'd just given her, but she ached to be filled. Part of her wanted to know if they really still had that old magic—the part of her that had always been self-destructive. Madison thought she'd buried that side of her, but being around Kane brought it right back to the surface. She forced herself to look into his steel gray eyes.

"I can't fuck you. I'm sorry that I let this get out of control. I know it sucks that I'm leaving you..." She looked back at his dick again. It was dripping. "...like that. I didn't mean to be a cocktease."

"You were always so good at it."

"Seriously, I'm sorry, Damien. But you need to leave. We can't. I can't. I've already..." She couldn't bring herself to say the word cheated. "...crossed a line. Tonight was a lot. Let's not make it worse."

Kane snorted. "Worked out pretty well for you. Whatever. Fuck you, Maddy."

"Damien... I'm sorry."

He pulled up his pants, found his t-shirt, and stormed out of the bedroom.

“Fuck,” Madison sighed, falling back onto the bed.

## seven

The Acela from 30th Street Station in Philadelphia back to Union Station in D.C. took an eternity. Madison didn't expect such a full train on a Saturday morning, but her icy hostility ensured the seat next to her stayed vacant. Her hair was pulled back into a tight ponytail, and she wore no makeup. In a black t-shirt and leggings, she looked like she was on her way to her own funeral.

Cassandra was pissed when she saw Madison packed up to leave as she walked into the Rittenhouse Square condo. The handler wanted to do a debrief with the team, but Madison assured her that Kane could handle that. She'd quipped that she'd barely met the prince and the Russians hadn't been there anyway, so what was there to debrief? Cassandra tried to insist she stay, but Madison stood her ground, saying something had come up and she had to get home. She wasn't going to tell their boss that Kane's cock was the thing that had come up. She said she would be reachable by phone if they had any questions.

When she got out of the Uber at home in McLean, Charles's SUV wasn't in the driveway. She realized the family was at Penny's soccer game. She was in a morbid mood, and as she set her bags down in the dim, still house, Madison wondered if that was what it would be like if the family left her. The guilt over what she'd done with Kane was crushing.

Madison was still wide awake when the sun had come through the bedroom windows in Philadelphia. She'd still been as exhausted as she'd been when Kane walked into that bedroom, but her brain was too charged to sleep when he'd left. She still felt traces of the heat he'd stoked in her, but that was overwhelmed by guilt when she finally had a moment to think. She'd never felt those conflicting emotions before.

Alone in the dark, she'd tried to justify her actions by telling herself that it was all part of the case. That she was doing the best she could, given the extraordinarily strange circumstances she found herself in. As a younger woman, she'd been very good at self-justification, but mature Madison saw right through it.

She was bone tired, but she couldn't stay in the oppressive silence by herself. The photographs of the family that she'd hung on the wall up the way upstairs stared at her like an accusation. They were potent reminders of everything she was putting at risk.

Madison had no choice but to accept some risks to stop the Kharabatis from getting their hands on Null:Echo, but fooling around with Kane on the side was not any part of that. It was a moment of weakness. I was exhausted and horny, and I wasn't thinking. I'd never do that if I were in my right mind. I won't put myself in that position again. The protestations sounded empty, even to her. She could only imagine how she'd react if she found out that Charles had cheated and tried to use those excuses.

After changing into jeans and a cute top, she threw on some makeup to conceal her exhaustion and drove over to the neighborhood sports complex. The game was about halfway through when she arrived. She was scanning the stands for Charles and Chazz when she saw her friend, Sarah van Holt.

"Where have you been hiding?" Sarah asked, pulling her into a hug. Madison clung to her friend for a beat too long, grateful for the comfort of the familiar.

"I have a special project at work. It's been demanding all of my time." She'd also been avoiding Sarah ever since the woman's husband, Bill, made a pass at her during their shared snack bar duty.

"I hope it's at least something you enjoy and not terribly boring."

"It's a new challenge," Madison admitted, recalling how hard Kane made her come just a few hours earlier. It was terribly wrong, but fell under the enjoyment category.

Sarah held her at arm's length and said, "You really have been burning the candle at both ends. Have you been sleeping at all?"

"Is that your nice way of telling me I look terrible?" Madison laughed. Only a close friend could get away with telling you something like that.

Cocking her head and making a quizzical face, Sarah said, "Come on, now. You're always gorgeous, Maddy. Even when you're tired. I don't think you could look bad if you wanted to."

"That's sweet, but it's bullshit. Thank you, anyway. And I'd kill for your skincare routine. You don't have a line on your face."

"Right. Also bullshit, but thank you," Sarah laughed.

Madison was envious of her friend. Sarah looked a decade younger than Madison, even though they were only separated by a few years. Sarah was softer, with a rounder face that filled out the lines that came with age. She was a stay-at-home mom with school-age children, and she had plenty of time for rest and yoga, and tennis lessons, but Madison wouldn't change places with her friend for anything. Charles made enough that she could stay home, but that had never interested her.

"We need another couples' night soon. It's been ages. I know Bill would love to see you guys. He's here somewhere."

"This work thing has me incredibly tied up right now, but as soon as this project is over, I promise we'll get something on the calendar."

Madison smiled thinly. She knew precisely how Bill van Holt wanted to see her. The way Kane saw her last night. Or maybe on all fours. He probably didn't want to see Charles so much. He had to assume that she'd told her husband. She wanted to tell Sarah what a creep she was married to, but it would crush her friend.

The women parted, and Madison found Charles in the stands. Apologizing with every step, she squeezed past the other parents watching the game to find a space beside her husband. The stands were unusually crowded. Too



many workaholic parents in the well-off Washington suburb missed games and activities because they couldn't tear themselves away from work. Sure, she was one of those parents at the moment, but she was there now.

"Hey, I didn't think I'd see you here," Charles said, taking her hand and kissing her cheek. Chazz sat on his other side, face buried in his phone. He was not a sports kid.

"I got out of there early. I wanted to get back to you guys. Can't say hello, Chazz?"

"Hey, Mom." He didn't look up from his phone.

Charles gently elbowed his son. "Don't ignore your mother. We've raised you better than that."

"Oh, hi, Mom! Hope your work trip was awesome!" He poured the sarcasm on thick. That's my boy, she thought. Chazz was smart and sensitive, but sharp as a tack.

"I hope you didn't work through the night to get home," Charles said, stroking her cheek.

Madison laughed. "If one more person tells me I look tired..."

"That's not really what I meant, honey."

The stands erupted, forcing their attention back to the game. Penny's team scored a goal, the first point of the game, and the parents were excited that something had finally happened.

Madison was thrilled for the distraction. She felt squirmy sitting next to Charles, like he could somehow sense what she'd done. In her mind, the scarlet A had already been stuck to her chest. It was just invisible to her. Living with having let another man touch her was harder than she expected.

The guilt was a weight that just sat in the pit of her stomach, but she would find a way to get rid of it. She had to. She had no intention of burdening Charles with the knowledge of what she'd done. Confession would be

selfish. Besides, anything that happened within the bounds of the mission was classified. That was what Madison kept telling herself.

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The family went to lunch at Red Robin afterward, and Charles sensed his wife was ill at ease. It was becoming a common occurrence, especially when she came home from those work trips. Later, watching Madison play a board game with the kids while he watched baseball, he saw the same wariness and tension in her. She never carried that kind of tension in her shoulders. He hated that she wasn't herself.

Ignoring the truth of her employment hadn't been an issue in their marriage. There had been times she came home disturbed by something she wouldn't—or couldn't—talk about, and he was generally supportive, letting her know he was there for whatever she needed. Madison always worked out whatever was on her mind for herself.

This time was different. Charles just felt it in his bones. She playacted normality, went through the motions of being the Madison he and the kids knew—the wife and mother—but it was there behind her eyes. He knew her too well to miss it. What is she doing on these trips to New York? he wondered. He didn't believe for a second that she was so affected by dealing with fussy diplomats at the UN. He knew he was going to have to break their long-held, unspoken compact and ask her what was going on.

Late June in the District was sweltering, even late in the evening. His upbringing in upstate New York didn't prepare him for the stifling humidity of living south of the Mason-Dixon line. Charles didn't spend much time outside in the summer if he didn't have to. Madison, however, seemed to revel in soaking up the humid heat, despite being from Boston. He found her sitting outside on the patio with a beer.

“Mind if I join you, or are you enjoying your solitude?” he asked.

“Please. You know you’re always welcome.” She reached over to pat the armrest on the Adirondak chair beside hers.

They both knew that wasn’t true. Madison enjoyed her solitude. He didn’t question it, but dropped into the chair, sipping from his bourbon before setting it on the small, round table between them. Insects generated a constant background buzz in the dark night. Charles remembered the last time they’d sat out there together, when Madison had pounced on him.

Madison’s voracious sexual appetite—an appetite for risky sex in particular—was another sign that something wasn’t right with her. It reminded him of the woman he’d met, but she’d mellowed considerably as she’d moved into middle age. She had to trust him with whatever was going on.

“How was the trip?” he asked. “Another night of pain-in-the-ass diplomats?”

“Something like that. The entitlement of some people is astounding.” She sighed.

“I’m sure you get enough of that here in D.C. Aren’t you used to it?”

“What I’m dealing with is on a whole different level. The expectations are...different. I can’t just roll my eyes and do whatever I need to and get my job done.”

“Do you want to talk about it?”

Madison stared at him.

“I know there are parts of your job that you’re not supposed to talk about, Maddy, but you don’t have to carry it all on your own. You know that you can trust me.”

“It’s not about trust, honey.”

“I have a security clearance, too.”

“Not high enough.”

“To discuss an annoying attaché from Europe...or wherever? I don’t see how that’s top secret.”

They stared at each other. It was the closest they’d come in sixteen years of marriage to discussing the thing they didn’t discuss.

“Charles...”

“Something different is going on, Maddy. And I know it’s not some diplomatic bullshit.”

“What do you want me to tell you?”

“The truth. As much of it as you can tell me, anyway.”

Madison stared at him, frozen, trapped. Charles had never gone there because she thought he instinctively knew he shouldn’t. But he was now. He knows! she thought. It screamed in her head. He knows! He can see it on you. You’re different, and he knows you’re a cheating slut. No one knows you better than Charles. Of course he knows!

Part of her wanted to tell him and get it over with. It would be easier to unburden herself. But it would be unfair to put it on him. Does he deserve to know? She understood that logic, but how did assuaging her guilt make anything better? Does he really want to know? She decided he didn’t. Madison was not ready to blow up her marriage. But he knew things weren’t right. She had to tell him something.

“Charles, I don’t talk about my work,” she began.

“I know. And I’ve always respected that.”

“I love that you respect my boundaries. But I think you understand things, don’t you? That my work isn’t quite as anodyne as some bland job at State?”

“Are we finally talking about this?”

*Is he going to say it? Say those three letters? C.I.A.? "I just want to know that we're on the same page."*

Charles laughed softly. "I hope you respect me more than that, Maddy. I'm not a fool. I know you don't work for the State Department."

"I respect you more than anyone I know, babe. That's the truth. It's one of the reasons I chose you." Madison realized chose was an odd way to say it, but that struggle between Charles and Kane from years ago was on her mind. She softened. "That's why I married you. And no, I don't work for State."

"Okay. So, what do you do? Why are you suddenly traveling?"

Madison shook her head. "I've been an analyst all this time. That's my job. I can't say more. But they needed me to do something else."

"In New York? Is that where you're really going? I have some idea how these things work, Maddy."

"I really am going to New York, but that's about all I can tell you, babe. The Age... They needed me to go out into the field and take care of something."

"Damn it, Maddy. Is it dangerous? Are you okay?" He took her hand.

"I can't tell you anything else. I wish I could." That was mostly true. "But know I wouldn't be doing it if it weren't important. I need you to trust me on this, Charles."

"I trust you. It's not that. But if they're asking you to put yourself at risk... If you're an analyst... Are you even trained for this, Maddy?"

She squeezed his hand. "I was a field officer before we met. I know what I'm doing. I can handle this." The last part was as much for her as it was for him.

Charles stared at his wife and, for the first time in the almost two decades that he'd known her, he wondered, Do I really know who she is at all? He looked at the woman who kissed the kids' boo boos and tried to picture her

as a secret agent—because that’s what she was telling him she was. Is she a female James Bond? He tried to picture a gun in her hand and just couldn’t.

This was Madison. His wife. He knew her. She was not some blunt instrument of the United States government. She made cupcakes for Penny’s bake sale and saved the beaters for him to lick off. Maybe she was a field officer once upon a time, but that wasn’t the woman he knew. And that made him even more concerned about the C.I.A. throwing her into the field. Whatever they were asking of her, it was clearly difficult. Madison was not handling it well.

“Don’t. Don’t ask me anything more about it,” she said, cutting him off when his mouth opened. “I wouldn’t tell you even if I could, Charles. This is as serious as it gets. I wouldn’t be back out there if it wasn’t. I don’t want you to know the things I know because I don’t want you to have to think about all of the eventualities.”

“I don’t want you to carry that alone. It’s not fair.”

“Charles, babe, it’s not about fair. It’s the job, and I accepted it. But I need to keep it separate from all of this, from you and the kids. I’m doing it all for you, to keep you safe, but it’s the only way I can do it. When I do the work, I have to tap into another side of me... I never want you to see me like that.”

His mind conjured all the worst things the C.I.A. did. Extraordinary renditions. Enhanced interrogation techniques. Charles didn’t want to believe that Madison could be involved in those things. She couldn’t do that and come home and kiss their kids goodnight. Has she ever taken a life? He hoped the public line was true, that most officers never had to use violence in the line of duty.

Madison watched him working it out and worried about where his mind was going. He’d seen spy movies. He was a worldly man. He could be imagining anything. She desperately hoped he didn’t go down the Mata Hari, honey trap road. She’d almost rather he think she was an assassin than someone willing to use her body to get what she needed.

Madison didn't want to know the way he'd look at her if he knew the truth. Deep down, she knew she was a slut, and part of her liked it. That was why the work was so easy for her. That was why she didn't resist Kane the night before.

*God, she thought. He can never know that.*

"I'm worried about you, Maddy. I don't know how you expect me to sit back and be comfortable with you going out there and doing...whatever you're doing."

"Just trust me. I'd never take an unnecessary risk. I'll come home to you. I promise. Always."

Charles sighed and looked at Madison. He did the only thing he could do.

"I'm going to hold you to that."

## eight

The team was split over how to proceed at Nox Venari. Madison and Kane thought it was ridiculous to keep going to the club and hope Prince Zaydan showed up for the night. Madison didn't confess that she wanted to spend as little time there—and playing Kane's wife—as possible, but some of the team saw through the ploy.

Dentiger pointed out that the prince headed straight up to the VIP lounge on his last visit, and that if he did so again, Madison wouldn't be able to get close to him unless the Richardsons arrived at Nox Venari before he did. The fake couple would have to put in a lot more time—and money—at the club before they were invited to join Obsidianus, the elite level of club membership. Manny, in his typically passive way, was good with whatever the professionals decided. He'd be ready.

Cassandra weighed both sides. She worried they'd miss Prince Zaydan if they weren't ready to move when he attended the club. No one wanted to pack the entire team into the van and wait to hear that he was on the move.

But the Richardsons would have to become actively involved if they began spending serious time in the club. She didn't buy Cora Ludolf's assurances that there was no pressure to perform. Perhaps not, but the officers would remain on the periphery, and that would limit their access to the prince once he was at the club. Melissa Richardson had to be seen as a viable mark if Zaydan was going to take an interest.

In the end, Cassandra decided to split the baby.

“Here's what we're going to do. I'll be in the van with Manny. The three of you will be in the hired car nearby. When the surveillance team tells us that al-Kharabati is on the move, you guys will get over to Nox. If we time this



right, Madison and Damien can arrive just as he does. That will give her the perfect position to make an impression on the prince.

“Remember, we expect the Russians to arrive to start negotiations for Null:Echo any minute. We have no time to waste.”

The meeting in the living room of the Rittenhouse Square condo broke up, and Madison went straight up to the master bedroom, where she spent most of her time when the team wasn't meeting. Kane had been watching her closely. She wanted any option that limited her time with him in an erotic setting like Nox Venari.

Kane hadn't tried to talk to Madison since their encounter after Nox Venari. He was still angry that she took her pleasure and threw him out of the bedroom. He'd kept his distance since she'd returned to their Philadelphia base. It was best for him if he stayed as hands-off with Madison as possible.

If he'd been a lesser man, he'd have tried to take what he wanted, although he didn't know how that would work out with a woman like Madison. He suspected she could still take him down if she needed to. But that was what men like Prince Zaydan bin Zaman al-Kharabati did. Men like Anatoly Reznikov, that Russian gangster they'd taken down on their last mission together.

Kane heard voices from the study and stopped short when he heard what they were discussing.

“She can't handle this, Cass. I fucking told you. Can't take someone off the shelf, covered in dust and think they'll perform,” Dentiger complained.

“I'm told she was one of the best at what she does,” Cassandra explained.

“A thousand years ago, maybe. Don't see nobody pulling Troy Aikman out of the booth and putting him into the game.”

“Who?”

Kane smiled in the hallway. Of course, a thirtysomething woman didn't know who the three-time Super Bowl champ was. Kane was from Philly. He hated the man back then and hated the years he had to suffer through Aikman doing analysis on Sunday afternoons.

"Troy Aikman? Maybe the greatest Cowboys QB of all time?" Dentiger marveled.

"It's like you're speaking Farsi. I don't understand a word you're saying," Cassandra complained.

Dentiger said she's fucking washed up in Farsi. Kane understood it because he spoke the language fluently. It rankled him. He was angry with Madison, but he wasn't about to sit back and let that asshole tear her down. She'd already done more for her country than Dentiger would probably do in his entire career.

"She's past it, Cass. You saw her in there. She doesn't want to go back into Nox. Do you think she's going to be able to keep al-Kharabati's interest? She's a fucking soccer mom."

"That's exactly what he likes. That's why she's here, Tay. I hear what you're saying. She's not my first choice either. Or choices one through ten. Hell, I think Bristow would have been a better choice. She still has the edge."

Dentiger laughed. "Shit, can you imagine the Deputy Director going into Nox? I don't know if she'd cut his throat or fuck him into a coma."

Cassandra allowed a laugh, but said, "That's not appropriate, Tay. You can't talk about Deputy Director Bristow like that. The last part, I mean."

"Yeah, sure. Whatever, Cass. I think it's a compliment to recognize a woman who can fuck a man senseless. She's not the only one..." He stopped short, like he'd been slapped, but Kane didn't hear that. "Anyway. Let's say she does get in the room with him. Are you confident Sinclair is going to be able to hang and reel him in, or is she going to run away? I bet she hasn't sucked a dick since Obama was in office."

“Tay, seriously, quit it. She is the only option now.”

“Come on, Cass. If you were maybe ten years older...”

“Don’t go there, Tay.” Cassandra sighed. “Sinclair needs to do this. We need her to do this. So, we’re going to support her and make sure she’s ready. We’re going to make sure she’s confident enough to go into Nox and do what needs to be done.”

“Maddy’s going to be fine,” Kane said, stepping into the room. He’d heard enough. “She could eat a scumbag like al-Kharabati for lunch and still have room for dessert. You haven’t seen her do the things I’ve seen.”

“What have you seen, man?” Dentiger asked. “Seems to me like you’ve seen a lot of her.”

Kane walked toward him, fists clenching.

“Boys,” Cassandra warned.

“Seems like some things happened at Nox the other night, right before al-Kharabati showed up. The video feed didn’t show anything, and we only heard muffled voices on comms,” Dentiger said.

The men stood only a few feet apart. “You know everything you need to. Nothing mission-critical happened in there. You’re just looking for an excuse to drop Maddy because she dropped you on the training course.”

Dentiger’s nose twitched, like he still felt where Madison slammed the crown of her head into it. “She just played dirty.”

Kane chuckled. “There is no playing dirty out there. There’s only winning and surviving. If you don’t know that, you don’t belong in the field, kid.”

“Kid?” Dentiger butted his chest against Kane’s, who stood his ground. “I’ll show you a take-down, old man.”

“Take your shot, kid.” Kane barely resisted popping Dentiger in the face.

“I said that’s enough,” Cassandra said, pushing between the men, a hand on each of their chests. She was surprised that Kane felt just as hard as the younger officer. She looked up at him. “I’m confident that both you and Sinclair can do your job. We’ll get this done, but to do that, we need to support each other, so cut the bullshit.”

“Sure, boss. Just keep the muscle in check. He said it himself. He’s not long on thinking.” Kane turned and started out of the room.

“The Agency needs to look at that mandatory retirement age,” Dentiger fumed from behind him. Kane sensed the younger man wanted to keep going and knew Cassandra was holding him back. He left them to it.

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Madison scrolled Facebook and Instagram in the back of the SUV, keeping tabs on her real life. While she was waiting for the second night in a row for Prince Zaydan to show up at Nox Venari, life went on without her back in McLean.

The Parent-Teacher Organization for the kids’ school held its annual end-of-year fundraiser that evening, but it was long over. It was closing on midnight. Madison would have been there if she weren’t wasting her time sitting in a cocktail dress in the back of an SUV in New York. The dress she’d chosen for Nox Venari would not have been appropriate for the Casino Night—although it was a dress-to-impress event—but she smiled thinking about how her friends, and their husbands, would react to seeing her in the short, skintight cocktail dress. She chose the outfit with its green-fading-to-black ombre pattern for how its subtle sequins caught the light when she moved. Bill von Holt would come in his pants, she thought.

It was the second night in a row that they were on standby for Peacock to show up at the club. She would have been much happier spending her Saturday night with friends at home than in the confines of the vehicle with

a surly Dentiger and a cool Kane. The previous night, Prince Zaydan met up with a group of sleek models and influencers and hit Solo House instead. Solo House was just as exclusive as Nox Venari, but lacking the kink elements.

They'd waited on standby until nearly 3:00 am, when the prince and his friends headed back to his penthouse, where they partied until dawn. Madison had been fast asleep and only woke when the SUV started moving for the journey back to Philadelphia.

Madison had always hated waiting. It was the part of fieldwork that she'd been worst at. She'd loved the action, even the thrill of anticipation when action was imminent, but watching and waiting was torture. She could only drink so much stale coffee from a thermos before she was crawling out of her skin.

Her current life did not lend itself to such late nights. She and Charles were usually in bed by eleven, even on weekend nights. Going all night to charm Prince Zaydan would be rough enough, but just sitting in a dark vehicle and waiting made her dull and slow. The Agency kept amphetamines and methylphenidate on tap for field officers, but she didn't want to go down that road. Madison was definitely too old to start popping go pills.

Kane had said about three words to her since she'd returned to their base in Philadelphia. Madison was torn because she felt like she owed him an apology, an explanation, but she understood it was best to keep her distance. Getting close to him only led to trouble. She could only hope that they could turn on being the Richardsons when the time came.

"Okay, we've got Peacock on the move," Cassandra informed them over comms. "He left the penthouse a few minutes ago, and he could be headed this way. Everybody get sharp."

Madison lingered on a particular photo that Sarah had posted to Instagram from Casino Night earlier that evening. Her friend was between Charles and Bill. Madison smiled, seeing her husband in her favorite suit. She also felt a pang of jealousy seeing Sarah cozied against him instead of her. Sarah would never try to steal her husband, although the low-cut evening gown

she wore to the event would have drawn Charles's attention. Madison was glad he was an honorable man. A lesser man might have made a pass at Sarah to get back at Bill. She powered down her phone, putting all of that out of her mind.

The SUV sat in a parking lot about a mile from Nox Venari. When the tail team confirmed that Prince Zaydan was on his way to the club, Dentiger pulled out and moved in the same direction. The plan was to arrive at roughly the same time and arrange a meet-cute. Madison needed to slow the prince down long enough to get close.

Peacock was two blocks away when they arrived. Madison and Kane waited in the SUV and took a moment to stretch on the sidewalk to get some circulation back after sitting in the vehicle for hours. The prince still hadn't arrived, and they walked inside to stall at check-in.

"I'm sorry, I'm sure I have them somewhere here," Madison said, pawing through her small clutch. It was absurd to think she couldn't find the two foxhead pins in such a tiny purse.

"That's fine, ma'am," the hostess replied patiently.

Syma was not at the door with the security guard. This hostess was a tall, slender Black woman with warm brown skin barely covered by draping champagne-colored satin. Her nipples were tight points easily visible through the fabric, which distracted Kane. She looked like a model they'd hired to act as hostess, and Madison wondered if she'd recognize the woman without the mask.

Madison produced their membership pins and handed them to the hostess, who tapped them against her tablet. She looked from the device to the couple to match their faces to the photos on file, then handed the pins back to Madison.

"Peacock just landed. Vamp for another minute or two," Dentiger directed over comms.

“Which mask do you feel like wearing tonight, darling?” Kane asked, turning to the table of masks in the foyer.

“I don’t know how much attention I want to draw to myself,” Madison replied, flashing a shy smile.

Masks were lined up on the table in neat rows. The club provided options from simple leather, lace, or satin harlequin masks to more stylized animal masks. There were intricate bronze and silver masks, and colorful, stylized ones. Madison puzzled over her choice the way she knew Melissa Richardson would.

Madison had just selected a midnight blue satin mask that swept back like a pair of wings when the doors opened and there he was, the prince himself.

“Make sure everything is perfect, Rami,” the prince said over his shoulder. “You know how these Russians can be. They want to be romanced, like a reluctant virgin.”

“Of course, sir,” the bodyguard replied.

Zaydan stopped short when he saw Madison at the table. Her russet hair demanded his attention. Something was familiar about the shapely redhead. It tickled his brain, but he was sure he didn’t know her. He stared at the way her breasts strained at that dress, offering a valley of freckle-dusted cleavage, and how the short cocktail dress clung to her hips. If he didn’t know her, he wanted to. He looked into her crystal blue eyes and smiled.

“That mask is perfect,” he said, his smooth, rich tones pouring over her. “It will draw out the blue of your eyes.”

She held the mask up to her face. “Do you think? I just picked it because it’s pretty.” A blush colored her cheeks, and it wasn’t entirely a performance. The young prince was even more charming than advertised.

Seeing the mask over her face, recognition clicked into place. This was the sexy MILF who walked into him and spilled her drink. Zaydan didn’t know if that five-thousand-dollar custom jacket had been ruined or not. He didn’t

concern himself with such things. He'd clocked her beauty that night, but he hadn't had time to linger; he'd needed to address specific pleasures waiting for him upstairs. Now, seeing her again, he regretted it.

"You're beauty outshines the mask..." He paused, searching for her name. "Melissa. It's just a shame that the mask will hide it." He intentionally swept his dark eyes to her cleavage. "Or some of it, anyway."

Madison returned his smile. Flirting with the dark, handsome man was too easy. "Are you always so forward...with married women?"

Of course, the man beside her was her husband. Zaydan vaguely remembered him, just as he barely noticed him then. He thought the older man was handsome in a generic white man way—except he had a hardness Zaydan never saw in men like him. The husbands of the women he seduced were always so soft. I may need to keep an eye on this one, Zaydan thought.

"Will you think me a cad if I say yes?" Zaydan asked.

"I'd say it makes you something, but I guess it's expected in a place like this."

"Perhaps it is even welcomed, Melissa?"

"Perhaps."

"Darling, we need to finish checking in," Kane said, playing the role of David Richardson. At least, that's what he told himself.

Richardson would not sit back while another man openly flirted with his wife—even if that was why they'd gone to Nox Venari. There's a way to do this respectfully, Kane thought. The prince hadn't so much as acknowledged him. Madison was not really his wife, but he still felt like he was being cuckolded.

"I apologize, sir, for monopolizing your wife. Melissa is your wife, yes?" Zaydan offered.

"She is. Dave." Kane offered his hand.



Zaydan smiled when the big American tried to intimidate him with his handshake. Men like him were so predictable. But Zaydan was not easily cowed. Nor was he weak. He followed a strict fitness regimen. He relished the surprise in the husband's eyes when he returned the handshake with as much power as he received.

"Do you mind, honey? I believe... I'm sorry, you've never introduced yourself. Are you trying to be a man of mystery?" Madison interrupted.

"If we were beyond the curtain, we'd be masked, and we could be however we chose to be."

Zaydan paused, looking for a hint of recognition in the beautiful redhead's eyes, and found one. He supposed a woman like her was too busy with her life to follow the latest gossip. She was probably marshalling her children to their activities—as a proper woman should. The prince liked thinking of her as a dutiful mother. That would make it sweeter when he made her something else.

"So, you prefer to remain nameless? Is your name a symbol, like Prince?" Madison asked, with a playful smile.

"You may call me Zay."

"Zay," Madison said, like she was trying it out. She already knew from his file that the prince's close friends called him Zay, but such a name would be exotic to Melissa Richardson. She decided that it was a good sign that she was already in the Zay club. "As I was saying, Zay, I believe you owe me a drink."

"Melissa, excuse me, but you spilled your drink on me when you stumbled into me, and somehow I owe you a drink. Perhaps you owe me. I was very fond of that jacket."

"Are you asking me to take you shopping?" She gave him a long, slow look, aiming for something between admiration and distaste.

Madison liked his brocaded jacket—this one featured a subtler, electric blue pattern rather than the purple in his last jacket—but Melissa would find it on the ostentatious side.

“I’d enjoy taking you shopping more, I suspect, but no. It will be my pleasure to have a drink with you. David, you’ll join us, of course.”

Kane found it much too easy to generate Richardson’s annoyance with the prince. He wanted to tell the young man to fuck off, but that was counter to the mission goals, and Operation Scarlet Phantom was finally getting somewhere. He took a leather harlequin mask off the table.

“Please, lead the way,” Kane replied.

## nine

It had been a very long time since Madison had spent any time with someone in a position to have a bodyguard, and Rami's looming presence over them while she and Zaydan tried to flirt and get closer was a wet blanket. He stood behind the prince with his hands clasped in front of him and his chest thrust out.

The other buzzkill was Kane. She assumed he was playing his role as Melissa's dutiful husband, trying to feel out exactly what he wanted his wife to do. Her partner radiated nothing but anger and jealousy. She hoped he was playing a role.

Zaydan had asked Kane to get them all drinks in such a dismissive way that she was sure her partner was going to punch the man. Kane's fist clenched and unclenched, but he graciously did as he was asked. He knew the mission. It didn't matter if the prince rubbed him the wrong way.

They sat on a curved leather couch set into the wall, Zaydan on one side with Rami lurking over his shoulder, and Kane sat on the other. Madison was between them but positioned much closer to the prince. Close enough to touch. She held her Manhattan in both hands. The nervousness she projected wasn't an act. She found it disconcerting how easy it was to inhabit Melissa Richardson.

"We all wear masks, of course, but I don't believe I've ever seen you at the club before, Melissa," Zaydan said. He'd pulled the same custom-made black leather harlequin mask he'd worn during their first encounter from his pocket and slipped it on before entering the club proper.

"This is only our second time. This world is so new to us. Isn't it, honey?" She reached across the couch and took Kane's hand. It was a reach for him, but Zaydan was close enough to touch.

Kane forced a tight smile and squeezed her hand. “We’re entering a new phase of our lives and spreading our wings. So much of our marriage was focused on work and the kids. We finally have time to live for ourselves. I’m sure you’re still in that go-go phase of your life, but you’ll understand one day.”

“Yes, life has many phases, does it not? I do not have a wife or children, so I cannot speak to your experience, but I am very much enjoying all of the delights life has to offer. I cannot imagine ever being different.”

“But you’re so young,” Madison said. “You have no idea. You’re not even married yet.” She took note of his ringless hand. She knew his entire life story, but Melissa did not. “Life becomes very different once you’re married and the children come. And things are different now, I know. Dave and I were already married at your age. I may have even been pregnant with our first.”

“My age?” Zaydan chuckled. “How old do you believe I am?”

Madison smiled and looked down. “I wouldn’t want to guess.” She tried to put herself in Melissa’s mindset. She would probably overshoot because she was embarrassed to be sitting there flirting with such a younger man. She didn’t believe Melissa was there to find her inner cougar. “Thirty-three?”

Zaydan laughed uproariously. “Thirty-three? I think I should be offended. Should I be offended, Rami?” He didn’t even look back at his bodyguard when he asked.

“Yes, sir. Your youth and vigor are unrivaled. How anyone could mistake you for older...” the big man rumbled.

“My life would be over if I was thirty-three! My father or brother would surely have me married off. I would have babies running around the palace back home.” He was still laughing.

“Palace?” Madison asked, eyebrow raised.

“Does your country still practice arranged marriage?” Kane asked.

“Business always comes first, would you not agree, David?” Zaydan replied. “One can hope that love will bloom in such a union, but there are more important considerations. Fortunately, my family has not required my betrothal yet.”

“Fortunately? I suppose you wouldn’t be at a place like Nox Venari if you were married. You would be at home making those babies,” Madison said.

Zaydan flashed her a knowing smile. “Sex cannot only be about making babies, can it, Melissa? How dull would that make life?”

She hated how charming his smile was, and the way it tickled something deep in her core. She kept going back and forth, and at the moment, she didn’t want to enjoy her assignment. She replied, “That’s true. So, you’d bring your lovely wife here?”

“No, Melissa. Moments ago, you said that life is different now than when you were my age. And I would agree that is true. But also, life is very different in this country than where I was raised, even now. The way you Americans live is too libertine for my people.

“We understand that for a people to stay strong, they must remain strong and devout. Corruption of the soul seeps in when one is not vigilant. Devotion to Allah and his teachings is paramount for a strong people and a strong country. Apologies, but we are steadfast in keeping the corruption of your Western ways from our people.”

“But you’re not worried about the effect of Western corruption on your soul?” Kane pointedly asked, gesturing at the club around them with his lowball glass.

So late in the evening, the lounge at Nox Venari was less crowded as most members had moved on to explore other parts of the club. Music thumped from the room across the hallway, but they hadn’t stopped to see what was on display that evening. Some of the people who’d stopped back were finished with their night and grabbing a last drink on the way out.

But the threesome in the corner looked like they were just getting started. A thick brunette's dress was stripped to her waist while a tall, balding man kissed and groped her. The other man in their group watched and touched himself through his tuxedo pants. Western corruption, indeed.

"Some of us must engage the West to understand it. I travel extensively in the Western world, conducting my family's business. And as they say, when in Rome... But please, we are not here to discuss such weighty things, are we?"

Madison studied the young prince. He'd let the mask slip, if only for a moment. Men like him had always fascinated her, men who preached one thing for others while conducting themselves quite differently. She often wondered if they just thought they were above all others, stronger, incorruptible. Or, more likely, they didn't believe a word out of their mouths and simply enjoyed the exercise of power.

Madison had been sure Zaydan was the latter, but the fire in his dark eyes when he spoke about Western decadence made her believe he may have been driven by ideology more than they suspected.

Forcing a smile she didn't feel, Madison said, "I know I didn't come here tonight for a geopolitical discussion. I'm sure one has to spend time in your country to fully understand your culture."

"We have thousands of years of culture and so much beauty. I'm sure a discerning woman like you would appreciate it. I would be honored to be your host someday."

"We've been around the world quite a bit, but we haven't spent much time in the Middle East. My business has never had dealings there," Kane said. "And it's never been high on my list of places to visit."

"Do you only travel for business? Never pleasure? That sounds quite dull," Zaydan said, flashing Madison that smile again, like they were sharing a joke he didn't expect Kane to get.

“Now that the kids are older and out of the house, I’ve begun to accompany Dave on business trips, but our vacations are never about business. That would be quite dull, Zay. You’re right.” She placed a hand over his. “I’m sure you’ve been all over the world.”

“I did do my earliest travels accompanying my father on business. And then I went to school in England. But yes, Melissa, I’ve been many, many places, and seen many things.”

“Do you have a favorite destination?”

“London feels like a second home, of course. Moscow and Singapore both have their charms. I love it here in New York. You have such a vibrant city here, very unlike anywhere else in the world. But for sheer beauty and culture, Paris is my favorite.”

“Oh, this isn’t our city, Zay. Dave and I don’t live in New York. We’re just visiting,” Madison paused and looked down shyly, like she was embarrassed to mention it, and added, “For the club.” She quickly changed the subject, as she believed Melissa would. “But Paris in the spring is so beautiful. I really must get back there.”

Zaydan turned the hand she’d rested hers on and intertwined his fingers with hers. “Paris is beautiful in the spring, but it doesn’t hold a candle to you. They should be so lucky as to have you come and add your beauty to theirs.”

“Stop it, Zay. You’re being ridiculous.” She tightened her grip on his hand.

*Is this guy fucking serious? Kane thought. He watched Madison eating it up and decided she was playing her role expertly. An innocent housewife like Melissa Richardson might fall for al-Kharabati’s nonsense, he thought, but a woman like Madison never would. The Madison he knew ate overstuffed egos like the prince’s for lunch.*

“It is true, Melissa. You’re radiant. And if I may indulge in a cliché, that flaming mane of yours... Well, it fills me with quite spicy thoughts.”

“Spicy thoughts?” She laughed. “Do I even want to know? I appreciate the compliments, but a handsome, young man like you? I find it very hard to believe you came to a place like this to spend time with a woman like me.”

“A woman like you?” Zaydan appeared genuinely puzzled.

Madison smiled politely, struggling for the correct way to phrase it without making herself sound old. That didn’t require her to pretend to be someone else. She felt just as awkward flirting with a man in his twenties as Melissa would.

“Seasoned? No, that’s a terrible word,” she began. “Well, we’ve established you’re younger than thirty-five. Younger than thirty?” She made a face.

“I don’t mind falling back on cliches, obviously. Age is just a number, Melissa. I see an attractive, experienced woman in front of me. The number of years you’ve been on this Earth is immaterial to me. If it matters at all, it’s only to make you more appealing. I find women your age—whatever it may be—are far more sensual. You’re comfortable in your bodies, often more open...”

*I can’t believe this fucking guy, Kane thought. No way this shit works without the nice suit and the air of money. He supposed the prince was attractive, but he didn’t see how any woman with half a brain fell for al-Kharabati’s nonsense.*

Madison sipped her drink, realizing it was nearly empty, and smiled tightly. “Thank you for mansplaining women’s sexuality in middle age, Zay.”

Zaydan returned the smile, barely hiding his condescension. These American women are so confident in their place, so direct in challenging their men. If a woman in the palace ever said ‘mansplaining’ to a man, she would quickly regret it.

It wasn’t that women in Kharabat were weak or powerless, but they knew the real strength in exercising quiet power. A man did not want to be openly challenged by his woman. It was one of many reasons he so enjoyed taking women from their weak Western men and breaking them. This one will be



fun to break. And I will make this arrogant American prick watch her beg me for more.

“I suppose I spoke poorly. I did not mean to explain myself to you. I was only trying to say that I understand and value more refined women.”

Humility was as ill-fitting on Zaydan as his tuxedo was perfectly tailored. Madison allowed herself to be taken in, but only because it was her job. It had nothing to do with the young prince’s captivating nature, despite his regressive attitudes toward women. That was what she told herself.

Being in his late twenties very much made Zaydan a boy to her, but sitting close enough to catch his expensive, spicy sandalwood scent and feel the heat off his body, Madison realized he was very much a man. His thick head of jet-black hair, slicked back into a modified pompadour, his thicker, perfectly groomed beard, the forest of chest hair that peeked out from the collar of his black silk shirt were all the marks of a virile man, not a feckless playboy. Of course, he could be a playboy in a man’s body. She was too aware of how his hand caressed hers.

“You can make it up to me by getting me another drink,” she said.

“Of course, Melissa. Our night is just beginning.”

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“That’s a good start, isn’t it?” Manny asked.

“I’d say so. Sinclair seems to have him hooked. Our boy is certainly interested,” Cassandra agreed.

They were in the back of the Sprinter van, parked a block and a half up from Nox Venari. The windshield had several parking tickets on the windshield, which only made it look more legit, but the NYPD had a no-tow order on the van. The Agency hadn’t deigned to share why the van was

parked there. The NYPD didn't even know it was a CIA vehicle; after all, the Agency did not officially operate on US soil. The request had gone through Homeland Security. The Agency doesn't officially operate on US soil.

The views from both Madison's and Kane's hidden cameras were on the monitors mounted inside the van. Hers was a tilted close-up view of the prince, while Kane's was from farther back, giving the team a wider view that showed both her and Zaydan's body language. Cassandra was pleased that her officer and the prince sat so close together.

*Putting her hand over is a nice touch, she'd thought. Sinclair might just pull this off if she doesn't get scared or piss him off first.*

She saw the annoyance on his face when Madison mentioned mansplaining. The officer couldn't be a pushover, but men like the prince didn't like to be challenged too hard. Cassandra fought the urge to tell her officer to ease up.

"Of course, he's interested. Her tits are right in his face," Dentiger said over comms. He was on a channel that didn't include the officers in the club.

"Don't be so crude, Tay," Cassandra told him.

"He's not wrong," Manny agreed. "I mean, any guy would be captivated by those things. Look at him on the monitor. His eyes go down to her rack like every few seconds. If I didn't know better, I'd think he knows the camera is in the locket and he's staring right at us."

"Sinclair is doing her job and using her assets, just like either of you would," Cassandra said, rolling her eyes at the men she had to work with. She didn't even want to think about what thoughts of her bounced around inside their heads.

She was a fit, attractive Asian woman with long, jet-black hair she always wore up in a bun when she was working, which went with the plain pantsuits she often wore. That night in the field, she'd thrown a black leather jacket over a loose olive green t-shirt and jeans. Her sidearm was in

a shoulder holster under the jacket. She understood the importance of minimizing her sexuality, even her femininity, when she was working.

“They’re some assets,” Manny commented.

“Shit, bro, ain’t you ever touched boobies before?” Dentiger said with a chuckle in their ears. “Don’t forget, bro, she’s probably old enough to be your mom.”

He spoke the truth, but he also knew how tight her body was because it had been all over him when they wrestled on the training course at The Farm. Madison didn’t have the body of an average suburban soccer mom. He wondered how those tits held up when she let them out. Dentiger figured they’d be seeing them soon enough if she did her job right.

“Fuck off,” Manny shot back.

“Can you two act like professionals? Or at least adults? I know things are much looser in the field, but we still have standards, and there is still HR, even out here in the field,” Cassandra said.

Manny took offense at his boss’s suggestion that he couldn’t do his job and think about Madison’s tits. His mind had been filled with inappropriate thoughts about his coworker, and he thought he’d been doing excellent work. He knew enough to keep his thoughts to himself, but they couldn’t stop him from thinking them.

Women like Madison had always done it for him. There was something about an older woman, especially one who’d had kids and kept her hotness, that just did it for Manny. His formative years had been spent watching General Hospital with his mother and sister, and seeing sexy, mature women like Carly and Olivia had imprinted on him. Manny didn’t believe he had a MILF fetish like Zaydan, but sexy, mature women got his motor running.

Madison was right in that mold. When he’d seen the photos his fellow wizards in DS&T had mocked up of her for the Nox Venari application, he’d needed a minute alone with himself—even though he knew they

weren't real. And then when he saw her in the outfits for attending the club... Well, Manny developed quite the crush.

"We don't mean anything by it, Cass," Dentiger said. "Just blowing off steam. Trying to find something to keep ourselves sharp when so much of the job is sitting and waiting."

"Would you rather be inside Nox, swinging with the elite?" Cassandra asked.

Dentiger sat in the SUV a few blocks away and smiled. In his civilian life, Tayshawn Dentiger would never share his woman. Men who did that were out of their minds. But he'd seen some women worth his attention on the camera as Madison walked around the club. He would definitely throw one to that Syma who met them at the door on their last visit.

And then there was Madison herself. He could have played her husband. Or even just her boytoy. And if he was playing her husband, he certainly wouldn't be following her around Nox Venari like a cuck the way Kane was. He would have given her the fuck she needed on their first night at the club, convinced her they needed it to cement their cover as a couple looking for excitement. Madison would know who the top dog was once he made her eyes roll back in her head.

"Nah, Cass, you know swinging ain't my thing," he replied over comms. "But if it was me in there, I'd get the job done right."

"I don't even want to know what you mean by that. You wouldn't exactly make a convincing couple with Sinclair anyway. You'd need a different partner," Cassandra said.

"What do you mean?" he asked. A tense moment hung over comms.

"Jesus, Tay, I don't mean a racial thing. The two of you would not look remotely like a couple, and it has nothing to do with you being black and her being white. I don't think you and Madison together sell a nice, well-off pair of empty nesters looking for excitement."

“I feel you, Cass. I’d need a younger partner.”

“Which wouldn’t grab Prince Zaydan’s attention.”

“But if I had to go in, maybe you and me...”

Cassandra choked on his suggestion. Manny looked up over his shoulder to see if she was okay. She was red and coughing. She waved him off and spoke when she recovered.

“The last thing I want to do is go undercover in a sex club. I’d rather be back in a forward base in Afghanistan. You’ve lost your mind, Tay. And luckily, I wouldn’t attract the prince’s attention the way that Sinclair can. Now, everyone pay attention. It looks like they’re moving.”

Madison was indeed up and moving with the prince on their monitor. The view from her concealed camera was shaky, turning to an inky black when she stood and got too close to Zaydan. The camera concealed on Kane showed a bouncy shot of him following them. Rami, the bodyguard, was out of view.

Manny tossed another look over his shoulder at Cassandra. He’d suspected it for the past week, but now he was sure. The boss and Dentiger were fucking behind everyone’s back.

## ten

Zaydan led Madison into the bowels of Nox Venari, and she was comforted by Kane's presence for a change. She was by the prince's side, but her husband followed close behind. Rami walked several paces ahead of them, like he was clearing the way for his charge.

When the prince suggested showing her his favorite parts of the club, she knew she had no choice but to agree. She played it nervous and coy, and turned to Kane to ask what he thought. Her partner was coiled tight, but he said it was up to her. Madison would have liked him to be more protective—for David to be more protective of Melissa—but that wasn't his job. He was there to facilitate her cover and provide close backup.

Static cut in and out in their ears when they descended the staircase to the club's basement level. She wanted to check their comms but had no subtle way to do it so close to Zaydan. She could only hope the team outside was still in contact.

Several couples were in the pool area, all of them nude, and only some were wearing their masks. At least one couple was having sex in the water, and a group was all groping each other in the hot tub. There is not enough chlorine in the world, she thought. One heavy, older man sat in a chair and watched it all with his dick in his hand.

Zaydan placed a hand on the small of her back and guided Madison down a dark corridor in the opposite direction. She remembered where they were headed from their tour with Cora and tensed.

"How familiar are you with BDSM, Melissa?" he asked, purring close to her ear.

“Whips and chains and stuff?” she nervously giggled. “I read 50 Shades like everyone else. We saw the movies when they came out.”

His warm laugh was smooth as silk, giving her goosebumps, but it wasn’t reassuring. “That book was a silly housewife’s fantasy. Using that as a reference for dominance and submission is like watching those Fast and Furious movies and believing yourself to be a mechanic.”

“Is that your thing? Domination? Tying women down?”

Pitching Melissa’s surprise and fear took all of Madison’s acting skills. In her field days, she’d had enough experience with men who liked to dominate—and brutalize—women that she wouldn’t blink at going to a dungeon. She understood the difference between a loving BDSM relationship and the way powerful men liked to control their women, but most of her experience was with the former, not the latter.

Anatoly Reznikov came to mind. Madison—or Milica, as he’d known her—had been the last in the long line of women he’d treated like trinkets who existed for his amusement. At least she’d made sure she was the last.

A dark part of her enjoyed being seen as a sex object—even treated like one—but Charles had shown her that she had more value than that. She knew she might have to go back to that place with Zaydan, and it scared her. The prince did his best to keep his private life private, but she’d read enough in his file.

His breath on her neck gave her the good shivers. “Oh, Melissa, there is so much more to control than whips and chains.”

“I don’t think I’m ready for anything like that. No man has ever controlled me, let alone tied me down or whipped me.” She smiled to herself at the lie.

The basement dungeon at Nox Venari was huge. It was considered one of the club’s premier attractions. Not only did it have every piece of bondage furniture and implement one could ask for, but they had professional masters and dominatrixes at every club event.

“Wow, this is a popular place,” Madison commented when they walked into the space.

“It always is,” Zaydan replied, urging her forward with his hand on her back.

The expansive space was crowded, although most of that crowd was spectators. A woman with rich, light brown skin and flowing black hair was strapped to a large St. Andrew’s cross that was raised on a platform. Her body was all luscious, soft curves, and she wore a black leather mask adorned with the silver fox. A tall, buff Black man stood beside her in a harness and mask. He held a riding crop.

To the right, Madison saw a thick woman with jet black hair that cascaded down her back and massive breasts that were barely encased in black patent leather. Her lace-up, platform boots made an imposing figure. A man groveled before her on the hard, cold stone floor, licking those boots.

On the left, an older man and woman were locked in stocks, and there appeared to be a line of people waiting to flog them. Madison had witnessed a lot in her world travels, but the scene in the Nox Venari dungeon was intense by any standard.

“This is...” she murmured.

“Sexy,” Zaydan finished for her. “Isn’t it?”

“I don’t...”

Rami parted the crowd, and the prince guided her forward until they were at the front, the St. Andrew’s cross looming over them. Even masked, the woman strapped to it looked frightened. The muscles in her limbs kept tensing against her bonds. Madison was captivated by the anticipatory quiver of her flesh. Closer, she saw that a heavy chain hung from tight clamps that distended the woman’s nipples. That looks painful, she thought.

“Tell them why you’re up there,” the dom growled, circling the St. Andrew’s cross with the riding crop.



“I... I disobeyed...” the woman whimpered.

Only when Madison heard the captive’s clipped, British tones did she realize the woman strapped to the St. Andrew’s cross was Syma. The realization was a shock. She’d never expect to see the beautiful, self-possessed woman in such a position.

She stared hard at the man tormenting Syma. He was familiar, but she couldn’t place him with the fox mask hiding his face. He was tall and built like a former athlete who’d just started going soft in middle age. His obviously-dyed black hair was swept back from his mask. He wore something that looked like a leather onesie and was half-unzipped.

“That excites you, doesn’t it?” Zaydan whispered, misreading her interest.

“I... I’d never...” Madison breathed. It was both an answer and a dodge. She wouldn’t willingly put herself in such a situation, but seeing Syma up there made her pulse race.

“You never know what you are capable of with the proper motivation, Melissa.”

The dom tugged the chain connecting Syma’s nipples, and she whined. “How did you disobey, slut?”

“I wore...ahhh...mmm...panties...when...ahhh...you checked...”

“Bad girl.”

Syma took a quick swat from the riding crop across the front of her thighs. She yelped. Not a stitch of clothing protected her delicate, creamy flesh, and the thin leather rod left a vivid red mark.

“Ahhh god...please, sir...” Syma struggled to manage her breathing. “Th... that meant my cunt wasn’t available when you...mmmm...wanted it...”

“And that’s a terrible sin, slut.”

The dom's lips curled into a smile when he swatted her again. The riding crop landed with a sharp crack, which was followed by an excited gasp from the crowd. They wanted to see Syma punished. Madison felt strange and too hot. She didn't want to see the woman hurt. She didn't know what she wanted.

Syma cried out when the implement landed again, that time against the gentle swell of her belly. The dom paused, leaving her shaking, and then drew the tip of the crop between her swollen lips. She was waxed so smooth that the glistening of her arousal was obvious, even from where Madison stood with Zaydan. Syma whined and moaned when the crop teased her sex.

"You're dripping wet," the dom said.

"Because...ahhh...because I'm a slut...I...I need..."

"What do you need, slut?"

He pressed the length of the riding crop between her lips, pushing into her cleft and crushing against her clit. Syma wailed and sagged against her wrist restraints. She was moaning so much that she could hardly get out her words.

"Cock...ahhh, please...I need your cock, sir...please..."

He rocked the crop along her furrow, making Syma quake and beg.

"Do you deserve it, slut?"

"I...ahhh...only deserve...what you...god, please...choose to give me..."

Zaydan pressed his erection against Madison's thigh. It was impressive. There was no question that he enjoyed the exhibition. His breath was hot on her neck, and his grip on her hip tightened, while his other hand rested firmly just above her waist, on that little pooch that only happened after you'd had children. Madison hated that he chose to touch her there. She didn't need attention called to it.

“Tell these nice people why that is,” the dom said, still teasing his captive.

“Because you own me...ahhh god...you own this cunt...it’s for your...god...pleasure, sir...”

“Are you ashamed that everyone is witnessing your punishment, slut?”

“No...proud...proud they see I’m yours...ahhh...please...”

“Please what?”

“Please let me come...be good...promise...”

“We’ll see, slut. We’ll see how good you are.”

Madison turned away from the spectacle. She didn’t want to see how good Syma could be for her tormentor. She didn’t want to see what the stunning woman would have to do to prove her loyalty and earn her orgasm. Mostly, she didn’t like the things that watching it stirred inside her.

Zaydan followed when his new friend moved across the front of the crowd to get away from the St. Andrew’s cross. This one is wound tight, he thought. It only made him want her more. Fucking a slut felt good, but there was no challenge to it. But taking a woman like Melissa, who’d followed the rules her entire life, who’d thought she knew right from wrong, and shattering all of that, was thrilling, especially when she had a body like that.

## eleven

Past the edge of the crowd, Madison took a deep breath. Her hands were shaking. Too many thoughts fogged her brain. One moment, she could see herself as the one holding the riding crop and making Syma beg. Next, it was her secured to that giant wooden X, begging Zaydan to let her come. She didn't have time to clear her head because the prince was right there, and she had to be on again.

"This must all be so new and strange for you, Melissa," Zaydan said, standing close enough to brush a flaming lock back from her cheek.

"But you don't know me at all, Zay. Maybe you're seeing a different side of me, but you're still seeing what I choose to show. My head could be filled with dark, dirty thoughts I've never shared with anyone, not even my husband."

She pressed her cheek to his hand, hating that he looked even sexier with his mask on. If she had a couple more drinks, Madison could almost forget the terrible man beneath the mask—the one who wanted to get Null:Echo so his family could put their hand around the throat of the West.

"Tell me, Melissa. Tell me the things you're afraid to tell anyone else. I'll make them come true for you."

"I hardly know you."

"Doesn't that make it safer? How can I possibly judge you?"

Madison knew that was bullshit, but she was still taken in. The men of Kharabat, and the royal family in particular, did nothing but judge women. They would whip every woman in Nox Venari if they were back in Zaydan's homeland—and not in the sexy way that Syma was being abused.

“Zay...”

They were so close. The air in the space between them was charged, like it had a physical presence all its own. He was going to kiss her. Madison suddenly realized Kane was nowhere to be seen. Either they’d lost him in the crowd, or Rami was intentionally running interference.

Static burst in her ear, then Cassandra’s voice cutting in and out. “...you read me? Sinclair...bzzz...Kane...either of you...bzzz...” She’d wondered why her comms had been so quiet. The signal must have been having trouble penetrating the heavy stone walls of Nox Venari’s dungeon. Madison was on her own. Somehow, knowing she was alone with Zaydan, unobserved—by anyone she knew, anyway—was liberating.

Zaydan’s fingers were soft on the back of her neck. He’d probably never used those hands for manual labor a day in his life. But as those digits stiffened and guided her forward, she felt their strength. Despite his appearance, the prince was not the soft man the world saw. Looking into his dark eyes up close, framed by the mask, she saw it. And the dark part of her that always chased danger liked it.

He brought her lips right to his, but he didn’t kiss her. That wasn’t what he wanted. Madison took the bait. Zaydan wanted her—Melissa—to kiss him, and she did it. Their lips touched, and she felt that old hunger explode inside her. Any fears that she couldn’t seduce the prince had been badly misguided.

His balls throbbed when he felt that slight intake of breath right before she kissed him. He lived for that moment, when other men’s wives stuck a toe over the line, when they forgot they were someone’s mother, a proper woman of society, and gave into their carnal desires for the very first time. He was sure she was thrilling inside at how naughty she was. He tightened his grip on the back of her neck and pressed his erection into her, knowing she had no idea just how naughty she would get.

Madison grabbed his labels, holding tightly, pulling him closer as she kissed him harder. Zaydan thought it was her walls breaking down while her desire took over. He wasn’t far off, but the things that drove Madison—had always

driven her—were very different from what made a woman like Melissa Richardson.

She slipped her tongue into his mouth, her body taut as a bowstring. He held her waist with both hands. Those hands became more possessive as Madison's aggression with her tongue grew. She rubbed her stomach back against his hard-on, feeling it through her cocktail dress.

His hands slid up that smooth, sequined dress, trying to grope her through it. Beneath it, her breasts were firmly encased by a bustier-style bra. He pushed harder, growling into their kiss with frustration, even nipping at her tongue. Madison thought he must just be trying to push her breasts up and out of the dress. He was close to succeeding. She loved his aggression.

"Sinclair...Madison...bzzz...do you hear me?" Cassandra sounded more desperate for a response.

Madison ignored her.

Zaydan's lips slid across her jaw and then to her neck. She gasped, and it made him want to possess every part of her. Melissa's unravelling has begun, he thought. He fought the urge to just take it all right away. It would be more fun to strip away her propriety one piece at a time. She would be his willing, needy slut before she even realized it was happening.

Guiding her backward, he pressed her to the rough stone. "I want to fuck you up against the wall, Melissa." The words came out in a hungry growl.

Madison tried to rein it in. The line between her and Melissa was blurring. The throbbing in her core urged her to tell him to do it. Her words escaped like a weak plea. "Zay...we can't...there's so many people around...my husband..."

"He's here somewhere..." He spoke while kissing her neck. "He'd stop us if he wanted to. This is why you're here, isn't it, Melissa?"

His words sharpened her, reminding her exactly why she was there. He wasn't wrong. This was why Madison was there. Zaydan just didn't know

carnal desire wasn't her motivation. At least, not the important one.

Remembering her mission, the goal of Operation Scarlet Phantom, brought a pang of guilt, as it also reminded Madison of her real husband, Charles, sitting on his own in their nice suburban home some three hundred miles to the south.

"It's...Zay...I don't know...I'm...just..."

He kissed her again, cutting off the protests. Madison was glad she could just kiss him again. Melissa's dithering felt forced. Zaydan was an amazing kisser, and she hated him for it—but not enough that she didn't enjoy it.

"Don't be nervous, Melissa. Give in to your desire," he urged.

*Easy for you to say, she thought. You're not fighting generations of societal expectations and judgment. That worked for either Melissa or Madison. She wanted him to shut up and keep kissing her, but before she mashed their lips back together, she murmured, "You make it sound so easy..."*

Zaydan took his hands from her body, and she immediately wanted them back. Letting him take the wheel was proving to be much easier than expected. She was breathless from their kiss and nearly stumbled in her heels when he led her to another corner of the dungeon. She glanced over her shoulder but still didn't see Kane.

For a moment, she worried the prince's goon was doing something to her partner, but it was more likely Kane was just distracted by some pretty young thing.

A group of men, with a couple of women, were crowded around something. Zaydan shouldered someone aside to give Madison a view of what fascinated them. A petite blonde woman was strapped to a waist-high gurney with extensions that forced her thighs apart and her arms out at her sides. She was nude, except for a thin bandit mask that barely hid her identity.

The people around the table were not spectators. They freely touched the blonde, hands covering her breasts and teasing her nipples, caressing her thighs, rubbing her mound. A man and a woman, who stood on opposite sides of the gurney, each had a finger inside her. The woman fingering her, a stout, gray-haired woman in a flowing evening gown, flicked the blonde's clit with her thumbnail.

“Ohhh...I...ohhh...ahhh...”

The captive's weak, needy moans left Madison wondering if she was pleading for mercy or for more.

“Don't you see how incredible it is to surrender and just feel, Melissa?” Zaydan asked, his seductive voice warm honey in her ear.

“That's...crazy...why would anyone...”

Zaydan took her hand and put it on the woman. “Imagine all of that attention focused on you.”

Madison stared at her hand like it belonged to someone else. He didn't have to guide or coerce her. She touched the blonde on her own, feeling her smooth, pale skin. The flesh burned like a furnace, heating Madison. She traced a line of cursive print on the woman's ribcage that read: Life's too short...

“Someone, please...yesss...yesss...like that...just like that...fuck, yes...”

The stout woman rubbed her clit in a tight circle. The blonde's moans grew louder, and she tried to thrash against her restraints. She was truly helpless. The people around her could do anything they pleased to her body. One of the men pulled her nipple, stretching her small tit up.

“Fuck! Not so hard...” she cried, followed by, “Ohhh fuck...yesss...”

Kane's voice blossomed in Madison's ear. “I read you. I think comms are back up.”

“What the fuck are we looking at?” Dentiger asked over comms.



“Not sure where Maddy is. Wanted to give her and the douchebag space, and I lost them in the crowd down here. Figures these assholes love the dungeon best. What are you seeing?”

“Uh, some girl...I mean, woman...is strapped to a table or something. Everyone’s touching her,” Manny volunteered. He sounded dazed.

“It’s not Maddy, is it?” Kane’s voice was urgent.

“No, it’s a blonde. She looks familiar,” Cassandra answered.

The voices sounded like they were heard from a distant room. Madison was focused on the helpless, desperate woman in front of her. She and Zaydan were massaging one of her breasts, rolling the tiny, pale pink nipple between their thumbs. The blonde stared at them, mouth hanging open, staring while she moaned. Her message was clear. She wanted more.

Madison gasped when the recognition clicked. The petite blonde was the cute neighbor from a sitcom they used to watch as a family. She was a perky, simple blonde in her late thirties, married to an older man on the show. America would have been stunned to see her on that gurney, begging to come.

“This is why you’re here, isn’t it, Melissa? To be worshipped. Imagine all attention focused on your pleasure,” Zaydan murmured.

It was all she could think about. Her panties were soaked, and her thighs were slick with excitement. Madison would never allow strangers to do what they wanted like that, but being helpless and forced to accept pleasure from someone devoted to making her come? The prospect made her dizzy. She didn’t even think about what Melissa Richardson wanted.

Charles—as much as she loved him—would never do that to her. He couldn’t. It simply wasn’t in his nature. She never wanted him to see her like that anyway—reduced to her most primal, sexual self.

“Yes! Yes! Oh god, yes! Fuck me! Yes!” the sitcom star cried, arching her back off the gurney when she came.

An older man, it could have been her husband from the sitcom, turned her head and put his cock in her mouth. The trim, gray-haired man looked ridiculous in his full tuxedo with his slender cock sticking out. She seemed to gag on him, shouting her orgasm into his prick, but it didn't stop him from enjoying her mouth. Madison licked her lips unconsciously.

The snug cocktail dress went slack, giving Madison unexpected room to breathe. Zaydan had unzipped the back. She opened her mouth to protest, but he was already pushing the spaghetti straps from her shoulders and peeling the dress down to expose her tits, clad in expensive fleur du mal black lace that thrust them up and out.

"You're breathtaking, Melissa," Zaydan said, hypnotized by all of her soft, exposed, freckle-dusted flesh.

"Zay." She was breathless as she turned to him, the hand touching the sitcom star on autopilot.

"Stop pretending you don't want it."

Madison didn't. His hands molded to her breasts, and she mashed her lips to his. The kiss swallowed her deep moan. His touch was firm, but not too rough. They were both frustrated that the bustier bra's padding protected her from truly feeling his touch. His hands grew more aggressive as his frustration mounted, like he was going to try to tear the lace right off her body.

She held his face, kissing him so hard that it was like she was trying to climb inside him. Next, she pushed her hands inside his jacket to feel his chest through his soft, custom-tailored black shirt. He wasn't hard like Kane, but he was fit. She fingered the buttons of his shirt, toying with them, but didn't open them.

Zaydan wondered how far he could push the sexy wife. What would she let him do to her in the dungeon? He mostly preferred to take his pleasures in private, behind closed doors, but displaying her in the crowded room would prove how easily he could take control. He abandoned her tits, knowing he

wasn't going to wrestle them free from her infernal bra. Instead, he rolled her dress down past the swell of her hips, and it dropped to the floor.

Madison tensed when she realized he'd fully stripped the dress off her. Getting naked in a room full of strangers was not part of the plan. She was self-conscious about her body. Although she was in better shape than a lot of the women she knew who were her age, she still only saw the imperfections. She was fit, but she wasn't Pilates-toned like the blonde actress writhing on the gurney beside them.

"We can't...not here..." She panted, reluctantly breaking their kiss again. It became harder every time. She wasn't falling for him. She was just incredibly horny. She tried to cover herself, just as modest as Melissa would be.

Zaydan loved seeing her weak attempt to cover herself. Curves like that could not be hidden by her feminine hands and toned arms. Her tits were incredible. Her hips had a perfect feminine swell. He wouldn't allow her to hide a body like that. He took her wrists and gently moved her arms while taking a step back to truly look at her.

"Your body is heavenly, it should be seen. My god, you're femininity personified."

Madison knew he was laying it on thick, but it still worked. She glowed. Her core tightened, and her nipples throbbed in her bra. She knew she shouldn't fuck him, not when they were first spending time together—because Melissa wouldn't—but it was all she wanted.

"But not here...Zay...please..." Her eyes met his, and she didn't cover herself. She let him look. Others had begun to look, too. She fought the urge to retreat. She had to reluctantly seduce Zaydan. It was her job. Madison tried telling herself it was all about the job. She added another, "Please..."

## twelve

Kane caught sight of Madison as she was leaving the dungeon with Zaydan. He wasn't sure it was her at first because her dress was slung over the prince's arm, and she was stripped to her very sexy black underwear, but he hadn't seen another woman in that club with hair that matched Madison's.

*She works fast, he thought, and then regretted it. That wasn't fair. Her job was to use her charms to get close to Prince Zaydan. He should be happy that Operation Scarlet Phantom was moving forward. But he'd always had trouble separating his personal feelings when Madison was involved. Kane jealously wondered what he'd missed that got her dress off.*

Rami followed him while he followed Madison and Zaydan up the stairs to the main floor. He spoke to the team on comms under his breath. He'd perfected the perfect mumble to be heard on comms, but not by others around him, years ago.

"Located them. They're on the move."

Cassandra responded. "We have her video feed back. If you can't speak, Sinclair, clear your throat or something so we know you hear us."

Dread crept up Kane's spine when Madison didn't reply. He was worried the dirtbag prince was coercing her, and started to plan how he'd take down the mountainous bodyguard behind him. He'd made larger men fall. She finally answered with a soft cough followed by a sorry that wasn't meant for the team.

Zaydan swept her up to the second floor. Kane crossed his fingers that they were stopping there. Madison would be on her own if the prince took her to the third floor, which was for Obsidianus members only. Zaydan could get her in, but Kane wouldn't be able to follow.

The couple turned down the corridor and stopped at an open door. The prince turned and looked at Kane. “You can join us, of course. Melissa asked me to bring her somewhere more private so that we may continue to enjoy ourselves.” He disappeared into the room with Madison.

Kane fumed like he really was her husband. The bastard didn’t ask permission to take Madison. He followed them into the room.

“Melissa, darling, are you okay? Should we talk?” he asked. Appearing jealous was easy. Playing the concerned husband required acting.

Madison looked back and bit her lower lip. Kane knew that look. It was funny how even after decades, some things just remained the same. She was struggling to control herself. When Madison was too horny and a little tipsy, she only wanted to surrender. But she never forgot she was a professional.

Taking Kane by both hands and pulling him to a corner of the subtly-lit bedroom, she said, “Honey, it’s okay.” Closer, he saw she was flushed from her cheeks to her waist. Her pale, freckled skin made her tells all the more obvious.

“Should we be doing this?” he asked, aware Zaydan could hear them, despite the music pumped into the room from discreet speakers. Rami was a sentinel in the open doorway. Kane was sure the bodyguard would try to drag him out of there with a nod from his master.

“Don’t mess this up, Kane,” Cassandra chimed in on comms. “She’s got her toehold. She needs to keep Peacock on the hook.”

He noted that Cassandra Gale had no more of a problem pimping Madison out than any male handler would. Sisterhood, he wryly thought. Of course, there’d been that mission in Munich when he’d acted as a broker and literally pimped her out to a lesser Middle Eastern prince’s harem just so they could fix his location, so who was Kane to judge?

“It’s okay, honey. I trust him,” she lied. “He seems really nice.” Madison hugged him and whispered, “He wants to prove he can dirty Melissa up. Unfortunately, we don’t have the timeline for me to play too hard to get.”

Since she'd been around Prince Zaydan for a bit, Madison had realized two things about him. He loved to play the corruptor, just as she'd been told, and he was an impatient, imperious man. Slow-rolling him could be a mistake, even if they had more time. He seemed infatuated with Melissa, but another MILF could catch his eye at any time, and he could move on if he didn't think he'd get what he wanted from her. Zaydan liked coercion, but he wasn't a rapist. She hoped not, anyway.

Kane traced his hands over the stretch of her bare back between her bustier bra and panties. She was scorching in that lingerie. He wanted her all to himself and hoped she felt his erection pressing into her stomach.

"Seems like he's already dirtied you up pretty good, hasn't he?" he murmured, softly kissing her jaw. Madison softly sighed and melted into him. His balls ached for her.

She switched to the side that didn't hold the earwig, hoping the team wouldn't hear her. "Don't be a jealous asshole, Damien. Richardson would be conflicted, but remember that he wants this."

Madison traced a hand down over the front of his expensive, tailored tuxedo, upset with herself that she was so pleased by his erection. He grunted when she gripped it. It shouldn't have mattered that Kane still wanted her, but it did.

"Does he?" Kane asked, roughly kneading her ass with both hands. Perhaps softer than years ago, but it was still incredible. All he could think about was watching it while he took her from behind, and how the smug prince would be the one to enjoy that view. "Thinking you want something, and actually wanting it, are two entirely different things, darling."

Madison gave him a deep kiss that stole both their breath. His grip tightened on her, and she rubbed against his cock, sure she felt it grow. She was dying to sink to her knees and prove she was still the best Kane ever had, but that would be cheating because the mission didn't require it. She couldn't make that mistake again and betray Charles—again.

“Oh, he wants it. We all want things that aren’t good for us,” she softly replied, roughing his hair. Don’t worry, I’m not going to fuck him tonight.”

“Is there a problem?” Zaydan asked, standing beside the bed. “If you are having second thoughts...”

“Oh, no second thoughts,” she replied, kissing her husband one more time before turning to her potential lover. “I just needed to make sure Dave and I are on the same page. Everything I’ve read about this says how important communication is.”

Madison closed the distance, pressed her body into Zaydan’s arms, and kissed him. She couldn’t remember the last time she’d intimately kissed two men so close together. It was as thrilling as ever.

“I promise, she will enjoy herself, David. You’ll see.” He looked down at his redheaded prize, head full of forbidden things he wanted to do to her. Having her husband there to watch her break would make him come so much harder. But Richardson needed to know his place. The husband’s role had changed, and he needed to stay out of Zaydan’s way. Rami would make sure he did.

“Please,” she sighed, kissing him. “Go slowly and stop when I say. I don’t know what I’m ready for.” Inside, Madison was ready for the prince to use his youthful vigor and fuck her silly. But not that night. She would avoid that if she could.

“I will not rush, Melissa. I plan to enjoy every inch of your beautiful body.” He smiled and touched her mask. “May I?”

“Please. Will you remove yours, too?”

“Eventually.” Zaydan looked to his man at the door. “Rami.”

The bodyguard stepped fully into the room and closed the door behind him. The lock clicked with finality.

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Manny's heart was in his throat when he saw Madison on his monitor through Kane's covert camera feed. He thought about those photos the Wizards faked and thought, She is so much hotter in real life.

The undercover officers were in a well-appointed bedroom with mood lighting provided by wall sconces set into the dark, floral print wallpaper. The bed was a four-poster, with tall posts that ended in pinecones. An armchair was set in the corner, beside a window hidden by a heavy drape. The room looked more like something in an upscale bed & breakfast than a fuck room in a sex dungeon. Madison, in her expensive, black lace lingerie, classed the room up more.

The image from her camera went black when she got close to Zaydan. That didn't matter to Manny, who didn't care about seeing the men anyway. It had been dark when she hugged Kane, too. Whatever she'd said to him was too quiet for the comms to register, which Manny found odd. He planned to run it through filters later to see if he could up the gain and clean it up.

Kane moved around the room, jostling his camera in a way that made civilians seasick when they watched too closely, but Manny was used to watching covert camera footage. He must have decided to watch and sat in the armchair. Manny thought Cassandra was too hard on him a moment ago. It had to be weird to even pretend to be a guy who wants to watch his wife fuck other guys.

"Stop moving so much. I can't see anything when he does," Cassandra complained. Only the outside team could hear her.

"The man has to move around, Cass. Chill out," Dentiger said over comms—a rare instance of him defending the older man. He looked at the image of Madison in Zaydan's arms on an iPad in the SUV, making out with him beside the bed. Fuck, her ass is sweet, he thought. He smiled and added, "I can see just fine."



Cassandra hated his tone, but chose not to correct him. It wasn't professional, but he was looking at a half-naked woman. He was going to act the way a man acts. Even she had to admit that Madison looked good in that lingerie.

Zaydan turned Madison away from him. She faced Kane—and his camera—while her lover opened the row of hooks at the back of her bustier bra. She chewed her bottom lip and stared at her partner with a sultry look while the prince freed her breasts. The weight of them pushed the lace lingerie away from her body as the bustier opened, then dropped unceremoniously to the floor.

Manny gripped the small desk mounted in the back of the Sprinter van when he saw the slight drop of her heavy tits as they were freed. He was afraid he'd start rubbing himself through his khakis if he didn't. In his years at the Agency, he'd seen a lot of things, horrible things, comical things, but none of them got to him as much as seeing Madison, a woman he'd come to know, get undressed right before his eyes. Jesus! I'm going to watch her fuck, he thought.

Zaydan grabbed her tits from behind with both hands. He almost seemed to be weighing them or judging them at first, but it quickly became apparent that he was playing to Kane—her husband, or so he thought—and displaying Madison to him. It was a power play, saying that she was his and he was the one to show her off now, not David Richardson.

Madison pressed back against the prince as his touch became more aggressive and possessive. She braced her hands back on his thighs and lay her head on his shoulder, closing her eyes while he massaged her ample flesh. She gasped when his fingertips teased at her stiffening peaks to draw a new rush of pleasure out of her.

Manny wondered how she did it, knowing they were all watching. Maybe she likes knowing we're watching, he thought, and instantly regretted it because it made his balls ache.

Dentiger adjusted himself in his tactical pants while he watched on his own in the SUV. His mind swam with filthy thoughts about his MILFy fellow

officer. Take it, Maddy. Show us what a slut you really are. He wanted nothing more than to put a bullet in Zaydan's head, but he rooted for the man to pound the shit out of Madison.

He felt a little bad for Kane because he wasn't getting that anymore and obviously wanted to. He felt even worse for her husband. That poor bastard was somewhere back home with no idea what his slutty wife was up to.

Cassandra struggled because she didn't want to be judgmental. Madison was doing this because it was her job. She was doing it for her country. But still, Cassandra thought the older woman looked a little too into it, and she judged her for that.

Madison had to want it on some level to be so convincing. Cassandra didn't understand how she could get it up—so to speak—for such a horrible human being. She got that bad boys were hot, but Prince Zaydan bin Zalman al-Kharabati was not a mere bad boy. Within the last six months alone, he'd arranged the funding for a suicide bomb that went off on a crowded bus in Malaysia. Cassandra shuddered at the thought of his hands on her. And if none of that stopped her, the guilt of having a husband back at home would be a cold shower for her.

But a tiny part of Cassandra was jealous. She'd always been too tightly wound to just let go the way Madison did before their eyes. She was always too in her head. Her parents, who adopted her as a baby, may as well have been Korean, given how much they drilled into her that appearances mattered. She was no angel, but she couldn't do that. Cassandra could never just feel. She shifted in her sensible shoes and pressed her thighs together in her tight jeans, resenting what watching Madison stirred inside her.

## thirteen

Madison did everything she could to block out everyone else involved. She had to admit, Zaydan made it easier. His smooth, strong hands moved over her like he'd studied how to pleasure her. But there were two other men in the room, and the team was surely watching on their screens.

She couldn't think about the video recordings going into a file somewhere at Langley. They didn't have tech like that the last time she was in the field. The CIA never recorded her having sex with anyone before.

Kane was there in the corner, watching. He'd only ever been in the room, up close, to watch her once before. It was when he played broker to her penniless college student looking to make some quick cash by spending time with an oil-rich Saudi. Madison had to prove to the Saudi that she had the goods by stripping and masturbating while he watched with Kane.

That had been a surreal experience, and later, when Madison and Kane were alone in their hotel, they clawed each other's clothes off and desperately fucked all night. They even did it again in the morning before he took payment and handed her over.

Zaydan rubbed her through the sodden scrap of lace that was her panties, all four of his fingers expertly manipulating her labia until she was ready to beg him to fuck her. Madison was scared of how easily he teased her. She didn't want to think that he'd tapped into something that had been pent up inside her all these years. I love Charles. Liking this doesn't say anything about our lovemaking. She told herself that over and over again—when Zaydan let her think.

“You needed this, didn't you, Melissa?” he said, confident that he knew the answer.

He held her jaw, stopping her from kissing him, and making her stare deep into the dark pools of his eyes. The cold confidence she saw there was frightening.

“Yess...” she confessed, telling herself she was playing Melissa. His elegant fingers pushed the lace between her lips with an audible squish, making her head spin.

With the admission, he allowed her to kiss him. Madison pressed her tongue into his mouth like she was grateful for his benevolence. She’d refrained from tearing his clothes off up to that point because Melissa wouldn’t be too eager, but Zaydan felt how badly she wanted him. She reasoned the proper wife would stop pretending.

Madison pushed the stiff brocade jacket from his broad shoulders. Somehow, Rami appeared behind him to catch the hand-tailored garment and keep it from hitting the floor. She smiled and murmured against Zaydan’s lips, “Is he going to help me undress you?”

“Rami is here to attend to my needs. You should be so lucky to have such an attendant.”

The prince stroked his thumb along her cheek, and Madison saw him resist the urge to perhaps slap her and punish her for her insolence. His impulse disgusted her, but the danger thrilled her. She ignored the disgust and kissed him again. His desire for her made Madison throb to her core. She’d forgotten how exciting that raw desire from a man could be.

His chest was covered with black hair that had been shaved down to a smooth dusting over his pecs and abs. She wondered if Rami did that for the prince, too. Zaydan was lean and muscular, but he didn’t have a six-pack like a gym rat. His body was impressive, and Madison touched him everywhere, finding that having a fit, younger man after so many years was intoxicating. His hand covered hers when she reached for his belt.

“Tell me you want it, Melissa.” He pressed more firmly into her cleft. She gasped and stiffened, taking a moment to just feel it.

“I want it, Zay... I want to feel what you have... God...you’re driving me crazy...”

“That’s because you need a proper fucking, Melissa.”

Madison didn’t agree, but she did unbuckle his fine leather belt and unfasten his pants. She reached into the smoothest underwear she’d ever felt on a man and grasped one of the thicker roots she’d ever had in her hands. He smiled when he saw the surprise on her face.

Kane bristled while he watched Madison throw herself at the arrogant prince. He doesn’t deserve this. He doesn’t deserve her. Understanding that deserve had nothing to do with it made no difference. Watching Madison like that felt wrong on every level.

“Do you like a big cock, Melissa?” Zaydan asked.

“Size doesn’t matter as much as you guys think it does. It’s how you use it.” Madison kept pumping him, and he kept thickening in her hand. She thrilled, thinking he might exceed her grasp. She was half-lying about size.

Zaydan chuckled. This American woman amused him. She had a rebellious streak that most of her ilk didn’t. Their efforts at being playful were insipid. He would enjoy proving to her just how much she needed his cock.

“I assure you, Melissa, you will not be disappointed with its use.”

Sitting her on the bed, he shed his shirt, smirking when he tossed it onto the floor. Rami kept his station by the door. He could be as slovenly as American men. He put his boot on the bed beside her and unzipped it when she didn’t do it for him.

After slipping it off, he put up the other one, and she took the hint, looking up at him with amusement while she unzipped the boot and pulled it off. But he saw the dormant submission behind that playfulness. She was a woman who needed a strong man. Zaydan would teach her what she needed.

He dropped his pants and fought every instinct, leaving them crumpled on the floor. In the palace, someone would have rushed forward to take them. Madison didn't move to clean up after him, but just watched him. He didn't mind; he could see how distracted she was by the bulge in his black silk boxers. She couldn't hide her reaction when he dropped the boxers. His cock sprang out and nearly smacked her in the face. It pulsed with a life of its own, and she seemed entranced by it.

Zaydan stared at her and stroked it, thinking, yes, this is for you, American whore. And you will learn to properly worship it. She reached out and took over. Her fingers looked pale and dainty, wrapped around his thick, dark meat. He always loved the contrast when he bedded Western and Japanese women.

He moved it toward her face, and she turned her head slightly. She wanted it. It was in her eyes. He would be patient for now. "Show me yours then," he said.

Madison only hesitated for a moment before lifting her hips enough to roll her panties down her legs. She tried to sit with her knees together, but Zaydan nudged them apart with his. He read hesitation and worry on her face when she looked up at him, and it made him want her so much more.

His fingers slipped right up her furrow. She was drenched for him. Of course, you are, he thought. I can't wait to hear you beg to come. Madison gasped when he nudged his digits deeper into her pussy. She opened her legs wider. Zaydan curved them up and into her, hitting that special spot. She tensed, then raised her hips to pull his fingers deeper.

"Ohhh...Zay...I don't know..." she gasped.

"Oh, you know." He smirked. "You know exactly what you want, don't you? Are you being shy because your husband is here?" He looked over at Kane. "Do you want us to stop?"

Kane stewed in his chair. The gulf between what he wanted to tell the smug young prick and what he knew he had to say was massive. But watching Madison just spread her legs for the prince filled him with an unexpected,

bitter jealousy that he didn't expect and didn't know how to handle. He'd always been a little jealous when she slept with a mark, but it was nothing like what he felt in that room. Fortunately, he was a professional above all else, and he understood his role.

"No." Kane's reply was a low rumble. "Not if Mel wants to keep going."

"See, he wants this for you. Don't you want it for yourself?" Zaydan asked, fingers moving faster inside her.

Madison found it harder and harder to play hard to get. She wasn't the shrinking violet that Melissa Richardson should be, and she was out of practice pretending to be someone else. Zaydan's fingers stoked a fire inside her that she struggled to control.

She was drawing on the one thing she had. Her love for Charles. That love gave her the hesitation she needed, but it came with an overwhelming wave of guilt and shame. Madison loved her husband, yet she was drenched for Zaydan. How was that anything but shameful?

The prince guided her onto the bed, somehow without his fingers even leaving her pussy. Maybe they did. Everything was becoming a jumble for Madison. It felt like everything got real when they were on the bed. They were in each other's arms, kissing, touching, enjoying each other's bodies. She reached for him. He felt even thicker in her hand than he'd looked when he dropped his pants. She stroked him tentatively, the way Melissa would. It still felt wrong to have another man's cock in her hand for the first time in sixteen years.

Zaydan's beard was impossibly soft against her skin when he slid lower to tease her breasts. She hated how all that product felt in his hair, but she ran her fingers through it anyway and held his mouth to her. His hungry suckling was unrelenting. He didn't tease her nipples the way other men did, but latched on like he wanted to feed, working his tongue and only occasionally nipping with his teeth.

Pleasure bloomed from her tits, making her pussy clench around his relentless fingers. She needed to be filled, and as good as they felt, his

fingers weren't what she needed. Madison knew what would satisfy her. She'd seen it between his legs. She reminded herself, You're not fucking him tonight. You're not fucking him at all if you don't have to. Get a grip!

"Ahhh god...yesss...Zay...god yesss..."

His hungry mouth and those expert fingers rocketed her right to the edge. Zaydan slipped out of her, and she whimpered, so close, but denied. Madison wanted to shove his fingers back inside and demand that he finish her. But he wasn't just teasing. Instead of finger-fucking her, he pressed the full heel of his hand to her pussy, slowly mashing down to apply serious pressure to her labia, and stimulating everything at once. It was a new move for Madison, and she lost her mind.

"Fuck! Yesss...yesss...ohhh fuck...like that...god, just like that..."

He directed most of the pressure to her clit, working it in a rocking motion while he intensely suckled her nipple. That was all she needed. The orgasm slammed her like a tsunami of ecstasy. Madison felt like his hard massage of her pussy pushed it right out of her. And he kept rubbing, making her feel like the pleasure would never end.

"Zay...oh fuck...god, yes! Yes! Ohmygod! Fuck!"

The climax Kane gave her when he went down on her a week earlier had been intense, but Zaydan literally made her come harder than she had in years—maybe in over a decade. She'd forgotten she could come so hard.

Kane refused to touch himself, even though watching Madison come like that turned his cock to steel. His thick shaft was at an awkward angle, but he left it that way, deciding the discomfort was his penance for his confusing feelings for Madison.

He'd been kicking himself ever since he went down on Madison. It was a mistake, and he'd known it the second he left that bedroom. Having his hands on her earlier that night and then seeing her in nothing but that towel left him unable to resist temptation. Kane knew she was as horny as he was



and took advantage of her weak moment. He hadn't forced himself on her, but he should have respected her marriage and restrained himself.

Madison was still trembling, her eyes closed, when Zaydan slid between her thighs. He moved on top of her like it was his right. Perhaps he did deserve to claim Madison after making her come so hard, but that was not part of the plan. Her body still throbbed, but she could not give in to that. Melissa was never a fuck-on-the-first-date kind of girl, she thought.

"Zay...wait...no..." she panted, pushing against his shoulders with both hands.

The weight of his thick shaft dragged along her lips, and she ached for him to put it inside her, but she held onto the things she valued the most and found the strength to deny him. It was a calculation that forcing him to wait would only make him want her more.

"Are we still playing games, Melissa? I thought we were past that."

Zaydan teased his blunt tip along her folds, and her insides lurched in anticipation. Madison wanted this. Badly.

"No...Zay...not tonight...please..."

Madison pushed harder against his shoulders, telling him the please was not a request. For a moment, she thought she was wrong about the young prince, and he would try to force himself on her.

Mission or not, that would not go well for Zaydan. She would not lie there and let him take what he wanted without a fight. She knew Kane would back her play and deal with Rami if it came to that. Just as she braced herself for leverage, Zaydan rolled off her with a grunt.

"You American women, so puritanical. You want to fuck, but you deny yourselves pleasure. So insane!" he grumbled.

*And in Kharabat, you'd chop off my tits if I pursued my pleasure, she thought. Madison pushed her anger at his hypocrisy—being angry and*

*horny was another feeling she'd forgotten in her years with Charles—away and grabbed his hot shaft again, tightly pumping it, squeezing until she could close her fingers around it.*

“It’ll be worth it. I promise, Zay. Just not tonight.”

His look sent a shiver down her spine. It said, you’ll pay for making me wait. The dark part of Madison wanted him to make her pay. She deserved to be punished for all of this.

Madison pushed her hair back behind her ear, wishing she had a scrunchie, and leaned down to take him in her mouth. She wouldn’t fuck him, but she couldn’t leave him hanging either. He couldn’t think this was a waste of time. She had to keep him on the hook.

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Keeping a tight grip on his base, she stretched her lips around his impressive girth. Trying to fit Zaydan in her mouth was very different than sucking her husband’s cock, and her skills had gotten rusty. But she breathed through her nose and opened her mouth wider, stuffing more of Zaydan into her mouth. Madison wanted it to be a chore, but touching him, sucking him, just made her want him inside her even more.

It had been quite a shock when he dropped his pants, and his cock was right in her face. She’d known it was big when she touched it, but that wasn’t the same as having it hard and pulsing right in her face.

She’d never seen a fully waxed one before. It was as smooth as her pussy, which stood out even more on Zaydan because of the dark, buzzed-down hair on his chest and legs. Madison had to admit that a smooth cock was much more enjoyable to play with than an ungroomed one.

“Mmm...there’s the fire...the hunger...let it out, Melissa...yesss...that’s it...”

Zaydan’s praise made her suck harder. She pushed, taking him deeper. The spicy scent of his fragrance was even stronger down there, like he’d spritzed his cologne onto his cock and balls, which seemed so weird, but it wasn’t unpleasant. Certainly better than if he were musty and unclean.

“Yesss...show me...show me how you want it, sweet Melissa...”

His moans were a constant, low rumble through his body, like a cat purring. He stared down at her with triumph and desire. Zaydan lived for that moment when another man’s wife took his cock into her mouth. His gaze flicked to Kane. That was part of the thrill, having the husband watch his wife’s hunger for him.

Kane saw that smug look of victory and hated the prince more than ever. That look said, of course she needs my cock. She’s not getting what she needs from you. Your wife is a cock-hungry slut. Madison wasn’t even really his woman—not anymore—but Kane still wanted to lurch out of the chair and stab Zaydan in the neck. The knife tucked into his boot had gone undetected. Rami would surely get in his way, but he could take the man.

More than he hated that look on Zaydan’s face, Kane despised the way watching Madison suck that cock made him feel. He hated his erection. The prince was getting what he couldn’t have, and Kane wanted to murder the man for it. He knew Madison’s body language. She was into it. She wanted that cock in her mouth. Zaydan was right to look triumphant.

*She must have been a terror when she was younger, Zaydan thought. A woman only sucked cock like that if she had plenty of practice. I bet you sucked your way through entire frat houses, didn’t you? He knew better than to confront Madison with her slutty past. These American women loved to pretend they were something they were not. But once he peeled back that veneer of respectability, he would know all her secrets.*

Zaydan wound his fingers through her wonderful red hair, enjoying the feeling of her strong bobbing motion. He didn’t even have to shove his cock

down her throat. She was eagerly sucking him all on her own. He used her hair to pull her off his meat—but only enough that she could answer him. The blunt tip of his weapon rested on her full lips, and she rubbed them against it.

“When did you last have another man’s cock in your mouth, Melissa? Other than David’s?” His voice was thick with desire.

“So long...” she panted, eyes hooded with need. She flicked her tongue out across his head.

“Too long?” He smirked. When she didn’t take the bait, he asked, “When did you last have David’s cock in your mouth?”

Rather than answer, Madison just pushed her lips back over his girth. He’d let her get away with it this time.

Melissa would never answer him, and Madison certainly was not going to—even if Kane was her real husband. It was a shitty trick for Zaydan to pull. She ignored it and sucked him faster, pumping the portion she couldn’t stuff into her mouth with her hand, and working her tongue against him as much as his girth allowed in her crowded mouth. She wanted to get him off and get on with the real mission.

Zaydan grunted when she massaged his hairless balls, and tensed when her outstretched pinky nail tickled his taint. She could have sucked his balls if she really wanted to impress him, but Melissa Richardson probably did not suck balls. He would need to think he had convinced her to do it if that happened. His breath came harder. She knew he was close.

Madison fought her gag reflex when he added pressure. His fingers tightened in her hair. He was close and wanted to be in control when he came. His blunt head stretched the back of her throat, and her nostrils flared as she tried to breathe. Her hand drifted between her legs without conscious thought. His aggression was her drug, and his arrogance made it even hotter.

“Like it a little rough...don’t you...” Zaydan was panting, so close. He held her head in place and pumped his cock into her mouth faster. “Almost there...yesss...Melissa...just like that...”

Madison had trouble keeping up. She hated that the team was seeing her like that, cheeks hollowed and flushed, hair wild, eagerly sucking Zaydan. She hated that they heard the wet, sucking sounds coming from Zaydan using her mouth. Dentiger probably loved it. That haughty bitch Cassandra was probably disgusted. Manny was probably hard. She’d caught the way he looked at her. She didn’t want to know what was in Kane’s head.

Kane burned with jealousy, but god was watching Madison suck that cock hot. Seeing her do it as a mature woman, with kids and a respectable life, was even hotter than it had been when she was younger and reckless. He still hated how much he liked it, but he was gradually surrendering to the reality that he got off on watching her.

Zaydan grunted her name—her false name—and held it in her mouth while he finished. His balls tightened, and the thick rush of his release filled her mouth. Madison choked and pushed against his thighs, but he kept her there while she struggled to swallow.

Her fingers were busy on her clit, and the sharp orgasm they brought made swallowing even harder because she stopped thinking. Cum bubbled down her chin and dripped back onto his thighs. Zaydan didn’t release her head until he’d drained every last drop into her mouth. His smile was victorious.

“You are remarkable, Melissa. Very impressive. You should be proud, David.”

Zaydan’s breathing was already returning to normal. She reflected that he must have been in incredible shape. He didn’t seem strained at all.

“Are you okay, darling?” Kane asked, biting back every natural response he had.

Madison coughed and sniffled, wiping her mouth on the back of her hand. She knew she was a mess and tried to keep her face away from Kane’s

covert camera. Even looking the prince in the eyes felt like too much. She needed a minute to gather herself.

“It was a lot,” she admitted.

“Too much?” Zaydan asked.

The comment irked her, and she did look right at him when she said, “No. Never.”

“Good to hear. And how about you, David? Was watching your magnificent wife perform everything you hoped for, my friend?”

*You're not my friend, asshole, he thought. Kane said, "Mel is incredible. Incandescent. Watching her was...very hot." The confession felt too personal because it was real.*

“Please. You must enjoy her then. I am sure your balls ache for release.”

Zaydan slid off the bed and held out his hand, offering Madison up to Kane. He was flushed with endorphins from his release, feeling supremely confident. He wanted to press his control over the couple to see how far he could push them.

“Mel and I will reconnect,” Kane evenly replied. His real wife or not, he didn’t need the prince offering Madison to him.

“Now. Please. I know reclamation is important to couples...like you. And besides, I would still like to see the way Melissa fucks. Don’t you want your husband to fuck you?”

Madison felt trapped. She couldn’t say no, for so many reasons. But she didn’t want to fuck Kane, and especially not with an audience. Melissa would not want to have sex with the prince and his bodyguard watching. She looked from Kane to Zaydan and tried to form an authentic response.

“I do... But we don’t do that in front of other people.” She hoped she sounded excited, but shyly unsure.

Zaydan chuckled, amused by their reticence. “We’re in a sex club. I’d love to spend more time together, Melissa, but only if I can be sure you’re truly open. Fucking your own husband should not be such a big ask.”

“We’re not puppets,” Kane interrupted, coming out of the chair. Rami took a step forward, and the spy shot him a warning look.

“Do it,” Cassandra ordered in their ears. “This is an obvious test, and you can’t fail it.”

Kane was so shocked by the command that he almost replied to her in the room. It was not her place to order them to fuck. There had to be a line. Let Cassandra come in and fuck someone, he thought.

Madison got onto her knees on the bed and told Kane, “Come here, honey.”

“Mad...Mel...you don’t have to...”

She looked at Zaydan to her side before fixing her eyes on her partner. “Come here. I want to, honey.” She hated how much it sounded like she meant it.

“Very good! Listen to the woman, David. She needs a good fucking!”

Kane grumbled and walked to the bed.

## fourteen

Dentiger snapped a quick series of photos of the tablet when Kane walked toward Madison in the bedroom. It was a perfect view of her nude body as she knelt on the bed waiting for her lover. Fuck! he thought. She was hotter than she had any right to be.

He got that actresses and celebrities her age maintained their hotness, but they had personal trainers and nutritionists, and every image they ever posted was filtered to within an inch of its life. Madison looked incredible, kneeling there in all her glory in the image from Kane's high-res covert camera. She wasn't even in shape because she was a field officer. She'd been sitting behind a desk since Obama was president. Dentiger smiled, thinking how he'd love to get his hands on that.

*She's got fucking great tits, he marveled again. He couldn't get over how full and round they were in her late forties and after two kids. He'd never seen a woman her age naked in person, but he did not think they looked like that. He considered that he may need to expand his horizons. The only disappointment was that she wasn't fully shaved. Her landing strip had to go. Dentiger was more than happy to offer to shave her himself.*

He lost his view when Kane got too close and the camera went black, with jumbled flashes of light. It was all audio after that. The couple's murmured conversation and the obvious sounds of them kissing. Dentiger's mind filled in the blanks.

*They're really doing this, he thought. Cass ordering them to fuck was stone cold. That woman is lethal. Somehow, that seemed worse than if she'd ordered Kane to pull out a weapon and shoot Zaydan in the head.*

Madison and Kane would be kissing and touching each other while she undressed him. Dentiger imagined Kane's hands were all over those tits. He



knew his would be. He'd want to grab her pussy and see how aroused she got for that terrorist. She's probably so fucking wet he'll slide right in. She sucked that dick like she couldn't get enough of it. Madison's been playing all reserved and uptight, but she's been dying for a real fucking all this time, he thought. All she had to do was ask if she needed to get fucked.

After a series of jagged images, Kane's camera pointed up at the dark ceiling and didn't move. Dentiger was left watching what happened on Madison's locket camera. He had no interest in seeing Kane's come face. He closed his eyes and chose to go on picturing what was happening in his head.

Cassandra had a pit in her stomach after she gave the order. Her concern wasn't over a superior having an issue with such an intimate directive. Times hadn't changed that much at the Agency. It was still expected that officers would make whatever sacrifices were necessary to complete the mission. The Deputy Director would have her back anyway. Her tension was knowing she'd have to face Madison and Kane later. Especially Madison. Cassandra understood what she was asking of the officer.

The pushback she expected from the faux couple didn't come. Despite the confidence she'd expressed to Dentiger, she didn't know if Madison would do what was required when the moment came. Her officer sucking Prince Zaydan's cock had been a pleasant surprise. Even more surprising was how good she'd been at it. Cassandra thought suburban moms didn't suck dick at Madison's age.

Instead of finding an excuse, Madison told Kane to come to her.

Cassandra watched her camera. She didn't need to see her officer naked. Besides, the more time she spent looking at the older spy, the more she came to appreciate his sexiness. It was an uncomfortable feeling.

Manny's labored breathing in front of her was disturbing. He was a man, but she expected more restraint from the officers she worked with. Cassandra knew that if he'd been alone in that van, he'd have been jerking off. She shuddered at the thought. He'd better keep it in his pants.

Watching Madison Sinclair give that blowjob and then tell Kane to come and fuck her was one of the hottest things Manny had ever seen. He couldn't wait to return to Philadelphia and review the footage in private.

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"It's okay..." Madison whispered when she nibbled on Kane's ear and kissed the side of his face while she undressed him.

"We can find another way," he softly replied, kissing her.

Their lips locked together in a fierce kiss. She closed her eyes and there it was again—the intervening sixteen years melted away. Kissing Kane was as intense as it had ever been for her. She was scared by how much she ached for him. He pulled his lips back from hers, and she saw her raw need reflected in his eyes.

"I know you want this, baby. Don't hold back..."

Madison could have admitted that she wanted it, too. Maybe she should have. But that felt so wrong. Charles was still in her head. She'd been using thoughts of her innocent husband to mitigate her behavior all evening, but they had become an anchor. She felt like a terrible person because her intense guilt didn't stop her from wanting Kane. It's the job, she told herself, knowing it was a half-truth at best.

Once Kane was undressed, he lay her on the bed, their kisses becoming steamier as their legs intertwined and their hands explored each other's bodies. He remembered a time when he'd had her body memorized the way a blind man knows his home, every touch ingrained in him. Her body was still so familiar. Kissing her still felt like home. But her body was also so different after sixteen years. Madison was softer, curvier, so many more freckles—and he wanted to kiss every one. But when he nibbled the spot

behind her ear, she still gasped and pressed to him just like his Madison always had.

Kane wanted her so badly, but it still felt strange—wrong even. When he went down on her a week earlier, he wasn't thinking. He acted on pure adrenaline and instinct, and her body responded to him. They were working now. Playing roles. He had to stay focused and in the moment because al-Kharabati was right there, watching them. They had to play it right. But Kane still hated the thought that Madison was only fucking him because she had to.

Wrapping her hand around Kane's shaft felt right, even though she knew it was wrong. How many times had she held his cock? They were hot and heavy way back when, fucking every chance they got. Madison missed the heady feeling that she couldn't wait to get her clothes off and get him inside her. The guilt still hung over her like storm clouds, but it faded into the background, just like clouds always did when the rain never came.

Madison pulled Kane toward her as she rolled onto her back. She opened for him, holding his tip against her slickness. Kane kissed her with the pent-up desire of decades, but she still saw worry and desire war in his eyes. She touched his face with her free hand.

"Make love to me, baby. Please."

She didn't use a name because she did not want to call him Dave in that moment, and she didn't think Melissa would say fuck me. But her words still felt like a betrayal to Charles. That guilt was buried under an avalanche of pleasure when Kane thrust inside her.

"Ohmygod...yesss...baby...yesss..."

Kane felt her tighten around him and paused for a moment to enjoy it. He needed it even more than he realized. Her heat threatened to melt him quickly—too quickly. He moaned when her sheath rippled around him. There had been a lot of women since they'd last been together, but Madison remained the best fuck he'd ever had.

Madison locked her legs around him and urged with her thighs. She needed Kane to move—to fuck her. She was finally getting what she'd needed all night, and she didn't want to wait any longer for it.

Zaydan felt his cock plumping as he watched the married couple fuck. He'd slipped his underwear back on and leaned against the wall near the bed with his arms crossed, rather than retreating to the chair where the husband had sat.

The couple's lovemaking was more intense than what he usually witnessed from a long-married couple. Their passion was that of people who couldn't keep their hands off each other, not ones who'd been married for decades. They were obviously much more into bringing someone else into their bed than they let on. It pleased the prince.

Watching them together made Zaydan more determined to have Madison in every way possible. Claiming such a wife from a man who was so deeply devoted to her would be a delight. He would make her do things her husband would never dream of requesting, that he'd never even thought of. The man would never look at his wife the same way again when Zaydan was finished with her.

“Ohhh god...yesss...ohmygod yesss...baby...yess...ahhh...”

“Fuck...ohhh... fuck yesss...”

Zaydan glanced at his man in the room. Rami watched the rutting couple with special interest. The prince knew that watching these Western sluts was a special perk of the job for him. He loved to see his master break them because he regarded all of them as amoral whores. Rami knew a proper, devout Muslim woman would never dare to behave like these sluts. Zaydan appreciated his bodyguard's zeal, but his worldview was more flexible. However, sometimes he allowed Rami to take out his zeal on his women once he was finished with them.

Madison clung to Kane, nails digging into his shoulders, locking her heels behind his back for leverage to pull her hips back up at him. He drove into

her so hard. It was incredible. She hadn't had a pounding like that in years, and it was rocking her world.

“Harder! Ohhh fuck...harder, baby...yesss...do it...ohhh fuck...just like that...”

“Fuck...goddam it, Mmm...Mel...fuck...”

Kane scooped a hand under her soft ass and leaned in, putting all of his power into his strokes. Typical Maddy, always demanding—not asking—for more, he thought. He loved her fire. The shift tilted her hips, pressing her legs back. Her thighs trembled around him. This is what you want? Does he fuck you like this, Maddy? He smiled when her eyes went wide.

“Ohhhh fuck....yesss... Yes!”

Madison howled through a brain-shredding orgasm. Kane's subtle shift had him hitting the perfect spot inside her. God, he was so deep! She cried out again as it all overwhelmed her, and she became nothing but the ecstasy that possessed her. Head lolling to the side, she saw Zaydan staring at her like a hungry wolf. That look sent a shiver down her spine and made her come that much harder.

Kane wanted to hold out because he needed a good showing against her husband, and the eventual fucking she'd take from the prince, but her molten, coming pussy was too much to resist, certainly after weeks of thinking about that exact moment. He roared and shanked his cock deep inside Madison. She released a fresh, sharp cry—sounding surprised—when he unleashed and flooded her.

Madison's climax was trending down when Kane embedded himself and his release pulsed deep inside her. Feeling his seed claim her triggered a new, deep throb of pleasure that felt so much more intimate than her first orgasm. Her dark side understood that the very wrongness of the act was what made it so hot.

This was not her husband. Another man—a former lover—was flooding her pussy with his seed. Fucking Kane had been wrong, but letting him finish

inside her was a claiming. A much deeper betrayal. And she could never apologize enough for how good it felt. The moment was a stark reminder that being at her worst had always felt the best. Madison realized she'd been foolish to believe she'd left that side of her behind.

She wanted to turn away when Kane kissed her, but Zaydan was watching. The deep, slow kiss felt too intimate after what they'd just done. It was pouring gasoline on the growing bonfire of her guilt. Kane brushed her now-sweaty hair back from her face.

"You're incredible, darling," he said, the way he looked at her making Madison want to shove him away.

Instead, she gave him a peck back and said, "You are, baby. I couldn't have asked for a better man. I love you so much." The performance twisted her gut.

"I love seeing such a devoted couple. It's truly inspiring. I hope I find love like that someday," Zaydan said. He picked up his pants and began to dress. "Will you too be back again tomorrow night? I'd love to get to know you better."

"Twice in one weekend? That sounds like a lot," Madison said, trying to sound scandalized like Melissa would, instead of fearful like she actually felt. She needed a break from the excesses of Nox Venari, or she might lose herself.

"We have another engagement," Kane added, pushing off Madison and sliding out of her with a slick sound.

"What are you two doing?" Cassandra chirped in their ears. "If he wants to see you again, you'll be there!"

"That's too bad. I like to keep momentum going," Zaydan said. He was buttoning his shirt.

"Are you always here all weekend?" Madison asked. She wanted to cover herself, but they were on top of the sheets. She draped an arm across her

breasts and casually laid a hand over her swollen pussy.

“Not always, no. But I have friends in from out of town.”

Shit, Madison thought. She knew they had to go back on Saturday night. But before she could tell the prince they could change their plans, he took his jacket from Rami and was on his way out the door.

“Well, I look forward to seeing you...both of you...again soon.”

“Zay...” she started, but he was already gone.

“How did you let that happen?” Cassandra was shouting in their ears. “Get after him and fix this. The company has to be the Russians.”

“Calm the fuck down, Cass,” Kane said, hopping off the bed to find his clothes. “Al-Kharabati knows people all over the world. We don’t know it’s the Russians.”

“You can’t assume it’s not the Russians, dipshit,” Dentiger chimed in.

“You can fuck right off,” Kane snapped back.

“We’ll fix this,” Madison said, being the adult in the room.

She rolled off the bed and looked for her panties on the floor. The scrap of black lace was difficult to find in the dim lighting. Are there any real lights in this place? She gave up and pulled her bra into place.

“Could you?” she asked Kane, turning her back to him. She hated it, but the bustier bra had too many hooks in the back to fasten herself. Cassandra had helped her put it on back in Philadelphia.

Kane stood too close while she slowly worked his way up her spine. She was more aware of it than ever. “I’m usually doing this the other way,” he said.

“Can you just...hurry up? We need to catch him before he disappears.”

“We can just show up, Maddy. He’s not going to question it when he sees you in whatever you choose for our next visit to this place.”

“Damien... Just...”

Madison felt him finish with her bra and pulled away from him. His cum was running down her thigh, and she squeezed her legs together. God, I’m a slut. She wiggled back into her dress and went back to Kane to zip her. He was popping the studs back into his tuxedo shirt.

After zipping her, he slid the earwig out of his ear and held it in his fist. He stared at her until she did the same. The team would not be able to hear them.

“Don’t you think we should talk? About...” he said.

*Christ, is he doing this now? I thought I was the woman here? Madison had no desire to discuss her feelings with Kane. It was literally the last thing she wanted to do. Running after Zaydan was suddenly much more attractive.*

Voice low, she replied, “There’s nothing to talk about. We were doing our jobs.”

“That was just work? Bullshit, Maddy. You felt that, too.”

Madison took a deep breath, sorry that she had to be so hard. “It was fucking, Damien. Yes, it felt good. We were always good at that, weren’t we? I guess we’ve still got it. But it was just fucking, and yes, it was just the job. Can we go after Zaydan now, please?”

Kane looked like she’d slapped him. She ignored it and put her earwig back in place. Cassandra was shouting into the comms channel.

“What the hell are you two doing? Can you hear me? Manny, what’s wrong now?”

“We hear you. I’m going to run Peacock down now,” Madison responded.



Kane stood like a statue while she tried to balance and pull her heels back on. She did not have time to soothe his ego. She didn't even know what he expected. She left him standing there and headed for the door. He could catch up.

"Maddy, wait."

She turned, annoyed. But he wasn't going to pour his heart out. He had her mask. Kane placed it over her eyes and tied it behind her head. He even fluffed her hair back into place over it. She didn't even want to think about how her hair looked.

"Go get him. Seduce that bastard," he stoically said.

---

Madison couldn't be sure whether she was more relieved to catch the prince at the bar downstairs or to be away from Kane. Her partner was taking his sweet time following her. She stopped short when she saw Zaydan standing with three other men at the bar. It was clear he hadn't just run into them there.

Rami spotted her first and stepped between Madison and his charge. He was not going to allow the boss to be interrupted. That was when she was sure Zaydan was meeting with the Russians. Rami knew what his boss wanted. He wouldn't stand between the prince and Madison without good reason.

She began scheming on how to catch Zaydan's eye when he saw her past Rami's bulk. He tapped the tall, dark-haired man he'd been speaking with on the shoulder and smiled.

"Melissa, please, join us."

She returned his smile and elbowed past Rami to get to the prince, whose arm slid right around her waist like he was her boyfriend. Maybe he was, in

a way. After all, Madison had just sucked his cock and swallowed his load. God, I was kissing Damien right after that. I didn't even think! What was he thinking?

"I'm so happy to see you. I thought perhaps you and David would need some time to discuss the night's events and reconnect. I'm pleased to see that you are so flexible."

"Dave will be along. I just didn't want you to leave before I got to tell you how much fun tonight was. I never expected... I almost feel like a different woman..." she gushed.

"I don't know why David would let you out of his sight. Especially now that he knows what you're capable of, Melissa."

Zaydan was glowing because she'd chased after him. Madison was glad Operation Scarlet Phantom was going so well, but secretly, she was also thrilled he was so taken with her. The prince may have been a terrorist, but a girl wanted to be wanted. She needed something to feel good about with all that guilt crushing down on her. I'm so sorry, Charles.

Madison tried to kiss Zaydan, but he gave her his cheek and pressed his drink into her hand. Kane made out with her after she'd taken the prince's load in her mouth, but the man who supplied it was more squeamish. She sipped the smooth whiskey and tried to kiss him again. This time, Zaydan declared his claim on her with his tongue.

"David? Who is this David? And who is this sexy woman, my friend?"

The questions were asked in a thick Russian accent. She looked up at the speaker from her position against Zaydan. The Russian was average height, but that still made him shorter than Madison was those her spiked heels that put her at close to six feet tall. He was a thick-necked man whose black hair had been treated to tacky blonde highlights. Still, he might have been a handsome man if he hadn't seemed like such a brute.

Madison couldn't see his entire face—he wore one of the club's generic harlequin masks—but something was familiar about him. She didn't think

he'd been in their briefing packet, and she couldn't possibly know him. He was a young man in his late twenties, not someone she could have encountered in the field in the past.

"David is her husband, Sergei. The three of us were just having some fun upstairs. He lent Melissa to me tonight. I'm hoping it's the first of many nights." Zaydan kissed her again, just to prove he could.

The Russian shook his head. "These games you play. I know you enjoy them, but they would get your throat cut in Moscow." He laughed, but there was no warmth to it.

"Are you saying that you've never slept with another man's woman?" Zaydan asked.

"Once she's had my cock, she is only mine." Sergei laughed again and grabbed the front of his slacks.

Madison rolled her eyes. The hypermasculine energy made her gag. "I'm right here, guys."

"Of course. I am sorry. Melissa, yes? Surely we have met before. I know I have seen you. Yes?"

"We've only been to the club once before, but I know what you mean. I've never been to Moscow."

"How do you know I am from Moscow?" His eyes narrowed behind the mask.

Madison knew a Moscow accent from a mile away. She was sure she could still conjure one if she had to, but it had been ages. She told him, "You just mentioned Moscow, didn't you? I'm sorry, I just assumed that was your home."

Sergei smiled, showing a gold tooth. The smile was cruel. "I grew up in Moscow, but after my father's business interests changed, our family moved around. He sends his regards, by the way, your highness."

Zaydan laughed. “I keep telling you, it’s Zaydan. It would not be your highness anyway.”

Kane chose that moment to show up. He assessed the situation as he approached the group. He didn’t know exactly what was going on, but surmised the men with the prince must be the Russians. He hated that Cassandra was right. He wanted to take his place at Madison’s side, but that bastard Zaydan was all over her.

“Ah, you must be this David I keep hearing about. The man who shares his wife.”

Sergei didn’t even mask the contempt in his voice. He offered his hand and tried to crush Kane’s, but the spy was not the cuckold Sergei thought he was. Kane was pleased with the Russian’s surprise at his grip.

“David Richardson, pleased to meet you.”

“Likewise. I am Sergei. Sergei Reznikov. Perhaps you can help me recall where I know your lovely wife from.”

Both CIA officers froze at the name. Reznikov. It conjured nothing but memories of blood and violence. Kane remembered how he’d almost lost his life at the hands of a Reznikov. It was not a common Russian surname. He glanced at Madison, who was pale as a sheet. Why did she look like she’d seen a ghost?

Madison wanted to tear away from Zaydan and run from Nox Venari. It couldn’t be. He sends his regards. Sergei’s father. A man who could not be alive.

When she squinted, she could see the boy Sergei had been. He’d been sent to see his father at the family dacha outside of Moscow two or three times while she’d been there, posing as the former Ukrainian ballet dancer turned shot girl, Milica Jovanovic. Sergei would have only been about thirteen at the time, still a boy. But a boy whose eyes hungrily followed her around that dacha.

*He can't possibly recognize me. Not after all this time. That was a lifetime ago. Madison was thankful for the mask anyway. Still, the sound of the conversation and music around her faded into the background like she was hearing it underwater. She was preoccupied with one thought. An impossible thought.*

Anatoly Reznikov was alive.

To be concluded in the final installment of Undercover Wife, Scarlet Phantom, coming in January!

## undercover wife: scarlet phantom



**Sixteen years behind a desk made Madison Sinclair forget how dangerous desire can be.**

Now she's trading soccer mom respectability for the shadowed decadence of Nox Venari—the world's most exclusive playground for the powerful and depraved. Her mission: become irresistible to Prince Zaydan al-Kharabati, the ruthless head of an international terror network, who hunts married Western women like prey, breaking them for sport.

The bait? Madison herself—wrapped in silk and sin, playing the bored wife seeking forbidden thrills.

The complication? Her fake husband is Damien Kane—the ex-partner who once knew every inch of her body, every vulnerability in her armor.

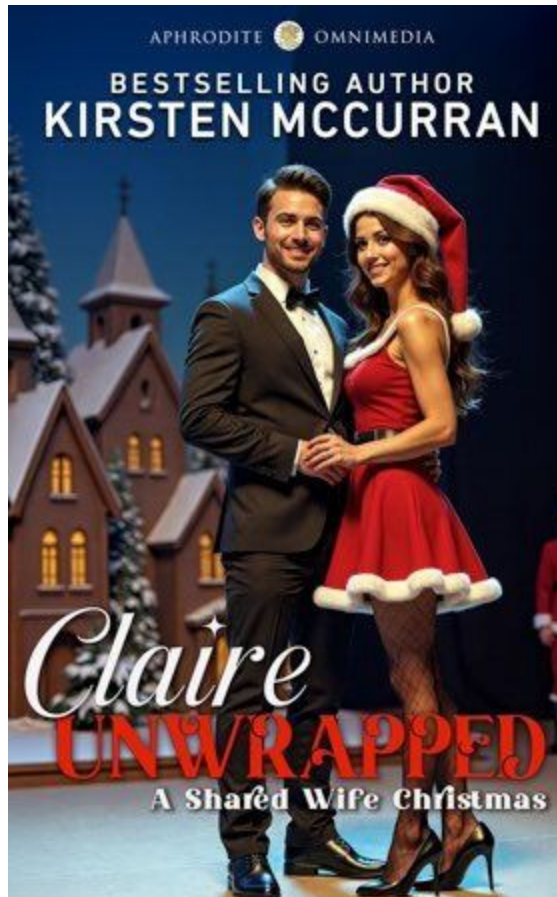
Prince Zaydan holds the key to Null:Echo, a quantum weapon that could plunge the world into chaos. The exchange will happen inside Nox Venari's velvet shadows, where temptation lurks around every corner, inhibitions shatter, and Madison must surrender everything to get close enough to strike.

But seduction is a blade that cuts both ways. As Madison descends deeper into the prince's twisted games—with Damien watching, wanting, remembering—she discovers the most dangerous territory isn't the mission. It's how much she's willing to sacrifice.

Madison will put everything on the line for her country and her family, knowing that success could mean losing everything. Undercover Wife: Scarlet Phantom is the thrilling conclusion to the Undercover Wife trilogy!

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# claire unwrapped



**Once, she was everyone's fantasy. This Christmas, she's about to become her own.**

At forty-eight, Claire Weston is a small-town celebrity. Every December she takes the stage as the leading lady in Merry Hollow's annual Christmas play—a beloved local tradition that lets her dust off the spotlight she once knew so well. Decades ago, she played the sultry Raven Chandler on the hit



soap *The Edge of Desire*. Now she teaches elementary school, tends to her marriage, and saves her acting for the holidays.

But this year's production feels different. Her new co-star, Ethan Blake, is twenty years younger, dangerously charming, and very aware of who she used to be. Their chemistry is instant—and impossible to ignore. Every rehearsal runs a little hotter, every “stage kiss” lingers a little too long, until the line between acting and wanting begins to blur.

Her husband Daniel has always loved watching her shine, but seeing other men drawn to her stirs something unexpected—something thrilling, possessive, and just a little forbidden. And as the snow falls and the curtain rises, Claire finds herself at the center of a passion she never expected to feel again.

**Claire Unwrapped is a steamy, emotional holiday romance about marriage, trust, and the intoxicating power of being desired—on stage, and off.**

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## the new wife on milford court



When Jeremy Sampson lands his dream job, it seems like a golden opportunity for his family. His wife, April, reluctantly gives up a life she loves for the shiny promise of a new adventure.

The Sampsons' luxurious new house on Milford Court is a dream home, but as they settle in, April can't shake the feeling that something is off about their glamorous new neighbors.

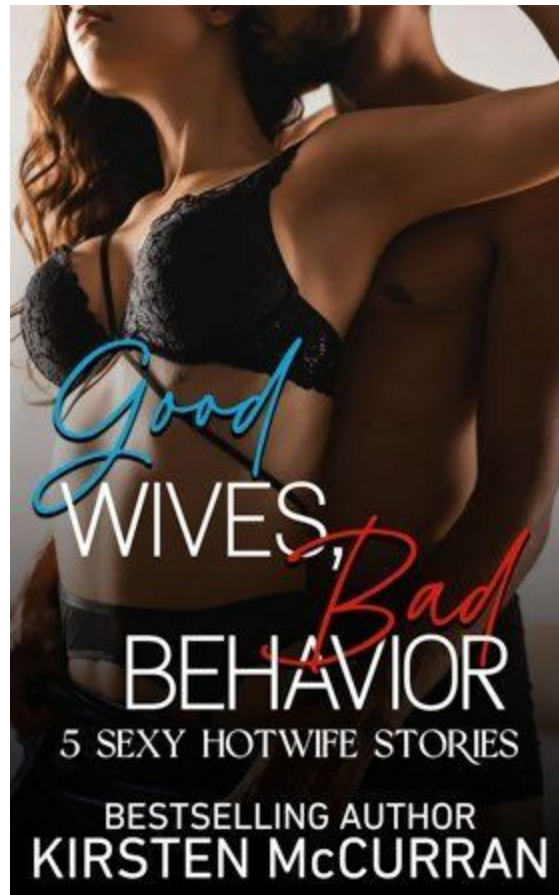
Sultry secrets lurk everywhere. April discovers the wives of Milford Court share a very special bond, one they're eager to share with her. As she delves deeper into the secrets of the gated community, April uncovers a world of forbidden temptations and dark desires.

Can April and Jeremy resist forbidden games played by the couples of Milford Court? Will Jeremy's dream job become a nightmare when he learns the real reason behind his good fortune? Get ready for a thrilling journey into the exclusive world of Milford Court, where nothing is as it seems.

**The New Wife on Milford Court is the latest adventure from bestselling author Kirsten McCurran, The Queen of Suburban Secrets!**

**[BUY THE SERIES NOW!](#)**

## good wives, bad behavior



From the mind of one of hotwife erotica's most loved writers comes this bestselling collection of 5 sultry stories featuring sexy suburban couples exploring their sexuality with their friends and neighbors. These very good wives behaving very badly could be the woman you see at the grocery store or the president of your local PTA. Kirsten McCurran specializes in pulling back the curtain on everyday couples' most forbidden desires.

**[ORDER NOW!](#)**



## picking forbidden fruit



Lauren Curry is a skilled massage therapist who finds joy in relieving her clients' pains. If anything, she's too giving, putting her clients first whenever she can. When a longtime family friend, Dylan, injures himself working for his father during college summer break, Lauren offers to treat him without hesitation.

Lauren is always the consummate professional, even when an attractive man is on her table—not that she sees Dylan as attractive. He's just a family

friend. She's known the young man for ages. But once she gets her hands on the college athlete's body, Lauren discovers just how sculpted it is. Lauren admires his physique with professional detachment until Dylan turns over, and she discovers that he's enjoying her treatment a little too much.

Can Lauren do the right thing and keep it professional? Or will a hot college baseball player help this suburban wife find her inner cougar? Dylan is a family friend. He's forbidden fruit. Can she resist picking it?

[ORDER NOW!](#)

## tara's homecoming



Tara usually passes on her husband's bro weekend with all his buddies at the Lockley University homecoming game, even though she knows all of them from their college days. She was a staple in their apartment when she started dating Mark. But it's their 20th year of tailgating, and she decides to see if the boys are as wild as they used to be.

The boys, Austin, Danny, and Shaun, were always like family to her, but Tara learns they see her very differently when their old drinking game,



Heads or Tails, gets going. It doesn't matter that they're in the middle of a parking lot filled with tailgaters. The challenges keep getting wilder and more daring. Next thing she knows, Tara is crossing lines she never imagined and experiencing things she didn't think possible for a 44-year-old married woman from the suburbs.

A weekend away can change everything. Tara and Mark will be tested like never before. Can their marriage ever be the same after all their limits are shattered? Tara's Homecoming is another pulse-pounding shared wife adventure from celebrated author Kirsten McCurran!

**[ORDER NOW!](#)**

## about the author

“Kirsten McCurran” is the pen name of a wife and husband team exploring the sexy secrets of middle-class, suburban couples. This couple has their own dirty little secret: they have lots of fantasies about what all their friends and neighbors are up to behind closed doors, and they turn those sexy fantasies into the stories they love to share with the world. The Mrs. could be the sweet mom you see in the stands at the soccer game or the pretty woman at the supermarket you wonder about as she's squeezing the melons. The Mr. could be your kid's little league coach.

Most of their stories are about married women looking to bust out and explore their wild side, often with the encouragement of their husbands—and sometimes without it. The strength of the couple behind Kirsten McCurran is that husband and wife writing together can uniquely capture the feelings of both partners in their couples as they explore their most forbidden desires. The Mrs. is all about exploring stories of daring women of a certain age exploring their sexuality, and the Mr. captures the feelings of the men who love them.

Kirsten McCurran has written over 60 books, which can be found at major booksellers. You can reach Ms. McCurran by email at [kmccurran@gmail.com](mailto:kmccurran@gmail.com).

If you'd like other ways to support Kirsten McCurran's writing, visit her website for links, [books.kirstenmccurran.com](http://books.kirstenmccurran.com).